
IsHaunted.com

The complete product documentation — every screen, rule and safeguard, written for the people who use it.

PRODUCT DOCUMENTATION

15 DOCUMENTS · 6 SECTIONS

24 AUGUST 2026

About this document

This is the in-product help, reproduced in full and unaltered — the same text the application serves to its users. It describes the software as built. It contains no business, market or financial information, and no usage figures.

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GETTING STARTED

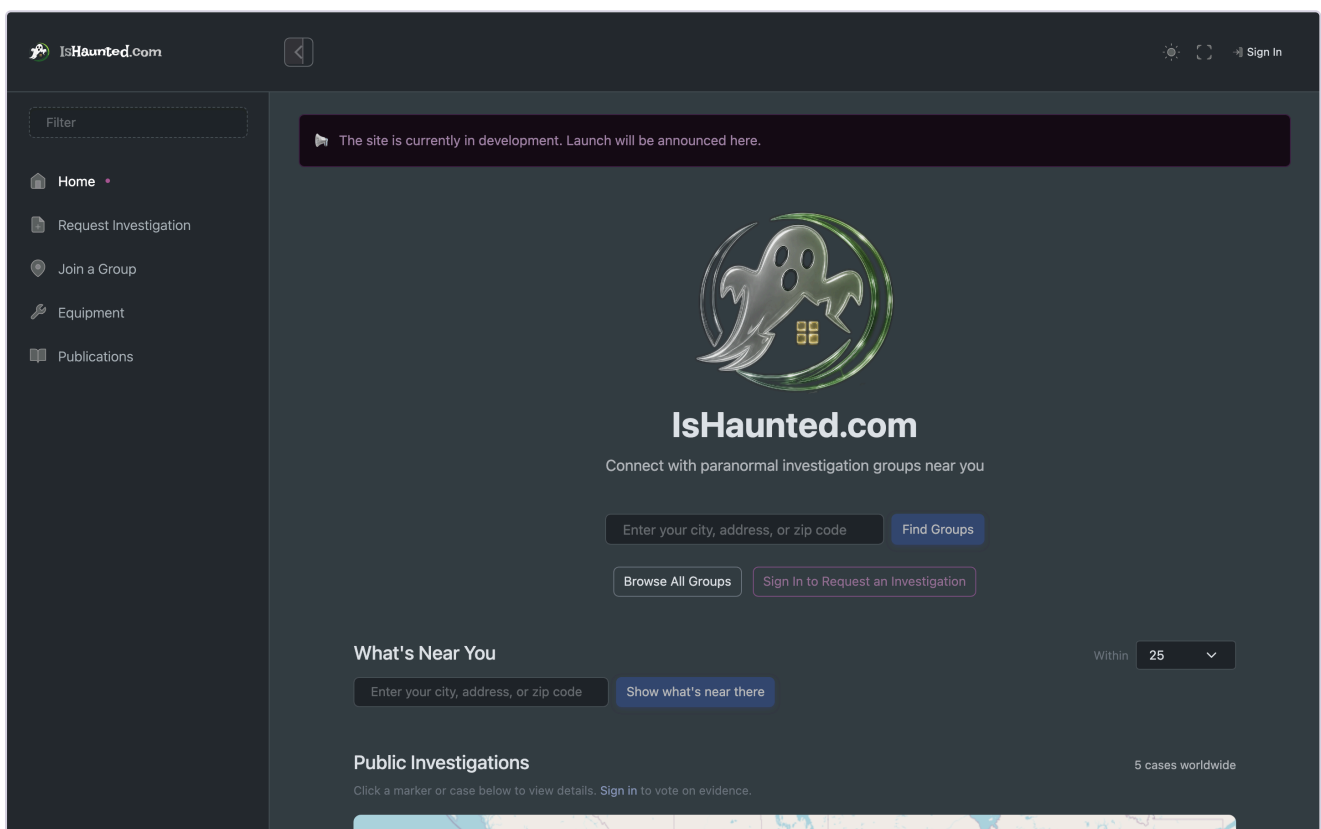
What IsHaunted.com Is

How the site works and who it is for.

Written for: **Public** — no account needed

IsHaunted.com connects people who have experienced something unexplained at a property with paranormal investigation groups who can look into it.

The short version



The home page: search for groups near you, and browse the cases groups have published.

A **client** describes what has been happening and asks one or more **groups** to take a look. A group that accepts opens a **case**. From there, the client and the investigators share a timeline of what happened and what was found, and the group schedules **investigations** — visits to the property.

Nothing about a case is public unless the group publishes it, and even then the client's name is replaced by whatever name they chose.

Who does what

YOU ARE	YOU CAN
A visitor	Browse groups and any cases that have been published.
A client	Ask groups to investigate, log what happens, and follow the case.
A group member	Work cases, record findings, attend investigations.
A group owner or administrator	Configure the group, manage members, accept or decline requests.

Voting on a published case

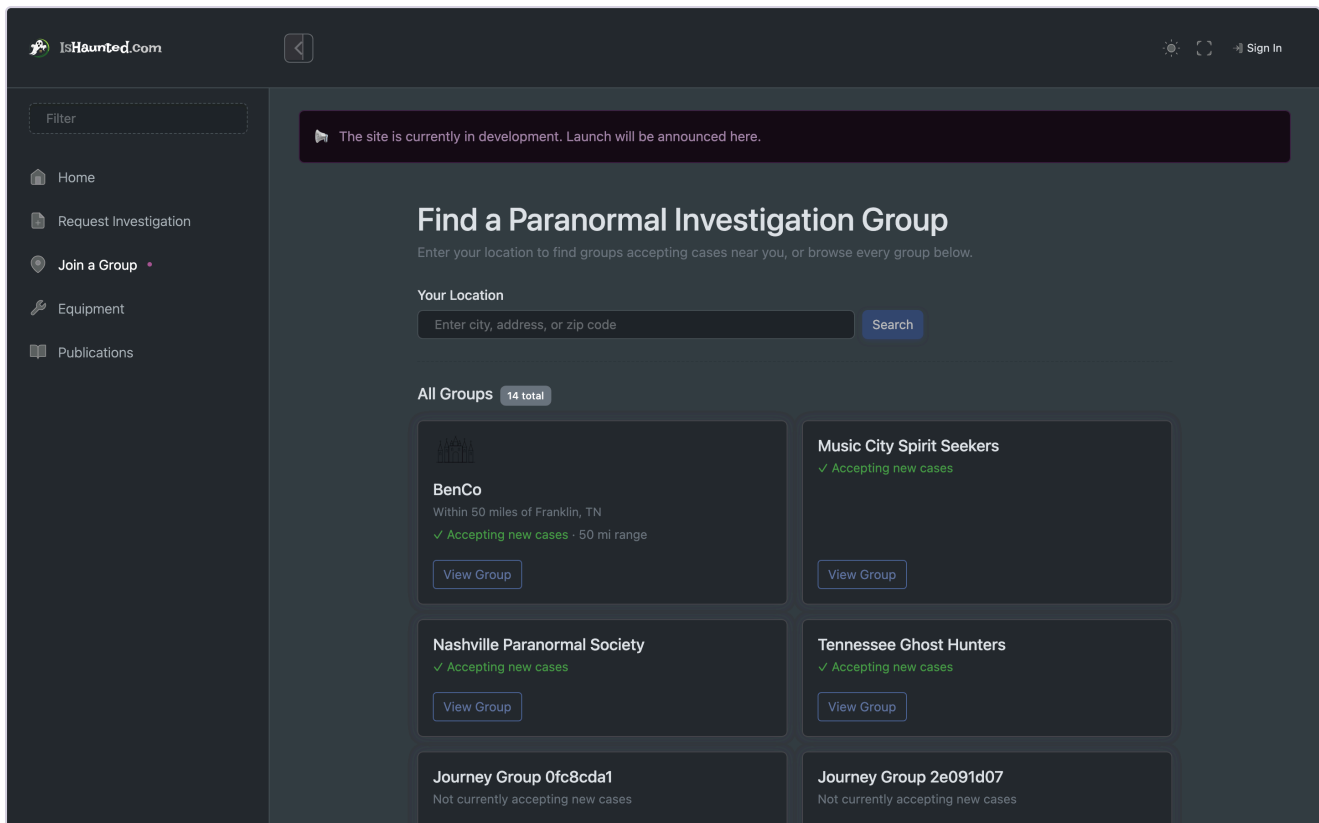
Anyone with an account can vote on a published case, and on individual pieces of evidence within it. There are three answers: **confirms**, **inconclusive**, and **disputes**. You get one vote, and changing your mind replaces it rather than adding a second.

Alongside the three counts you will see a single **score**. It is the votes added up, with confirms counting **+1**, disputes **-1**, and inconclusive **0** — so a green **+4** means the people who looked lean towards something being there, and a red **-3** means they lean the other way.

An inconclusive vote is not a wasted one. It counts towards how many people looked while moving the score nowhere, which is exactly what "I've seen it and I genuinely can't say" should do.

The score is always shown with the number of votes behind it, because **+4** from five people and **+4** from ninety are not the same claim. A score of **0** can mean the case is evenly split or that everyone was undecided — the counts beside it tell you which.

Finding what's near you



Browse Groups lists every group, closest first once you have given it a place to measure from.

The home page shows what's happening close to you — groups that serve your area, and public events you could attend. If your browser allows it, this uses your current location automatically; if not, type a city, address, or zip code instead. Either way, choose how far to look with the distance dropdown.

Groups and events are shown differently on purpose. A group that has opted in to being found is shown exactly where it is — that is the whole point of being listed. An event's location is only ever approximate, because it is an invitation rather than a business address, and the exact place is not shown until you are actually attending.

Finding your way around

Everything you can reach is in the **menu down the left**. It only ever lists what applies to you, so it grows once you sign in and grows again if you run a group.

Signed out it is a short list. Signed in, most of it is **grouped by subject**, so the menu stays about eight rows however much you can reach:

- **Your groups come first.** Directly below Home sits a link to each group you belong to, by name. Belong to more than five and they fold into one **Your Organizations** entry that opens into the list — the menu stays a menu, however many groups you join.
- **Notifications** and **Organizations** stay at the top level — you check those constantly, and they should not be behind anything.
- **My Work** — your cases, your investigations, your requests.

- **Equipment** — the public catalogue, your own gear, what you have out on loan, and gear questions.
- **Media** — uploaded files, the media library, your videos.
- **Community** — the feed, publications, finding a group, and requesting an investigation.
- **Administration**, for site administrators, holding the site-wide tools grouped by what they are for.

A few things worth knowing:

- **Filter** at the top of the menu narrows it as you type, and looks *inside* the groups. Type "checkouts" and you get the one entry, with its group opened for you.
- Entries with a **chevron** open into a group rather than going somewhere. Click the name to open or close it.
- A **number beside an entry** is work waiting for you. The colour deepens the longer it waits. A **closed group shows the total of everything inside it**, so nothing is ever hidden by being grouped — open it and each entry shows its own share.
- The **arrow beside the site name** collapses the menu to icons and back, if you would rather give the page the width.

Along the top right are the display controls: a **sun or moon** switches between light and dark, and the **arrows** expand the page to fill the screen. Both are remembered on this device.

Getting an account

You need an account to request an investigation or join a group. Accounts are free, and the address you sign in with is never shown publicly.

The screenshot shows the 'Create an account?' form on the IsHaunted.com website. The form is dark-themed and includes the following fields and labels:

- First name**: Input field with 'Sarah' entered.
- Last name**: Input field with 'Mitchell' entered.
- Display name**: Input field with 'Sarah Mitchell' entered.
- What people see on your posts and your profile. You can change this later.**: Text label.
- Your @name**: Input field with '@ sarahmitchell' entered.
- How people mention you — @yourname . Letters, numbers and underscores. This cannot be changed later.**: Text label.
- Email**: Input field.
- We'll send a link to confirm it. You can't sign in until you have.**: Text label.
- Password**: Input field.
- At least 8 characters, with an upper-case letter, a lower-case letter and a digit.**: Text label.
- Create account**: Button at the bottom of the form.

The sidebar on the left contains the following navigation links:

- Home
- Request Investigation
- Join a Group
- Equipment
- Publications

A top banner states: 'The site is currently in development. Launch will be announced here.'

The @name is checked as you type, so you find out it is taken before you fill in the rest.

Create one from the sign-in page — *New here? Create an account* — or go straight to `/signup`. You'll be asked for four things:

Your name	What people see on your posts and your profile. Change it whenever you like.
Your @name	How people mention you. Chosen once and permanent — see below.
Email	Where we send the confirmation link. Never shown publicly.
Password	At least 8 characters, with an upper-case letter, a lower-case letter and a digit.

Your @name

Your **@name** is your handle — `@sarahmitchell` — and it is how somebody writes to you or about you. Letters, numbers and underscores only, and it has to be one nobody else has taken; the page tells you as you type.

It cannot be changed afterwards. That is deliberate: your @name ends up written inside other people's posts, and letting it move would leave those posts pointing at somebody who is no longer you. Pick one you will still want in a year.

Confirming your email

You cannot sign in until you have. We send a link; open it and press the button on the page it takes you to.

The button matters — we do not confirm your address just because the link was opened. Mail scanners and security filters visit every link they find in a message, and a confirmation that happened on opening would be one they could complete for you, which would prove nothing about whether the address reaches a person.

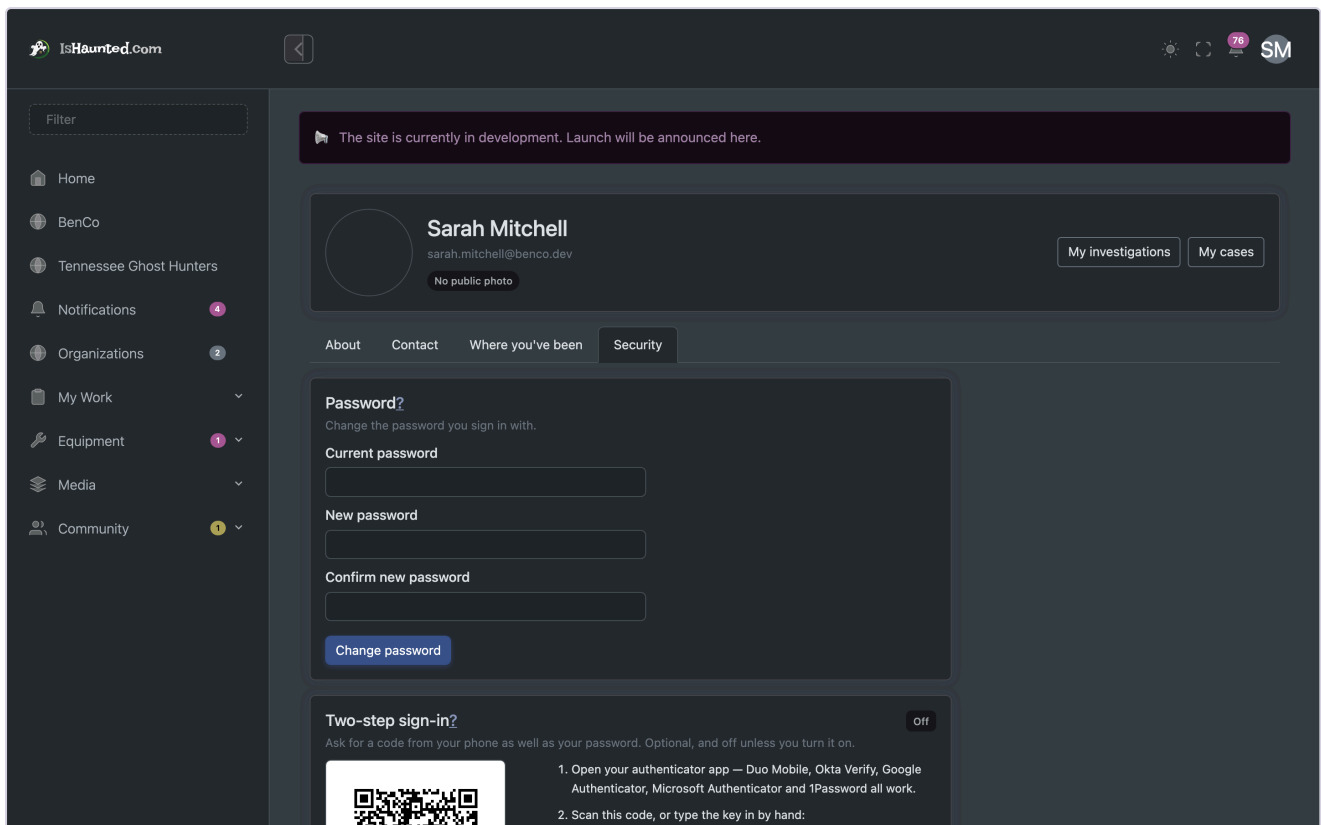
If the link has expired, sign up again.

Your first minute

Right after your first sign-in, a short welcome walks you through the basics: what people should call you, what brought you here (it drops you at the right door — requesting an investigation, finding a group, or starting one), and a ten-second tour of where everything lives. Every step is skippable, and skipping means it never asks again.

Two-step sign-in

You can ask us for a code from your phone as well as your password. It is **entirely optional** and off unless you turn it on, under **Security** on your profile. Nobody else can turn it on or off for you — not an administrator either, because only you have the app that makes the codes.



Scan the square with your app, or type the key beside it in by hand.

Any authenticator app works — **Duo Mobile**, **Okta Verify**, Google Authenticator, Microsoft Authenticator, 1Password. Scan the square code with the app, type the six digits it shows, and it is on. If you cannot scan, the key is printed beside the code to type in by hand.

Save the recovery codes. They are shown once, and once only — we keep a scrambled copy that cannot be read back, so nobody can recover them for you afterwards. Each one signs you in a single time if you lose your phone. Print them, or put them somewhere that is not the phone.

Turning it off again needs a current code from your app, which is what stops somebody at your unlocked computer removing it.

Signing in once it is on

Enter your email and password as usual. We then ask for the six-digit code — on a phone the keyboard offers it straight from the notification, so you rarely have to read it across.

If you have lost your phone, choose **I can't use my app** and enter one of your recovery codes instead. Each one works once.

When sign-in will not let you in

The message says which of these it is, because the answer is different every time:

WHAT IT SAYS	WHAT TO DO
Invalid email or password	Check both — or see the note below if you usually sign in with Microsoft.
Confirm your email address first	Open the link we emailed you when you signed up.
This account is locked for a few minutes	Too many attempts. Wait — resetting your password will not help, because it was not the problem.
Too many sign-in attempts	The same, but counted across the whole site rather than your account. Wait a minute.
Couldn't reach the sign-in service	Nothing is wrong with your password — it was never checked. The site could not reach the service behind it. Try again shortly.

If you are asked for a code, nothing has gone wrong at all — your password was right, and that is simply the second step.

Forgot your password — or never had one

Forgot your password? on the sign-in page emails you a link to choose a new one. The link brings you back to the site; if your mail app breaks the link, the email also carries a code you can paste in by hand.

The same flow covers a case that does not look like "forgot" at all: **an account created by signing in with Microsoft has no password**. Password sign-in against it says "invalid email or password", which is true but unhelpful — there is nothing to be wrong yet. Use the reset link to add a password, and both ways of signing in will work from then on.

Already signed in? **Profile** → **Security** → **Password** does the same job without the email round trip: it offers *Add password* if your account has none, and an ordinary change-password form if it does.

Empty, or broken?

A list that shows nothing is telling you one of two different things, and the page says which.

"**Nothing here yet**", or a sentence like "*This group hasn't shared any files yet*", is an answer. The list really is empty. Nothing is wrong, and there is nothing to retry.

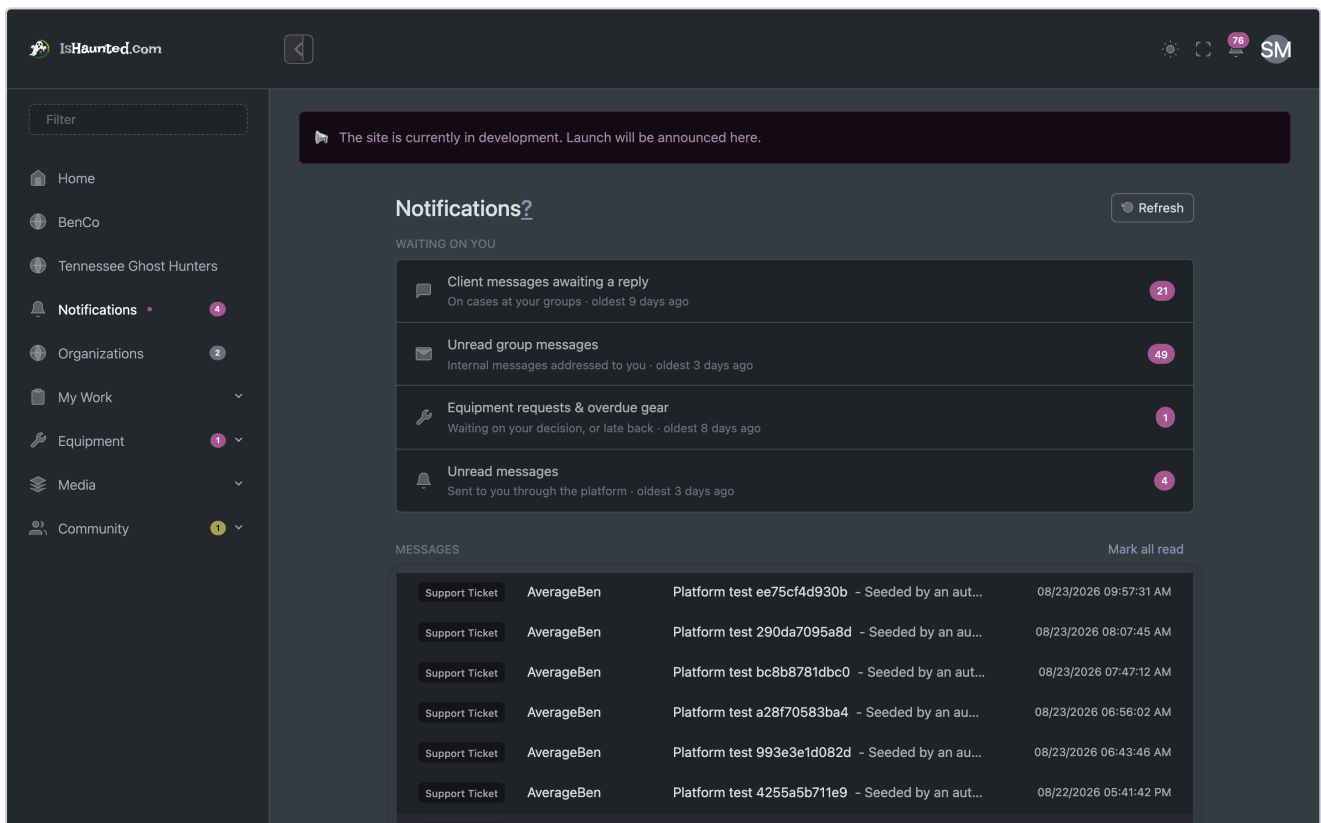
"**Couldn't load this**", in a bordered box with a **Try again** button, means the page could not fetch the list at all. What you were looking for is still there — the site could not reach it, or was not allowed to. Try again first. If it keeps happening, the box usually names the reason, and quoting that on the contact form saves a great deal of guessing.

The difference matters because these used to look identical: anything that failed to load simply showed an empty list, so the site would tell you your group had no members when it had four and had merely refused to say so.

Notifications

The **bell** in the top bar counts everything waiting on you, and the number is a total across several different kinds of thing. Open it, or the **Notifications** page, to see which.

Replies on your cases	A group has written back about a case of yours.
Client messages awaiting a reply	Somebody has written to a group you belong to.
Unread group messages	Internal mail at one of your groups.
File permission requests	Somebody wants access to a file you own, and is waiting on your answer.
Equipment requests & overdue gear	Waiting on your decision, or late back.
Posts that mention you	Somebody named you with an @name in the feed.
Unread messages	Sent to you through the platform.



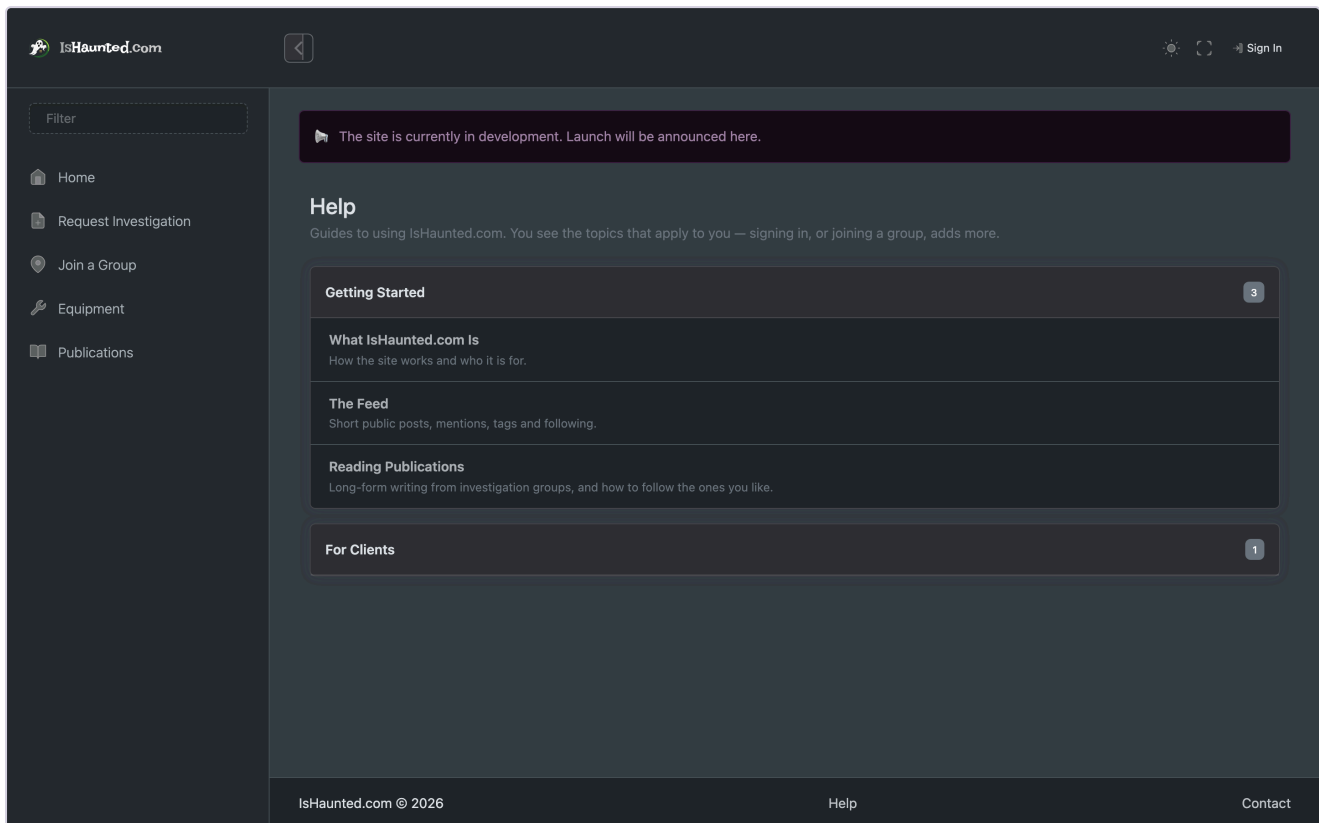
Everything waiting on you, grouped by what it is.

Buckets with nothing in them are not shown. The page is a list of things to do, not a dashboard of zeroes.

The colour means age, not importance. A single item from last week is coloured more urgently than five from this morning, because the old one is the one somebody is still waiting on.

Opening something is what clears it — a message you have read, a post you have opened, a request you have answered. Nothing disappears before you have seen it.

Finding help



The help index. You only see the topics that apply to your account.

Every page that does something non-obvious has a small ? beside it. That opens the relevant part of this documentation in a new tab, so you never lose what you were in the middle of.

Getting in touch

Contact, in the footer, reaches the people who run the site — not a group. Use it for anything about the site itself: an account you cannot get into, something that looks broken, a question this documentation does not answer. To ask a group to investigate something, send a request instead; that is a different thing entirely and goes to the group, not to us.

You do not need an account to write in. After you send the form you are given a **tracking link** — keep it. It is how you read the reply and see whether the message has been picked up, and it is the only way back to a message sent without an account. If you were signed in when you wrote, the message is attached to your account as well.

Joining a group — or starting your own

On a group's public page, signed in, there's an **Apply to join** box (when the group is taking applications). Say a line about yourself if you like, send it, and the group answers — you'll see the state of your application right there on their page.

Or found your own: **Organizations** → **Start a Group** walks you through it in four short steps — what you're starting and its name and web address, where you work (optional, it feeds the "near you" search),

whether you're taking applications, then a review. Only the first step is required, and closing the tab keeps a draft so you can pick up where you left off.

The first question is **what kind of group this is**, because it decides what everything else starts as:

Investigation group	Starts private : your address is hidden from the public and your calendar is members-only. Cases stay between you and your clients. This is what most groups are, and it's the default.
Ghost walking tour	Starts public : your meeting point is shown and searchable, and the tours you schedule are visible to everyone with no account needed. A tour nobody can find is worth nothing, so it doesn't start hidden.

Neither choice locks anything away — a tour company can take investigation requests, and an investigation group can run public tours. It's a starting point, and every part of it is changeable from your group's settings afterwards. If you run tours as well as investigations, turn on **runs public tours** in your settings and you'll be listed under walking tours in the group finder while your badge still says what you mainly are. You're the owner from the first moment, and your new group's page offers a quick tour of what to do next — relaunch it any time from the ? button on your group's page.

What you'll see as a new member

Once a group accepts you, its hub shows you the member baseline: the group's details, the member list, the calendar, messages, and files. **Cases and investigations are not part of the baseline** — those tabs appear when the group hands you a role that opens them (many groups use an "Investigator Role" for exactly this). Titles like *Probationary* or *Senior Investigator* are seniority labels and open nothing by themselves; if a tab you expect is missing, it's a role you're missing, not a bug — ask whoever runs your group.

Going to a group's public event

Public events are open to anyone — you'll find them on a group's page and under **Join a Group**. Say you're coming with your email address, click the link we send, and you're on the list (that also creates you an account, with no password to invent).

Afterwards, if you captured something, the event's page lets you **offer it to the group**. A member reviews every submission. If yours is accepted it becomes part of that event's public record, credited to you; if it's declined you're told why, and your file stays private. You can see where each of your submissions stands on the same page.

GETTING STARTED

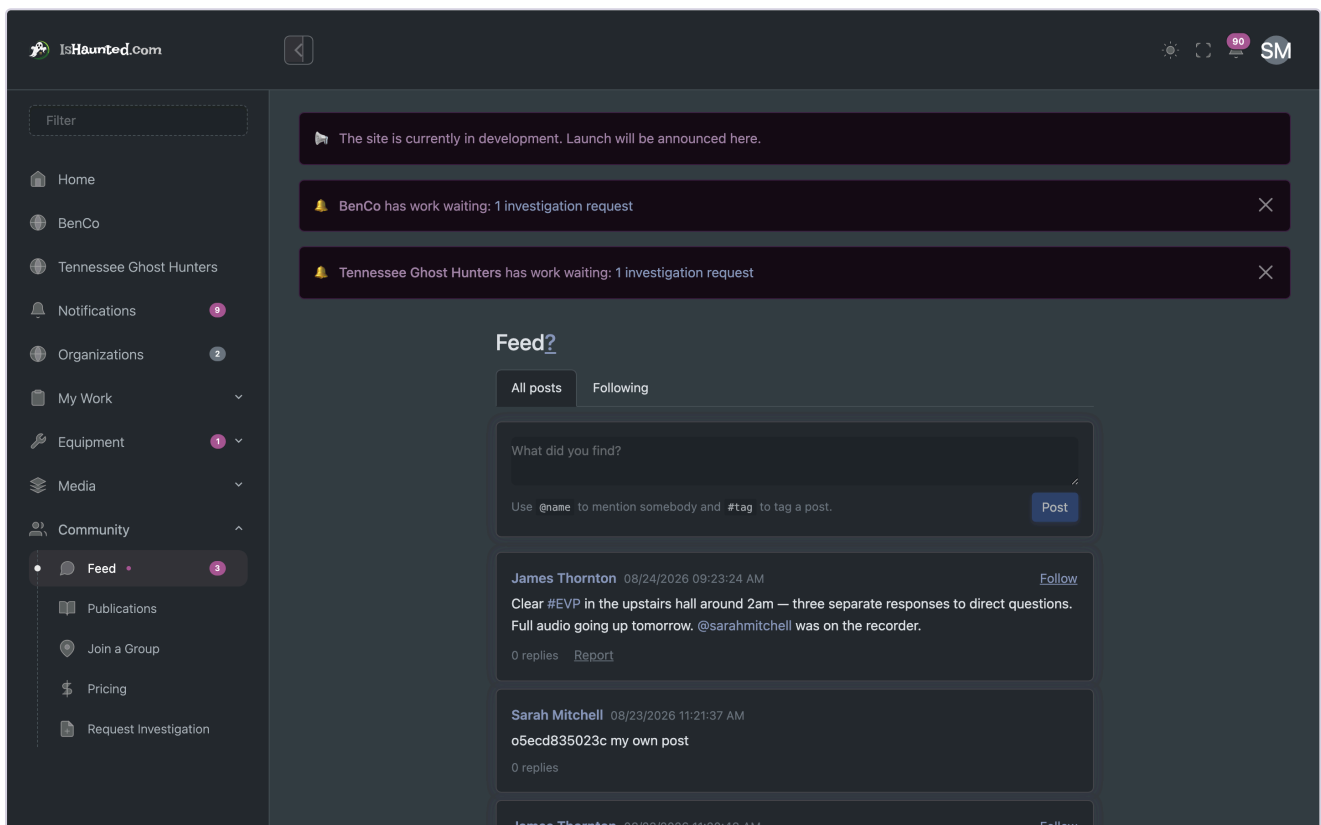
The Feed

Short public posts, mentions, tags and following.

Written for: **Public** — no account needed

The **Feed** is the short-form public side of the site: anyone signed in can post, and everyone signed in can read. It is where you say what you found last night, rather than write it up.

Long pieces do not belong here — a post is at most 1,000 characters on purpose.



A post.

#EVP and @sarahmitchell became links on their own — you only typed them.

Writing a post

Type in the box at the top of the feed and press **Post**. Plain text, no formatting: the point is that a post is quick to write and quick to read.

Mentioning somebody

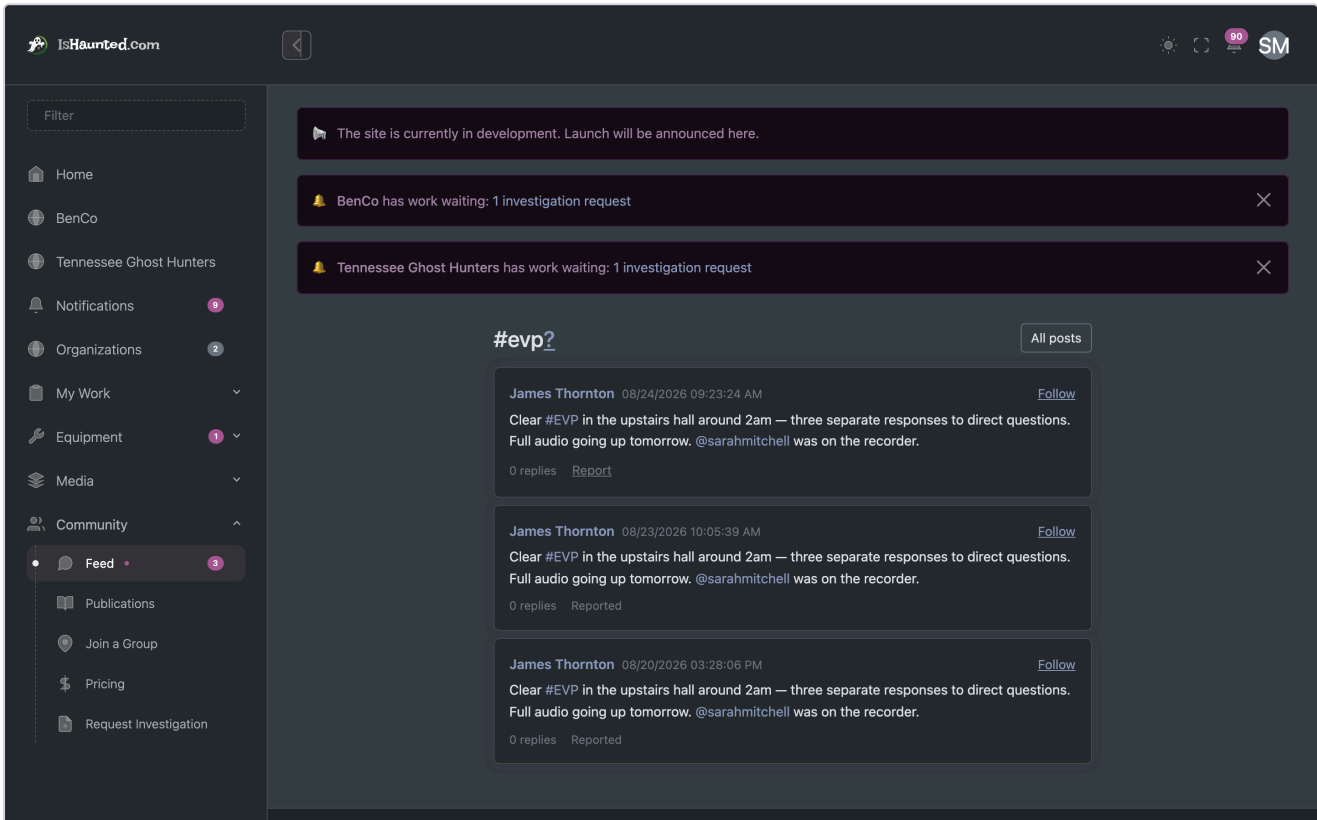
Write @ followed by their name — @sarahmitchell. If it matches somebody, their name becomes a link and they are told they were mentioned. If it matches nobody, it stays as ordinary text, which is how you can see a typo did not reach anyone.

An **@name** is the permanent one somebody chose when they made their account, not their display name. So a mention keeps pointing at the right person even after they change how their name is shown.

An email address in a post is not a mention. `ben@example.com` stays an email address.

Tagging a post

Write # followed by a word — `#evp` , `#bellwitch` . The tag becomes a link to everything else carrying it.



Clicking a tag opens everything carrying it. The address is shareable.

Capitals do not matter: `#EVP` , `#evp` and `#Evp` are one tag, so they all gather in the same place. Tags cannot start with a number, because `#1` and `#2026` are almost always a list or a year rather than a subject.

Saying what a post shows

When you attach a photo or video, the composer offers a **category** — the same list of experience types used everywhere else on the site (Apparition, Voices / Whispering, EMF Spike, and so on). It is always optional, and a plain chat post does not need one.

Picking one does two things: the category appears as a small label on your post that readers can click to see everything else of its kind, and it tells the site what your footage claims to be. If the site's own measurements disagree — a clip tagged as voices that carries no audio track, for instance — **you, and only you**, will see a gentle note on your post offering to change the category. Nothing is blocked and nobody else sees the note; an honest mislabel is not misconduct, and changing it is one click. Posts whose content clearly does not match their label rank a little lower in **For You** until it is sorted out.

Posting straight from the video editor

When you export a finished video in the editor, **Post to the feed** appears beside "Upload to server" and "Save to my machine" (if you're someone who may post at all). A render made from a case names that case before anything goes public, and footage from a **private engagement** requires an explicit confirmation — the client was promised privacy, and publishing any of it is a deliberate, recorded choice.

The group that worked the case decides separately whether the post carries **their** name: until they claim it, the post is credited to you alone. A claimed post wears the group's name, a link to their page, and a **Group verified** badge — the group vouching that the footage is what it says. **Moderator reviewed** appears when a site moderator personally cleared the video. Both badges lift a post's standing in **For You**.

Promoted cards

Every eighth spot in the main feed carries a card instead of a post — alternating between a group promoting itself (always marked **Promoted**) and the site's own pointer to the group finder. If you choose **Show groups near you** on a promoted card, your browser asks your permission and the cards re-order nearest-first. Your location is used for that one ordering and is never stored — leave, and it's forgotten.

Reading

All posts	Everything, newest first.
Following	Only people you follow — plus your own posts, so you can see what you just wrote.

Click a post's reply count to open it and read the replies. Opening a post is what clears a "mentioned you" badge from your **Feed** menu entry, so nothing disappears before you have seen it.

While the page is open it quietly checks for newer posts; a "**new posts**" button appears when there are some, and clicking it brings them in without losing your place. The site's home page also shows a small taste of the feed's current top posts — the front door on the front page.

Following

Press **Follow** beside somebody's name on a post, or on their feed page. It is one-directional and nobody is asked: following changes what you are shown, not what you are allowed to see. Everything in the feed is public to signed-in people either way.

Press it again to stop.

Reporting a post

If a post should not be here, press **Report** on it. An administrator sees it and decides.

Two things worth knowing:

- **Reporting does not hide anything**, and neither does a lot of people reporting the same post. A person makes that decision, so a group who dislike somebody cannot remove their posts between them.
- **You can report a post once**. Pressing it again changes nothing, and the button says *Reported* afterwards so you know it registered.

You cannot report your own post.

If the feed is not there

The whole feed can be switched off for the site by an administrator, in which case the menu entry and its pages are simply not there. That is a decision for whoever runs the site, not a fault.

Reading Publications

Long-form writing from investigation groups, and how to follow the ones you like.

Written for: **Public** — no account needed

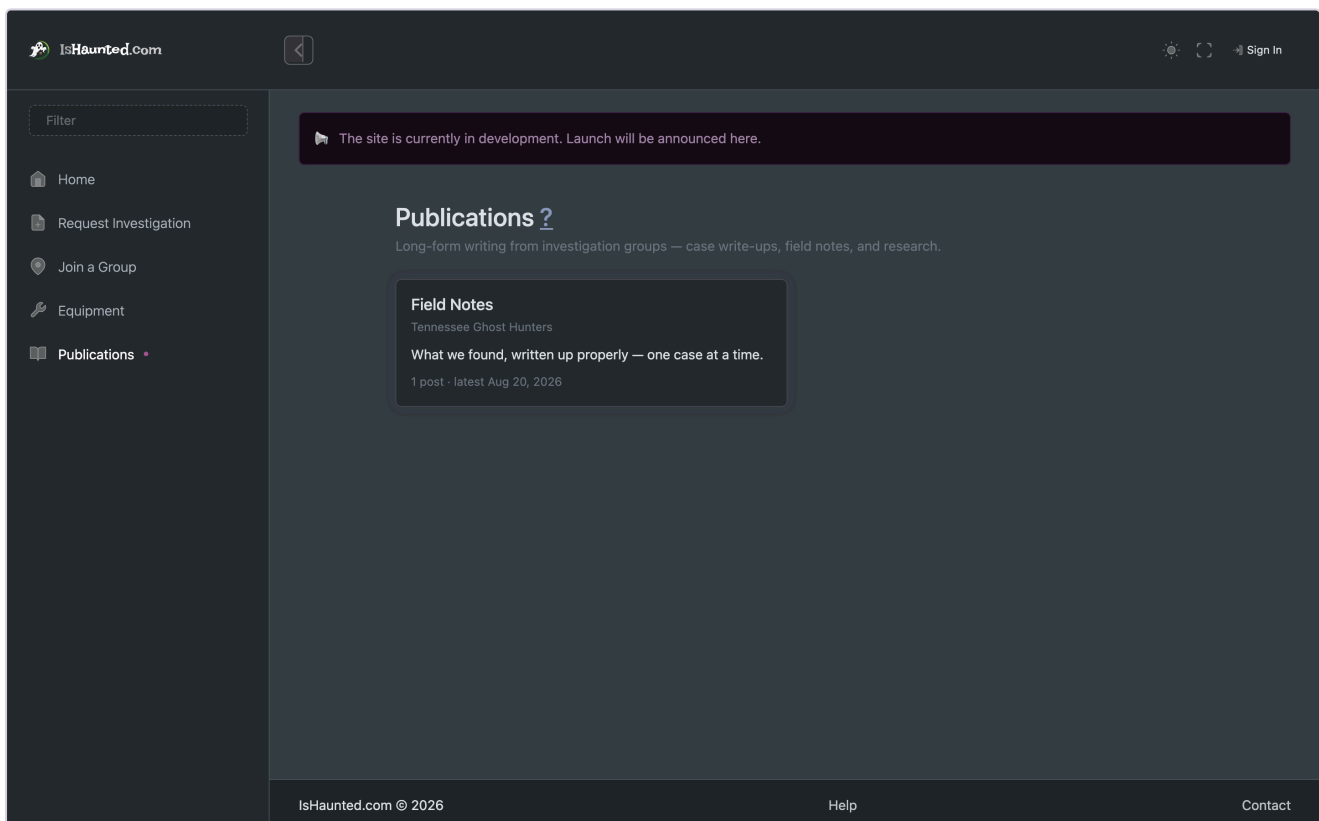
Publications are where groups write at length. A publication is a group's own title — *Field Notes*, *The Ridgeway Case*, whatever they call it — and inside it are posts: case write-ups, research, notes from a night that turned into something worth explaining properly.

If [the Feed](#) is what somebody says on the way home, a publication is what they write the following week.

You do not need an account

Everything published is readable by anyone. No sign-in, no email address, nothing to dismiss before you can read. Share a link to a post and the person you send it to can simply read it.

An account only matters if you want to **subscribe**, which is how you keep track of the groups whose writing you want to keep up with.

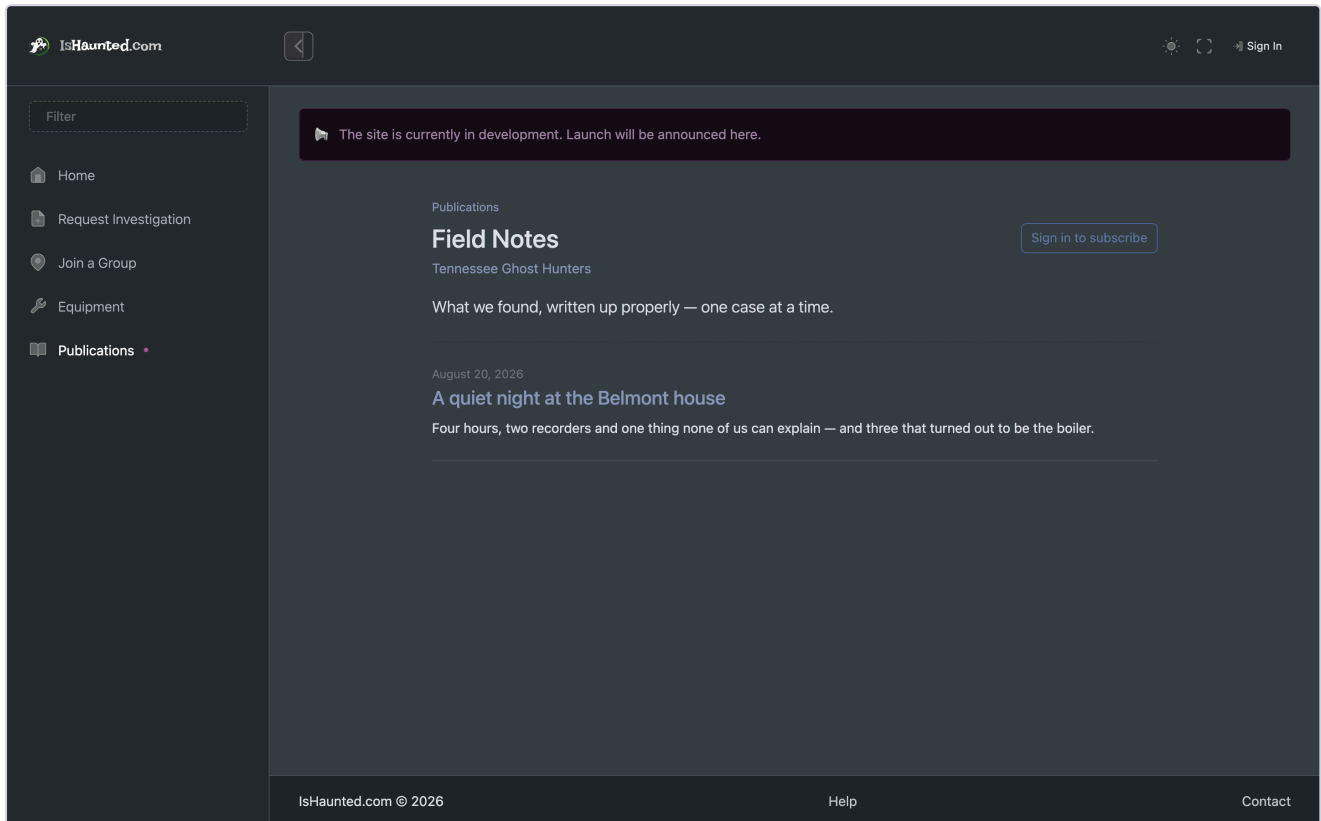


Every group with something published. The card shows how many posts there are and when the most recent one went up.

Finding something to read

Publications in the left-hand menu — under **Community** once you are signed in — lists every publication with at least one published post. Publications with nothing in them yet are not listed — a title that leads to an empty page is not worth the click.

Open one and you get its posts, newest first, each with a line or two about what it covers.



A publication's own page. The group's name links back to its profile, and

Subscribe is in the top right.

Subscribing

Subscribe on a publication's page tells the group you are reading. If you are not signed in the button says **Sign in to subscribe** instead, and brings you back to the same page afterwards.

Your subscriptions appear at the top of the **Publications** page, with the date of each one's most recent post, so you can see at a glance who has written something new.

Subscribed on a publication you already follow unsubscribes you. Nothing is lost by unsubscribing — you can subscribe again later, and everything published stays readable either way.

Posts marked "Subscribers"

Some posts may be marked **Subscribers**. You will see the title and the opening lines, and the rest is only for people who subscribe.

Today nothing on the site is actually marked this way — every post is free to read in full. The label exists because groups have asked about it, and it is better for you to have seen it explained here than to meet it for the first time on a post you wanted to read.

Reading a post

A post is a page: a title, the date it was published, and the piece itself. There is nothing to expand, no "continue reading", and no interruption partway through.

If a link you followed leads nowhere, the post has been withdrawn. Groups can take a post down — usually because something in it was wrong — and a withdrawn post stops being served straight away.

The iPhone and iPad Apps

What the apps do, how to get signed in, and what still lives on the website.

Written for: **Public** — no account needed

There are native apps for iPhone and iPad — one app that runs on both, laid out for each. It is the same account and the same data as the website: sign in on your phone and you are looking at the same groups, cases and investigations you see in a browser, because both are talking to the same place.

The apps are built for the half of this work that happens **away from a desk** — standing in a building at two in the morning with one hand free. Anything long or fiddly (writing a report, editing video, laying out a public page) stays better on the website, and always will.

What you need an account for — and what you don't

Reading the feed and browsing public events needs **no account at all**, exactly as on the website. Sign in when you want to join in.

Signing in works the same way it does in a browser, including two-step codes if you have them switched on. You can also **sign in with your Apple Account**: if you already have an account here under the same email address, that signs you into it rather than making a second one. If you don't, the app asks for the name people will see and your @name, and makes one — Apple has already confirmed the email address, so there is no confirmation link to wait for. Choosing "Hide My Email" works too; the address Apple gives us is a relay that reaches you. Your phone stays signed in afterwards; you will not be asked again every time you open the app.

Setting two-step **up** on the phone works a little differently from the website, for a good reason: on a phone the app is itself the second device, so there is no QR code to scan. Instead the app shows you the key to copy, and offers a link that hands it straight to your authenticator app. Your recovery codes are shown once, with a button to save or send them — the site cannot show them to you again.

What's in the app today

The feed	Scroll it signed out or signed in, open a post and its replies, tap a hashtag or category to see everything like it, and open somebody's profile. Photos and video play in the app.
Posting	Write a post, attach a photo or video from your library, or take one with the camera right there — which is the thing a phone is genuinely better at than a laptop. Add a category so people can find your footage. Like, reply, follow and report.
Notifications	Everything waiting on you, in the same buckets the website's bell uses. Colour follows the AGE of the oldest item rather than the count — fifty messages from this morning are a busy day, one from last week is the thing worth chasing. Rows open exactly what they count.
Your cases	Your cases and their timelines — what happened, what the group has written back, and photos attached to either. Log something that happened right from the case, with photos from your library or one you take there and then; say when it happened, or say that you don't know rather than guessing. Reports your group has published are there to read in full, and to share or save, and you can message your group about the case — what you send and what they send back, in one conversation. Who to contact is a tap away: their email opens Mail, their number dials.
Investigations	The ones you're on, split into what's coming and what's been, with your assigned role and any evidence deadline. Where you've been draws the places you've investigated on a map.
Events	Public events, readable without an account, and you can reserve a place. Add to calendar puts one straight into your own calendar.
Your account	Sign in and out, create an account, confirm your email, change your password, and turn two-step sign-in on or off.

Anything the app cannot do yet says so plainly rather than showing you an empty screen. A count with no screen behind it yet is still listed on Notifications — it just isn't tappable, rather than pretending to lead somewhere.

A note on what the app shows you

The app follows exactly the same rules as the website about who may see what. A private engagement is redacted the same way, media waits for the same safety check before it appears, and a group's name only appears on footage it has claimed. Nothing is looser on a phone because it is on a phone.

Getting the app

The apps are not on the App Store yet. When they are, this page will say so and link to them.

Requesting an Investigation

How to ask a group to look into what you have experienced.

Written for: **Public** — no account needed

Before you start

The screenshot shows the 'Request an Investigation' page on the IsHaunted.com website. The page has a dark theme. On the left is a sidebar menu with options: Home, Notifications (13), Organizations, My Work (with sub-items: My Cases, My Investigations, My Requests), Equipment, Media, Community (with sub-items: Feed, Publications, Join a Group, Pricing), and Request Investigation. A top navigation bar includes the site logo, a back arrow, and user icons (13 and DP). A purple banner at the top states: 'The site is currently in development. Launch will be announced here.' The main content area is titled 'Request an Investigation' with a subtitle: 'Tell us about the activity you've experienced. Your request will be reviewed by paranormal investigation organizations in your area.' Below this is a progress bar with four steps: 1 (Location), 2 (About You), 3 (Your Experiences), and 4 (Find Organizations). The 'Step 1 — Your Location' form includes a text input for 'Street Address' (filled with '123 Main St'), a text input for 'Apt / Unit (optional)' (filled with 'Apt 4B'), and three text inputs for 'City', 'State' (filled with 'TN'), and 'ZIP Code' (filled with '37201'). There is a 'Verify Address' button and a 'Next: About You' button.

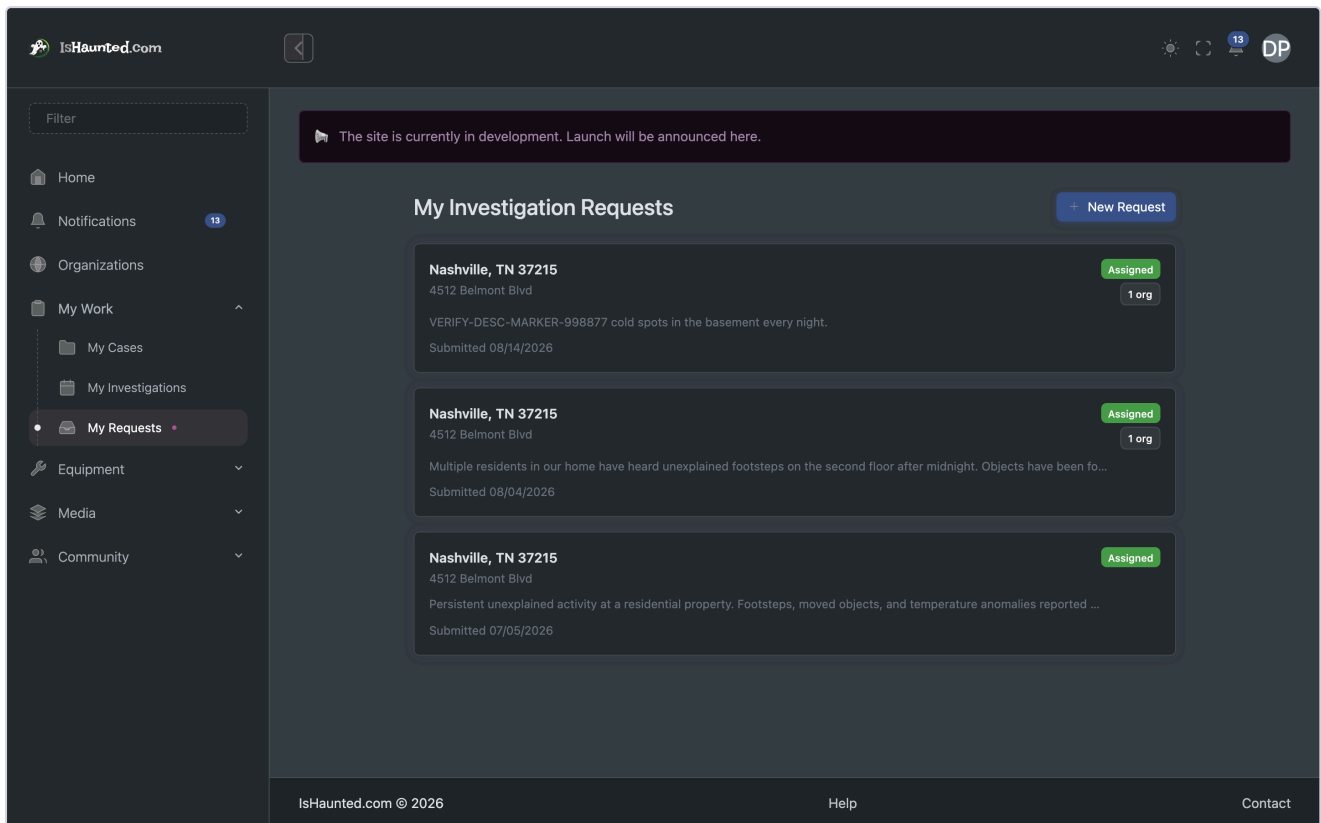
Describing what has been happening. Nothing is sent to a group until you choose one.

You will be asked to describe what has happened. Write it as plainly as you can, in the order it happened. Investigators find dates, times and who was present far more useful than adjectives — "three knocks on the north wall, about 2am, twice last week" is worth more than "terrifying activity".

Choosing a group

Request Investigation starts a request and is the quickest way in — at the top of the menu before you sign in, and under **Community** once you have. To look at who is out there first, **Join a Group** in the same place lists the groups working in your area. You can send the same request to more than one; each decides independently whether to take it on.

What happens next



My Requests tracks where each request stands with each group you sent it to.

1. The group reviews your request. They may mark it as under review while they discuss it.
2. If they accept, a **case** is opened and you get access to it under **My Cases**.
3. If they decline, you are told, and you can send the request to a different group without writing it again.

Your address

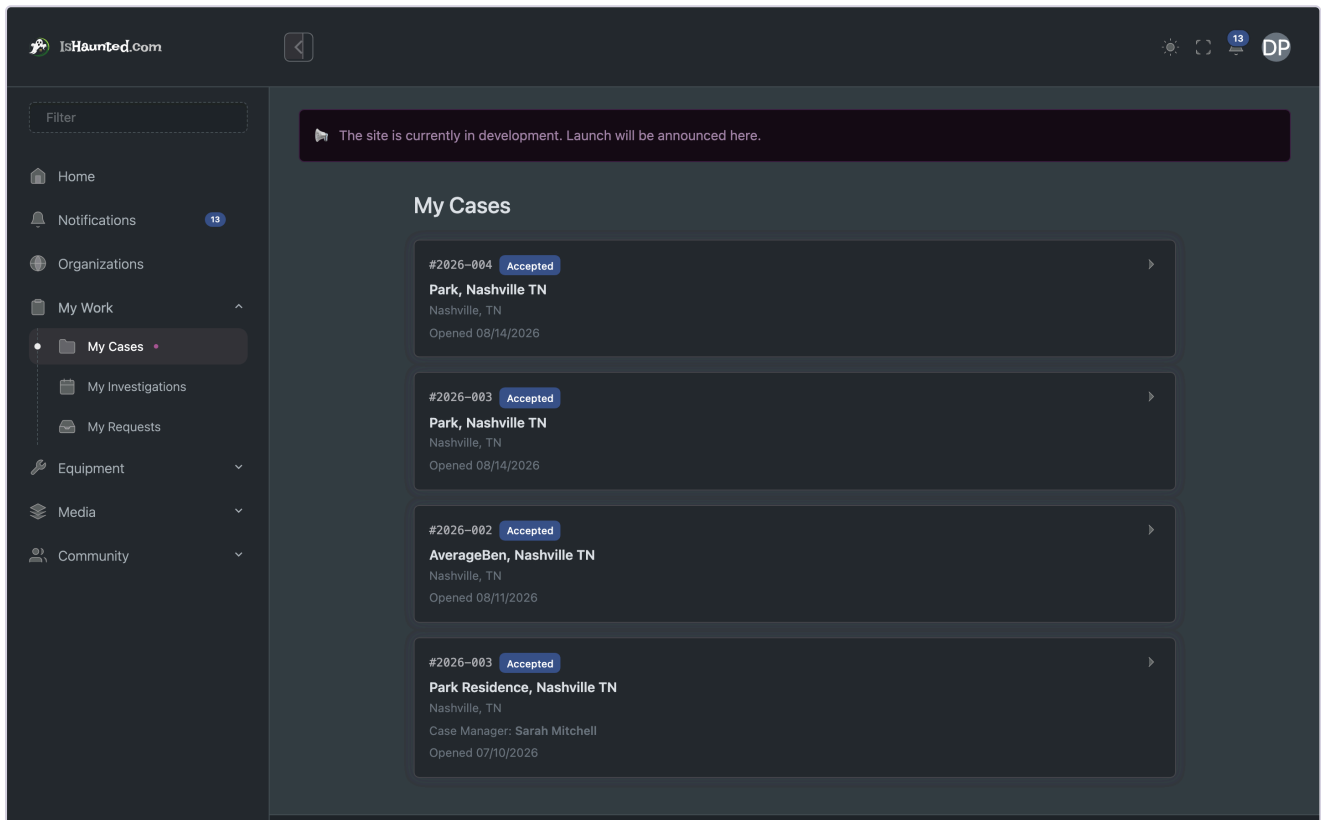
Groups need your address to reach you — that is the point of the request. It is never shown on public pages, and it is not shared with groups you did not ask.

Following Your Case

The case page, logging occurrences, and who can see what.

Written for: Signed-in users

The case page



My Cases lists the cases a group has opened for you.

My Cases lists every case you are part of, whether you opened it or were invited onto it by someone else. Opening one shows the calendar, everything logged so far, files, and your message thread with the investigators.

Logging an occurrence

Use **Log Occurrence** whenever something happens. Record it while it is fresh — the date and time matter more than polish. You can attach photos, audio, or video, and you can tag what kind of experience it was so investigators can group similar reports.

Several people can report the same moment. That is expected, not a problem: the timeline shows entries that share a time together and labels them, because two independent accounts of one event are more useful than one.

Who sees what

MARKED	SEEN BY
Internal	The investigators only.
Shared with you	The investigators and you.
Public	Anyone, if the case is ever published.

Your own reports are always visible to you and to the group working your case.

How you are named publicly

If a case is ever published, you choose the name shown — "A local family", "The homeowner", or anything you prefer. Set it on your case page under **How You're Named Publicly**.

Your investigators always see your real name. They cannot work a case while blind to who reported it, so the alias applies to public pages and shared documents only.

On a private case — yours is one, because it came from your request — the protection goes further than the name slot: if an investigator's written report or a timeline entry mentions you by name, the public copy substitutes your chosen name (or a neutral phrase like "the client") automatically. What they wrote is preserved for the investigation; what the public reads does not carry your name.

If your case is paused

A paused case means the organization's subscription ended — nothing more. **Nothing you reported or they collected has been lost**, and all of it stays readable to you. If the group renews, the case resumes exactly where it left off. If your case had a public page, it comes off the public site while the subscription is lapsed — your privacy does not depend on the group's billing.

You can also **move your case to a different organization**, right from the banner on the case page. Pick a group, and choose what they will be able to see:

- the **history** collected so far — reports, notes, evidence
- the **investigations** the previous group ran

If a month passes with the case still paused, the platform sends you a reminder that the move is available — you never have to wait on a group that is not coming back.

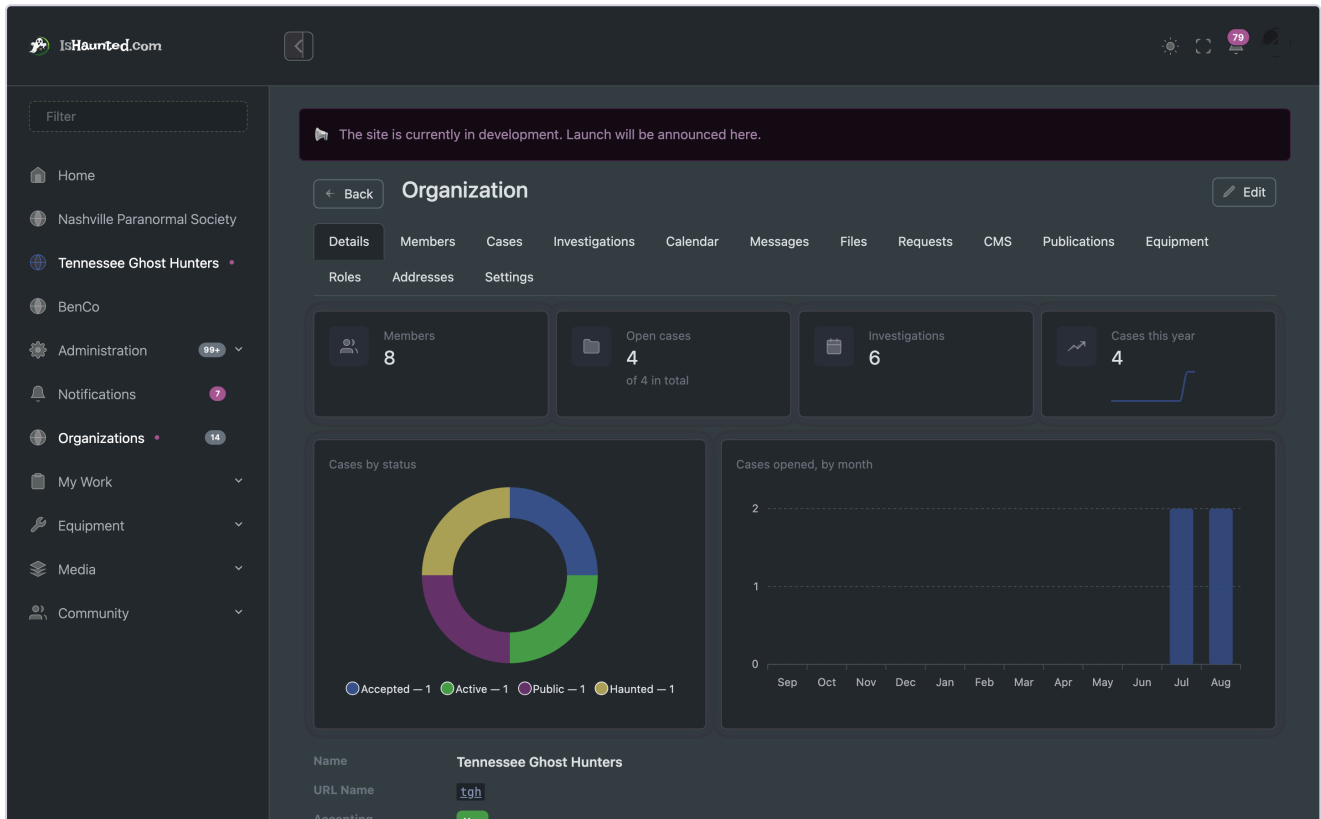
Anything you don't share stays with the original case — visible to you, never to the new group, and nothing is deleted either way. The findings belong to the original group *and* to you, which is why this is your choice alone; the original group is not asked. The new group answers your request, and you hear their answer either way. Until they do, you can withdraw the request.

Working a Case

The case page from the investigator's side — timeline, files, investigations.

Written for: **Group members**

Every case belongs to a group, and the group's own page is where its cases are listed.



Open a group from Organizations, then its Cases tab, to reach any case it is working.

The case tabs

The screenshot shows the IsHaunted.com web application. On the left is a dark sidebar with a search filter and a menu including Home, Nashville Paranormal Society, Tennessee Ghost Hunters (selected), BenCo, Administration (99+), Notifications (7), Organizations (14), My Work, Equipment, Media, and Community. The main content area has a dark header with a development notice. Below it, the case title "#2026-002 — Bell Witch Cave — Annual Survey?" is displayed with location and date. Action buttons for Public, Audio Mixer, and Edit Case are on the right. A horizontal tab bar contains Overview (selected), Timeline, Investigations, Files, Transfers, Messages, Reports, Research, Notes, and Video. The Overview tab shows a Case Summary and a Details panel with fields for Reference, Address, and Source. A Points of contact section is also visible.

IsHaunted.com © 2026 Help Contact

A case opens on Overview. Every other part of the case is a tab along the top.

This screenshot is identical to the one above, showing the 'Overview' tab. The caption indicates that the other tabs (Timeline, Investigations, Files, and Reports) would show the same case data from different perspectives.

IsHaunted.com © 2026 Help Contact

Timeline, Investigations, Files and Reports, each on the same case.

Overview carries the original request exactly as the client submitted it, shown separately from the case description so the two never blur together as the case is edited.

Timeline is the working record. Every entry has a visibility: internal to the group, shared with the client, or public. Choose deliberately — "internal" means not shared onward, not hidden from its author.

Investigations covers scheduled visits, attendees and RSVPs, and each visit's binder.

Binders

A binder is the case timeline filtered to one investigation. Entries recorded during a visit stay on the main case timeline as well — that is the point of reusing it rather than keeping a separate store. Filter the timeline by investigation to see just that visit.

Instrument readings

Readings recorded during a visit go in as **Instrument Reading** entries. Record the value, its unit, and what the ambient baseline was — a reading without its baseline cannot be judged later.

Entries at the same time

Two people often record the same moment, and unrelated things sometimes coincide. Entries sharing an event time are shown together and labelled "1 of 2 at this time". The ordering is stable, so you can refer to an entry by position and have it still be there tomorrow.

The investigations map

The group's **Investigations** tab shows every visit the group has run, on one map and in two lists: what is coming up, and what has already happened. Case-bound visits and ones with no client case sit together, because they are the same kind of work.

Visits at the same spot share a single marker with a count on it — the same place accumulating visits over the years is the normal case, not an oddity.

If something is missing from the map, look just beneath it. An investigation whose location could not be found on the map is listed there with the reason, rather than quietly leaving the map one pin short. Usually the address has a typo, and correcting it puts the pin back.

The **Edit** button appears only on visits you are allowed to change. That is decided per investigation rather than by rank: the person who scheduled it, the case manager, whoever is leading that particular visit, group owners and administrators, and anyone the group has specifically granted the investigations permission.

Scheduling a visit with no case

Schedule an investigation on the group's Investigations tab books a visit that belongs to no client case — a landmark, a public building, or the group's own outing. Everything else about it works the same way: it appears on the map, the team can check in, and the findings are shared under the same rules.

Because there is no case behind it, there is no case page either — so wherever you click one of these (your My Investigations list, your profile's map, the group's map), you land here, on the group's Investigations tab, with that visit highlighted and its team panel open.

Describe where it is, and the form will tell you if the system already knows the place:

This place may already be on file.

Use this place attaches the visit to the existing record, which is what puts your visit on the same page as everyone else's work at that location. If it is genuinely somewhere new — a different flat in the same building, a different cabin on the same site — carry on typing and a new place is created. The suggestion is only ever offered; nothing is merged behind your back.

A place is only suggested when the address matches **and** it is within about a tenth of a mile. Both have to agree, because an address alone cannot tell two flats apart and a map position alone would suggest the house next door.

Duties — who's doing what tonight

Every visit has jobs: somebody leads, somebody owns the equipment, somebody collects the evidence at the end. The roster's **Who's doing what** panel makes those explicit — each duty is a row, each holder a badge, and a duty nobody holds shows **Unfilled**, which is the gap to close before the night of.

Duties belong to one visit only. They are not titles (a junior investigator can lead a small visit) and they are not roles (holding Equipment tonight grants no standing permission). The one duty with teeth is **Lead Investigator**: the visit's lead can edit the investigation, exactly as before — handing that duty to someone is the same act as naming them lead.

Your group defines its own duty list under **Settings** → **Investigation duties**, and a duty can ask for a **minimum title** from the ladder. That ask is soft: assigning someone below it shows a warning with an **Assign anyway** button, because the senior calls in sick and the capable junior steps up. The exception is recorded, so it was a decision rather than an accident — the holder's badge carries a small △.

Who the client talks to

Every case answers "who do I talk to" with a name. On the case's **Details** column, **Points of contact** lists the members the client sees on their side of the case, and their messages are what land in those members' notifications. Choose contacts with the button there — the case manager and group admins can save the choice.

With no explicit contact chosen, the **case manager stands in** automatically, marked as such. Clearing everyone returns to that fallback; the client's view is never blank while the case has a manager.

Arriving on site

The investigation's **Team** panel shows who is expected and who has turned up. Open it from the attendees on a case's Investigations tab, or from **Team** on any row of the group's Investigations list — including visits

with no case, which is the only way to check in to one of those. A name turns green once their attendance is recorded, and the time beside it is when they say they got there.

Press **I've arrived** to check yourself in. The time is editable, and it is meant to be: most sites have no signal, so checking in the next morning and correcting the time to when you actually got there is the normal way to use it, not a workaround. Times in the future are refused — that is a typo rather than a memory.

Whoever manages the investigation can also record attendance for somebody who forgot. Those two are kept distinct: the panel marks a row **Recorded** when somebody else entered it, so "checked in on site" and "ticked off afterwards" never look like the same thing.

Attendance is what puts a visit on your own map under **My Investigations**.

Writing up what you saw

Everyone who was on the team files their own account, in the **What people saw** section of the investigation's Team panel. One each, in their own words.

They are deliberately separate accounts rather than one shared write-up. Four people in a building at night see four different nights, and the places where two accounts disagree are usually the most useful part of the record — a single summary, written by whoever holds the edit right, loses them.

Only you can write yours, and only you can withdraw it. There is no override, unlike arrival, where somebody else can record that you turned up. Whether you were there is something another person can vouch for; what you experienced is not, and an account with your name on it that you did not write would be worse than no account at all.

You can revise it afterwards — most people write up the next morning and correct it for days after. A revised account is marked as revised, so somebody comparing accounts knows whether they are reading what you said on the night or what you say now.

Everyone in the group can read all the accounts. That is the point of keeping them.

Tagging what kind of experience it was

Timeline entries can be tagged with experience types — knocking, cold spots, shadow figures — grouped under categories. Tagging is what makes patterns findable later, across cases and across groups, so it is worth a moment even when the write-up already says it.

If nothing in the list fits, group owners and administrators can **add a type inline**. It is usable immediately; nobody has to wait for approval to record tonight. Site administrators are told, and they confirm it or remove it afterwards.

Two things happen quietly to keep that list from filling up with near-misses:

- **We ask before creating a type spelled very like an existing one.** Pick the existing type if that is what you meant, or say yours is different and we add it as typed. It is a question, not a refusal.
- **A type you added disappears again if you untag the last entry using it,** as long as no site administrator has confirmed it yet. A word invented for one occurrence and then removed does not

outlive it. Confirmed types stay, and so do the ones we ship.

Leading a visit

The **Lead** column on the team list marks who is running this particular investigation. It is not a promotion: it applies to this visit only, and it lapses with it.

The lead can edit the investigation — the schedule, the team, the details — for as long as they hold it, and can hand it to somebody else. Only people who can already change the investigation can name a lead, so it cannot be taken, only given.

Who can see the findings

Each investigation carries its own sharing setting, on the investigation's edit form.

SETTING	WHO READS IT
Just this group	Only your own group. The default for anywhere somebody lives.
Groups who have also investigated this place	Any group with a visit recorded at the same place.
Anyone	Everybody, including visitors who are not signed in.

The middle one is worth reading twice: the audience is **whoever has investigated the place**, and that list keeps growing. A group that goes there next year will be able to read what you shared this year. The form says so when you pick it.

You do not have to share your own findings to read what others have shared. The point of the setting is that people comparing notes on the same building is useful, and requiring a contribution first would mostly deter the cautious.

Investigations at a **private residence cannot be made public**. Publishing what happened inside somebody's home is theirs to agree to, and there is no way to ask them yet, so the option is withheld rather than offered without the consent behind it.

Private engagements

Some cases are somebody's home. The platform calls those **private engagements**, and treats them differently on every public surface. A case becomes one in three ways:

- it came from a **client request** — a family asked for help, so the case is born private;
- an investigation on it is placed at a **private residence** — the moment the place is bound, the case is designated;
- someone ticks **Private engagement** in Edit Case.

The designation never comes off by itself. Clearing it is a deliberate choice in Edit Case, for the rare case that was marked private by mistake.

Write real names freely — the public copy substitutes

Inside your group, work the case in plain language: reports, timeline entries and notes can name the client and the household exactly as people speak. On a private engagement, the platform replaces those names **at the moment a public page renders** — the stored text is never touched, so nothing you wrote changes and nothing needs editing before publication.

Who becomes what:

- **The client** is replaced by the alias they chose themselves, or your group's pseudonym for the case, or — when neither is set — "the family" (if two or more people live at the property) or "the client".
- **Each person on the case's People list** is replaced by their **Public label** if you set one ("the lady of the house"), or a label read from their relationship ("a family member", "a neighbor", "the homeowner"), or simply "a resident" or "a witness".

The Public label field lives in the person's entry on the case. A short noun phrase works best — it is dropped into the middle of sentences.

What the substitution does not do

It replaces **the names on the case** — the client's, and the people you listed. It cannot know about a nickname nobody recorded, a name inside a photograph, or a voice on a recording. It also matches whole words only: "the Parkers" is not "Park", so a family nickname derived from the name survives unless you add the person. The pre-publication check still reads your case label and pseudonym and warns when either carries the client's name.

Private engagements and your plan

Taking on private-residence work — accepting a client request, placing an investigation at a residence, accepting a private case transferred in — and **publishing** a private case both require a plan that includes private-residence cases. The Pricing page says which plans do. Two things are never gated: work already in hand (a case your group already holds keeps working, whatever your plan), and a client moving their own case — their move is only ever limited by the destination group's plan, not yours.

If your subscription lapses

When a paid period ends without renewal, published private engagements come off the public site along with the pause of open work. Nothing is deleted: the case remembers it was public, and once the plan is renewed its page shows a one-click **Republish** banner. Public-place cases — landmarks, businesses — are untouched by billing and stay published. Both renewal warnings say all of this before it happens.

Applying privacy protections to an older case

If your group took a case on before you had the protections — or before your plan included them — **Apply privacy protections** in Edit Case brings that case up to date in one action. It:

- makes the case private, if it was not already;
- removes the exact coordinates of the property, leaving the address in your own records where your investigators still need it;

- cleans the location data out of every file on the case that has not been cleaned already, rebuilding each from the original, which was kept untouched for exactly this reason.

Then it tells you two things it did **not** do.

It does not rewrite anybody's words. If your client's name appears in a report, a timeline entry or the case label, it lists every place and leaves the text exactly as written. An account of a night belongs to the person who wrote it, and a find-and-replace through it can change what a sentence means or break a quotation. Edit the ones that should read as the pseudonym instead.

It cannot undo publication. If the case was public, the report says so plainly. Anything a visitor already read, a search engine already indexed, or somebody already saved is out, and making the case private now stops it going further rather than calling it back. That is worth knowing before you tell a client the problem is solved.

The case label when a case goes public

A case reaches the public through **Edit Case** — set the status and tick **Make Public** — and the pseudonym then stands in for the client's name everywhere the site writes it. Everywhere except one place: the **case label**, which is free text your group typed, often in the "surname, city" habit that is perfect for private files and wrong for a public page.

So the save checks. If the label about to go public contains the client's name or the street address, saving warns you once, names exactly what would leak, and suggests naming the place instead — "The Hargrove Farmhouse", not "Hargrove, Franklin TN". It is a warning, not a refusal: a surname is also sometimes a street or a town, and only you know which your label means. Save again and it publishes as written.

The same save reads the pseudonym itself. "The Park Family" as the pseudonym for the Parks is a disguise made of the thing it hides — if the pseudonym contains the client's real name, you will be told before it publishes.

Place pages

Clicking the location on the Investigations tab opens that **place** — every visit recorded there, by every group, that you are allowed to see.

The line at the top counts only what is visible to you. It never says how much is being withheld, because that would be its own way of telling you what you cannot see.

Your own group's visits are listed separately from what other groups have shared, and only your own rows show their sharing setting: how another group chose to share something is their business.

Place pages work for visitors too. Somebody who is not signed in sees only investigations that have been published, and nothing else.

Group messages

The **Messages** tab on your group is its internal mail. It is not the same thing as the message board on a case, which the client can read — nothing here is visible outside the group.

Messages arrive in folders down the left, with a count of what is unread in each:

FOLDER	WHAT IS IN IT
Inbox	Everything addressed to you, of any kind.
Sent	What you have written.
Broadcasts	Announcements to the whole group.
Direct	Messages to named people.
Case teams	Messages tied to a particular case.
Public	Messages anyone in the group can read.

Unread messages are shown in bold. Clicking one opens it below the list, and marks it read.

Writing one

Compose asks first who the message is for. Broadcast and Public go to the group as a whole and need no addressing. **Direct message** and **Case team** ask you to tick the people you mean, from the group's own member list — and you have to tick at least one, because a direct message with nobody on it goes nowhere.

The subject is optional. The body is not.

Mark as encrypted / **private** flags a message as sensitive. It is a marking on the message, for the people reading it — it is not a second password, and it does not hide the message from anyone who could otherwise open it.

Incoming cases

When another group — or a client moving their own paused case — asks your group to take a case over, it appears at the top of your **Cases** page as *Incoming cases*, with Accept and Decline right there. For a client-proposed move, the card says what you will be able to see of the previous group's work: the client decides whether their collected history and past investigations travel with the case, and that choice is theirs, not the previous group's. Accepting gives the case a fresh number in your group and makes it active again; the client is told either way.

Case transfers follow your plan. A group whose plan doesn't include case transfers can neither send a case to another group nor accept one in — both ends are checked, so a case also can't be handed *to* such a group. The refusal says exactly that when it applies, existing cases are never affected, and declining an incoming transfer is always allowed. A client moving their own paused case is never blocked by their current group's plan — only the destination's plan matters for their move. The Pricing page shows what each plan includes.

Evidence from people who attended a public event

Anyone who attended one of your public events can offer what they captured — audio, photos, video — from the event's own page. Nothing they send goes into your record automatically: submissions wait in **Evidence from your public events** on your group's Calendar tab until a member accepts or declines one. Declining asks for a reason, and the submitter is told either way.

Accepting puts the file into that event's **public** record, credited to the attendee — that is the bargain a public investigation makes, and submitters are told so before they send anything. Anything you decline stays private to the person who sent it.

Your Profile and Photos

Display name, contact details, public and private photos, and who can see them.

Written for: Signed-in users

Your profile

The screenshot shows the user profile page for Sarah Mitchell on IsHaunted.com. The page has a dark theme. On the left is a sidebar with navigation links: Home, BenCo, Tennessee Ghost Hunters, Notifications (4), Organizations (2), My Work, Equipment (1), Media, and Community (2). The main content area has a top banner stating 'The site is currently in development. Launch will be announced here.' Below this is the user's profile card for Sarah Mitchell, showing her email (sarah.mitchell@benco.dev) and a 'No public photo' placeholder. To the right of the profile card are buttons for 'My investigations' and 'My cases'. Below the profile card are four tabs: 'About' (selected), 'Contact', 'Where you've been', and 'Security'. The 'About' tab contains a 'Name' section with a text input field containing 'Sarah Mitchell', a 'Your real name' section with fields for 'First name' (Sarah) and 'Last name' (Mitchell), and a 'Sex' dropdown menu. A 'Save' button is at the bottom of the 'About' tab. To the right of the 'About' tab is a 'Private photo?' section with a 'None' placeholder, 'Choose File', and 'No file chosen' buttons. Below this is a checkbox labeled 'Show my private photo to clients of the groups I work with' with explanatory text.

Your profile. Everything here is yours to change, and most of it is private by default.

My Profile, in the menu under your avatar, is where you set your display name and photos. Your sign-in address is not changed here and is never shown publicly.

The page opens with your name and picture, then three tabs:

- **About** — your display name and both photos, with the consent switch for the private one.
- **Contact** — email addresses, phone numbers, postal addresses and web links.
- **Where you've been** — the map of investigations you have attended.

Most visits here are to change one thing, which is why the sections are behind tabs rather than stacked down one page. The map in particular only loads when you open its tab.

Sex

Under your name sits an optional **Sex** field — Male, Female, or Unspecified, and it starts blank. It exists for exactly one thing: when you have no photo, the site shows a placeholder icon, and this choice picks which of the three placeholders you get. It is never shown to anyone, never shared, and never guessed from your name; blank and Unspecified both mean the generic placeholder stands in.

Two photos

You can set two pictures, and they are treated very differently.

- **Public photo** — anyone can see it, including visitors to published case pages.
- **Private photo** — shown only to people you actually work with.

Who sees your private photo

THEY ARE	THEY SEE IT
You	Always.
Someone in a group with you	Yes — colleagues see each other properly.
A client of a case you are working	Only if your group allows it and you opted in.
Someone on the same case as you, as a client	Yes.
Anyone else	No — they see your public photo, or your initials.

The client rule needs both keys. Your group has to allow member photos to be shown to clients, **and** you have to switch it on for yourself. Either one alone shares nothing, and the profile page tells you when you have opted in but no group allows it yet.

Your contact information

Below the photos you can record as many email addresses, phone numbers, postal addresses and web links as you like. Each one is yours alone — nobody else can add to or edit your list, and an administrator changing their own copy of your record never touches these.

Mark one email and one phone as **Primary** if you want a single obvious "reach me here". Marking a new one primary clears the old one automatically: it is a slot, not a checkbox you can tick twice.

Addresses are looked up on a map as you type. If the lookup finds the place, the coordinates are stored with the address; if it does not, the address still saves — it simply has no pin.

What public means

Everything you add starts **private**. Private means only you and the people who administer the system can see it; it is never shown on a case page, in a group directory, or to anyone you work with.

Ticking **Public** on one entry publishes that entry, and nothing else. A public email address is the one thing that lets somebody invite you to a calendar event by typing your address — that lookup deliberately ignores your sign-in address, so an unpublished account cannot be found by guessing.

Confirming an email address

An email address cannot be made public until you have confirmed it. That stops anyone typing a stranger's address into their own profile and then receiving that stranger's invitations.

Press **Send confirmation link** next to the address. If the system is set up to send mail, the link arrives in that inbox. If it is not — which is normal on a test system — the page shows you the link instead so you can copy it.

Opening the link shows the address, partly hidden, and a **Confirm** button. You do not have to be signed in, and you can open it on any device. The address is only confirmed when you press the button, so a mail scanner that follows links cannot confirm it for you.

Links last seven days, and you can only ask for a new one once a minute. Asking for a new link retires the old one. If you later change the address text, the confirmation is cleared and the entry goes back to private — the new address has not been proven, only the old one had.

Your investigation map

Your profile's **Where you've been** tab keeps a map of the places you have actually been; the same map appears on **My Investigations**. Clicking a pin opens the case that visit belonged to.

It shows visits you **attended** — not ones you were invited to, and not ones you said yes to. A map of places you might have gone is not a record of where you have been, and only the second is worth keeping.

That means it fills up slowly, and starts empty. Attendance is recorded after the visit, so a scheduled investigation appears in your list straight away but on the map only once someone has confirmed you were there.

Security — your password and two-step sign-in

The profile's **Security** tab holds how you get into your account.

Password. Change it here whenever you like. If your account was created by signing in with Microsoft it has *no* password yet — the panel says so and offers **Add password** instead, which asks for no current password because being signed in already proves who you are. Adding one lets you sign in either way from then on; Microsoft sign-in keeps working.

Locked out entirely? **Forgot your password?** on the sign-in page emails you a link, and that same link is how a Microsoft-only account sets its first password.

Two-step sign-in. Optional, off unless you turn it on, and worth turning on. Scan the code with any authenticator app — Duo, Google Authenticator, Microsoft Authenticator, 1Password, Okta Verify all read

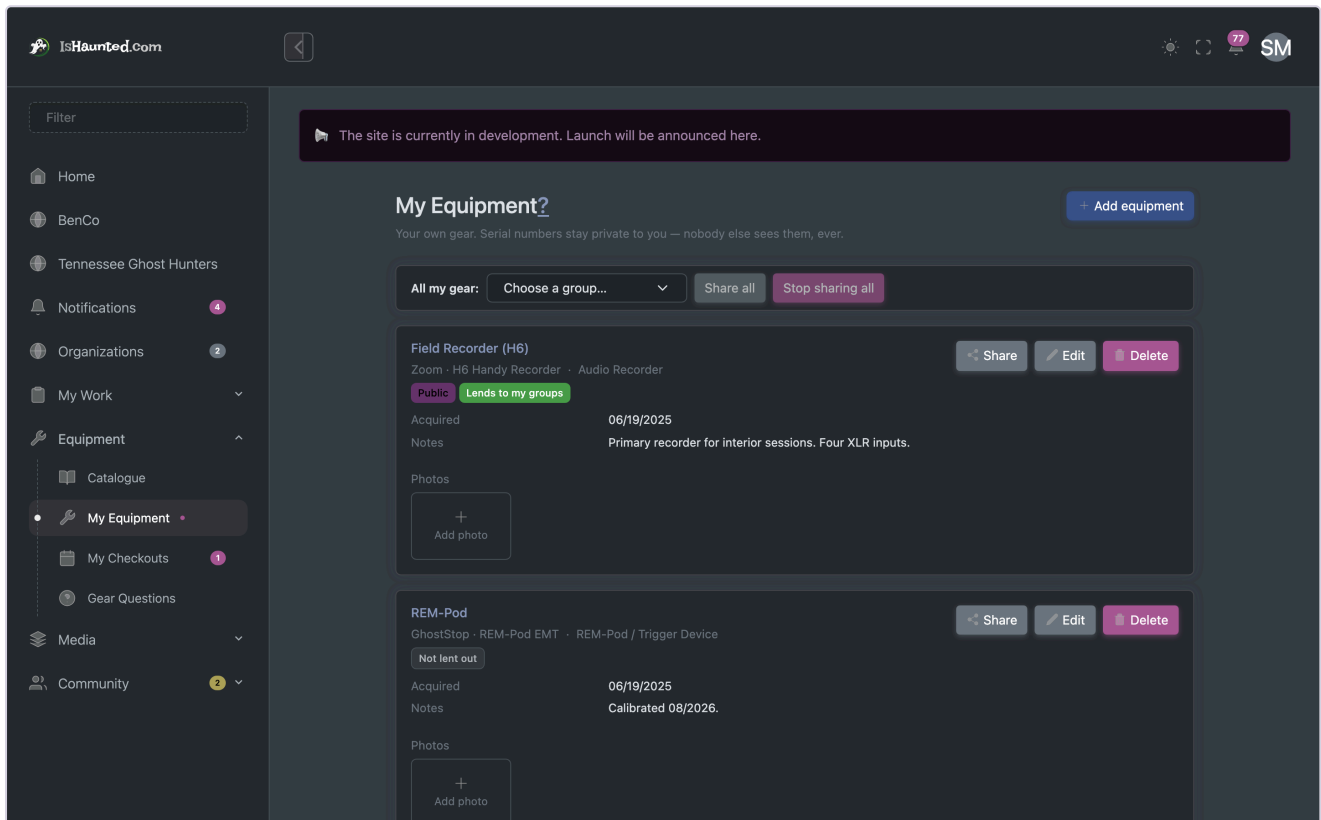
the same code — and keep the recovery codes somewhere safe: they are how you get in when your phone is not to hand, and each one works once.

Your Equipment

Logging the gear you own, adding photos, and what stays private.

Written for: Signed-in users

Your equipment list



My Equipment: everything you own, whether or not anyone else can see or borrow it.

My Equipment, in the main menu, is where you record the gear you own — recorders, cameras, meters, lights, anything you take on an investigation. Each piece gets a make and model from the shared catalog, a name you choose, and optionally a serial number, an acquisition date, notes and photos.

Everything starts private to you. Listing a piece publicly, sharing it with a group, and offering it for loan are all separate choices you make piece by piece.

Clicking a piece's name — anywhere it appears — opens its own page. That page shows each reader only what they are entitled to: you see its serial number and condition there, a member of a group you shared it with sees that it is yours and how to ask for it, and a passer-by from the public catalog sees the piece with no mention of you at all.

What stays private

Two things about a piece of equipment are **never** shown to anyone but you:

- **Who owns it, outside your groups.** The public catalog never links your name to a piece — one you chose to list appears without an owner. Inside a group you have shared with, your name does appear beside your gear: that is the point of sharing, so members know whose kit is whose.
- **The serial number.** This one stays private even later on, when you can share gear with a group and lend it out. Somebody borrowing your recorder does not need its serial number, and neither does the person approving the loan.

Site administrators can see equipment records, as they can everywhere else in the application.

Adding a piece of equipment

Choose a category first — that narrows the makes and models to sensible ones. Then pick the make, then the model, then give it a name you will recognise in a list, like "my backup recorder".

When you don't know the make or model

Not everything has a manufacturer and a product name, and you should never have to invent one.

- **No brand at all** — a homemade trigger device, an unbranded flashlight: choose the make **Generic / Unbranded**. Every category has a generic model waiting under it.
- **A known brand with no particular model** — an Eveready flashlight, say: choose the make normally, then use **I don't know the exact model**. That adds a single shared "generic" entry under that make, so everyone in the same position picks the same one instead of typing a dozen different guesses.

When we ask "did you mean...?"

If you add a make spelled very like one already in the catalog — **Sansung** when **Samsung** is there — we stop and ask before creating it. The catalog is shared by everybody, and one mistyped manufacturer sitting beside the real one looks exactly as genuine as the real one to whoever comes next.

You always have both answers:

- **Pick the suggested make** if that is what you meant, and it is chosen for you.
- **Say yours is different**, and we add it exactly as you typed it. Plenty of real makes are one letter apart — Ring and Ping are two different companies — so this is a question, never a refusal.

We only ask about makes an administrator has already confirmed, so you are never being pointed at somebody else's typo.

Linking to a make or model

Every make and model has a readable address — `/equipment/zoom/h1n` — so a link you paste into a message says what it points at. If you arrive by an older link, the address bar updates itself to the readable one.

Correcting a name corrects its address too, so a make fixed from "Sansung" to "Samsung" no longer answers to the mistake. That means a catalog link shared before a correction may stop working; the catalog is

shared vocabulary, and keeping the typo alive in the URL would be the worse trade.

Tidying up after yourself

A make or model you added is removed automatically when the last piece of equipment using it goes away, as long as no administrator has confirmed it yet. Type a make wrongly, delete the item, and the mistake leaves with it — you do not need to ask anyone to clear it up.

Confirmed makes and models stay, whether or not anyone currently owns one. Those describe what exists in the world, not just what happens to be in the database this week.

Who can see a piece, and who can borrow it

These are two separate choices, set per piece of equipment, and both start switched off. Letting people know you own something is not the same as offering to lend it.

Who can see it. By default only you. Two ways to widen that, and they are independent:

- **Share it with a group** — use the **Share** button on the piece and tick the groups that should see it. They see the make, model, photos and what you call it, alongside your name. They never see the serial number.
- **List it in the public catalog** — shows the piece under *Gear people own*, visible to anyone, signed in or not. Even then it never carries your name or its serial number.

Sharing with your groups

Sharing is per piece and per group, so you can put most of your kit in front of a group and keep one piece out of it. You can only share with groups you are actually a member of.

If you have a lot of gear, the **All my gear** row at the top of My Equipment shares or unshares everything with one group at once. It still writes the same per-piece choices underneath, so you can immediately go and untick the one piece you would rather keep back.

A share lasts as long as your membership. If you leave a group, your gear stops appearing to it straight away — the choice is remembered, so it applies again if you rejoin.

Who can borrow it. Three options, and you can pick any combination:

OPTION	WHO CAN ASK	RECORDED AS
Groups I've shared it with	A group you've shared the piece with can borrow it for the group's own use	Borrowed for that group, and optionally tied to an investigation
People in my groups	Someone you share a group with, borrowing as themselves	A personal loan
Anyone with an account	Any signed-in user	A personal loan

Leave all three unticked and the piece is never borrowable, however many people can see it. You approve or deny every request either way, and you set how long the loan runs — or leave the due date empty if you are not worried about getting it back by a particular day.

If you allow anyone to borrow a piece but do not list it publicly, the form will say so: people outside your groups have no way to find it, so the offer does nothing until you list it.

Retiring a piece

When you stop using something, **retire** it rather than deleting it. Retired gear disappears from borrowing and from the public catalog, but its loans and service history stay readable — and you can put it back in service whenever you like.

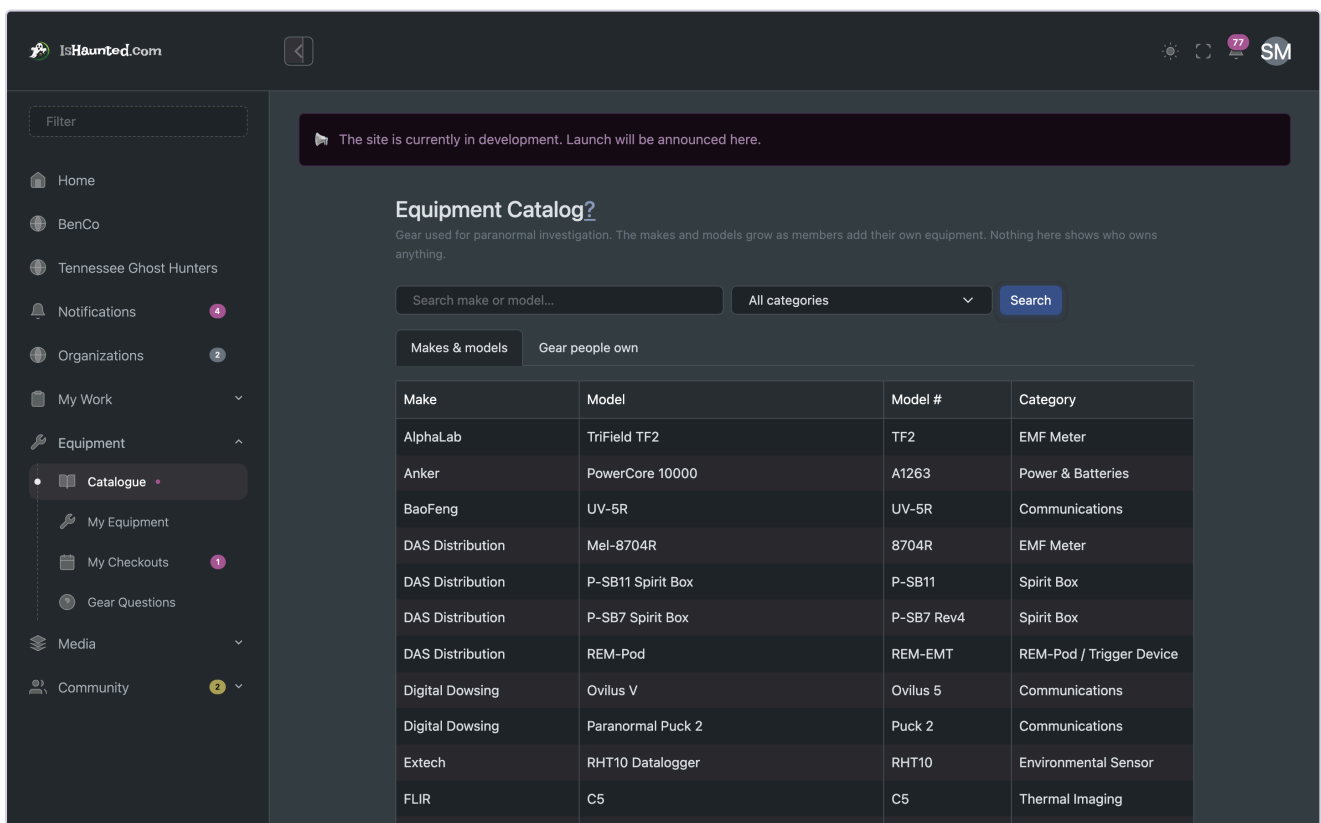
Once a piece has been lent or serviced, deleting becomes unavailable for exactly that reason: removing it would take the record of what happened to it, including loans other people were part of, along with it.

What we keep about your photos

A photo carries more than the picture: most phones record where and when it was taken, and which device took it. When you upload one, that information is separated out and stored against the record, and the copy anybody sees has none of it — so a photo of gear at your home does not carry your address with it.

Your original file is kept exactly as you sent it and never shown to anyone. The separated details are readable only by group Administrators and site administrators.

The public catalog



The screenshot shows the 'IsHaunted.com' website interface. A sidebar on the left contains navigation links: Home, BenCo, Tennessee Ghost Hunters, Notifications (4), Organizations (2), My Work, Equipment, Catalogue (selected), My Equipment, My Checkouts (1), Gear Questions, Media, and Community (2). The main content area features a dark header with the site name and a notification: 'The site is currently in development. Launch will be announced here.' Below this is the 'Equipment Catalog?' section, which includes a search bar and a dropdown menu for 'All categories'. A table titled 'Makes & models' displays a list of equipment items.

Make	Model	Model #	Category
AlphaLab	TriField TF2	TF2	EMF Meter
Anker	PowerCore 10000	A1263	Power & Batteries
BaoFeng	UV-5R	UV-5R	Communications
DAS Distribution	Mel-8704R	8704R	EMF Meter
DAS Distribution	P-SB11 Spirit Box	P-SB11	Spirit Box
DAS Distribution	P-SB7 Spirit Box	P-SB7 Rev4	Spirit Box
DAS Distribution	REM-Pod	REM-EMT	REM-Pod / Trigger Device
Digital Dowsing	Ovilus V	Ovilus 5	Communications
Digital Dowsing	Paranormal Puck 2	Puck 2	Communications
Extech	RHT10 Datalogger	RHT10	Environmental Sensor
FLIR	C5	C5	Thermal Imaging

The catalog lists makes and models, and — on its second tab — the gear people have chosen to list. It never names an owner.

The equipment catalogue — **Equipment** → **Catalogue** in the menu, or just **Equipment** if you are not signed in — is public: anyone can browse it, including visitors who are not signed in. It has two halves. *Makes & models* is reference data: what gear exists, by make and model. *Gear people own* lists individual pieces whose owners chose to list them. Neither half ever carries who owns anything or any serial number.

When you add a make or model that isn't listed yet, it goes into the catalog as a proposal. You can use it straight away on your own equipment. It appears in the public catalog once a site administrator approves it, which keeps the shared list from filling up with typos and duplicates.

Make and model pages

Every make and model has its own page, reached by clicking the make and model under any piece of gear. It gathers what everyone who owns one has contributed: how many are owned, how many are offered for borrowing, the manufacturer links people have added, and their photos.

Everything on that page is anonymous. It never says whose photo is whose, or who owns how many. Where you see a photo you can click, that is because you are allowed to open that particular piece — its owner listed it publicly, shared it with a group you are in, or it is your own. Everyone else sees the same photo with no link behind it.

The manufacturer's page

Each piece of equipment can carry a link to the maker's own page for it. It is optional, and the links everyone adds for the same make and model are gathered on that model's page — so one person's research into a recorder's specifications saves the next person the search.

Photos

Each item can have as many photos as you like. The first one you add becomes the main photo — the one shown first — and you can promote any other photo to main, or remove any of them.

Photos load when you open your equipment list, not as thumbnails in a long grid, so a list of many items stays quick.

Hide from the model page is set on each photo separately. A photo of the piece against a plain wall may be exactly what belongs on a make and model page, while the one taken in your living room is not — so the choice is per photo rather than all-or-nothing. Hiding a photo keeps it on the item itself; it only stops it appearing in the pooled set. Captions you write are shown publicly with the photo, so write them as something a stranger will read.

Questions and FAQs

Two related things, one public and one private.

Things worth knowing is the FAQ you write about your own piece — anything a borrower would want to know before asking for it. It appears on the item's page, and entries from publicly-listed items are also gathered on that make and model's page alongside other owners'. FAQ entries never say who wrote them, anywhere, including on your own item's page.

Questions are asked by someone thinking about borrowing. They arrive in **Gear Questions** in the main menu, where you can answer, or decline without answering, and afterwards publish a good answer into the FAQ.

The anonymity, exactly

A question is anonymous in **both** directions. You will not see who asked. They will not see who answered. The notice announcing a question says only that one arrived.

This is deliberate: a question is how someone finds out whether a thing has a quirk they need to know about, and people do not ask that of a person whose answer might decide whether they get lent the gear at all.

The anonymity covers questions and FAQs only. **Borrowing is not anonymous** — if that same person goes on to ask for the piece, you will each see who the other is, because you should know who is holding your recorder. A group's shared-gear list still names owners too.

Publishing an answer to the FAQ **copies** the text rather than exposing the conversation. You can rewrite it first — what reads well as a reply to one person rarely reads well as a public answer — and the original thread is left as it was said. An answer can be published once.

Feedback and moderation

After a loan comes back, both sides can leave feedback about the other. Neither ever sees what was written about them — not on any page, and there is no notification, because telling someone feedback about them exists is most of the way to showing it to them. What lenders write is shown to future lenders deciding that person's next request; what borrowers write is shown, unattributed, to other borrowers considering asking. The full rules are in [Borrowing Equipment](#).

A group's **Administrators and Owner** can open **Equipment feedback** from the group's page. It lists everything left about the group's gear and its members' loans, naming both sides, and anything that crosses a line can be removed. That page exists so a complaint can be acted on — it is the one place in the app where feedback is attributed on both ends.

Who is looking

Each piece counts how many times its page has been opened and how many times someone followed its manufacturer link. Those numbers are shown to the Administrators and Owner of the group that owns the equipment, and to site administrators. Nobody else sees them — not other members, and not the individual owner of a personal piece.

The counts are totals only. Nothing is recorded about who did the looking.

Borrowing Equipment

Asking to borrow gear, handing it over, and getting it back.

Written for: Signed-in users

Equipment can be borrowed from two places: gear a group owns, and gear a member owns personally and has offered to lend. The steps are the same either way. What differs is who decides.

Who decides

WHOSE GEAR	WHO APPROVES
The group's own	Anyone with the group's Equipment Checkouts permission
A member's own	That member, always

Nobody's group permission lets them lend out somebody else's personal equipment. If it is yours, the decision is yours.

Asking to borrow

Find the piece and choose **Ask to borrow**. Gear turns up in two places: your group's **Equipment** tab, and the public equipment catalogue — **Equipment** → **Catalogue** in the menu — under *Gear people own*.

If the owner lends the piece to more than one group you are in, you will be asked **who you are borrowing it for**. That choice matters: a loan taken out for a group is recorded against that group, and can be tied to a particular visit. A loan you take out personally is just yours.

If the owner only lends the piece personally, there is nothing to choose and no group is recorded.

You can add when you need it and a note about why. Neither is required, but a note is the difference between a request somebody can say yes to and one they have to ask about first.

You can only have one open request per piece at a time. Asking twice is a duplicate, not a nudge.

Asking a question first

Every piece has its own page, reached by clicking its name. On it you will find **Things worth knowing** — an FAQ the owner has written — and an **Ask a question** button if there is something they have not covered.

Questions are **anonymous in both directions**. Whoever looks after the piece sees your question but not your name, and their answer comes back without theirs. Ask whatever you actually need to know: this exists precisely so that finding out about a temperamental battery door does not cost you the loan.

Anonymity stops at the question. If you go on to **ask to borrow**, that request carries your name, as it must — you are asking someone to hand you their equipment.

Your questions and their answers are in **Gear Questions** in the main menu.

Being turned down

Whoever declines has to give a reason, and you will see it. A bare "no" tells you nothing about whether to ask again next week.

A declined request is final — the row stays as a record of what was asked. If circumstances change, send a fresh request.

Handing over and getting back

Each side confirms the transfer coming toward them.

- **You confirm you have it.** Once your request is approved, the loan is not "out" until you press **I've got it**. The person with the equipment is the one who can truthfully say they have it.
- **The lender confirms it came back.** When you return it, they press **Got it back**, optionally noting the condition. This is deliberately not yours to do: a loan should not be closable by asserting you returned something.

Until you confirm the hand-off you can still **cancel** — plans change, and an approved request you never collected should not have to become a loan.

Due dates and overdue

Whoever approves can set a date it is due back, or leave it open if they are not worried.

A loan is **overdue** once it is out and past that date. That is worked out fresh every time anyone looks, so it is never stale, and it shows as a red badge on **My Checkouts** and a count on your notification bell.

Photos of its condition

Either side can attach photos to a loan — as the gear goes out, and as it comes back. They sit side by side on the loan's **Details** view, which is the whole point: "was that scratch already there?" is much easier to answer with the two pictures next to each other than from memory.

A hand-off photo can only be added once the loan is approved and before it is over, and a return photo only once the gear is actually out or just back. Photographing a hand-off that never happened would be recording a fact about nothing.

Condition photos are private to the two sides of that loan. They never appear in the public catalog.

Asking for more time

If you need a piece for longer, open the loan's **Details** and ask to keep it until a later date. You can only ask while you actually have the gear, and only one request can be waiting at a time.

Whoever lent it can grant or refuse. Granting moves the due date; refusing leaves the original date standing and needs a reason. Either way you get a notification, and the request and its answer stay on the loan — so "asked for another week, was given three days" is still readable later, rather than just a due date that quietly changed.

Feedback after a loan

Once a piece is back, both sides can leave feedback on the loan's page. It is optional, and you can leave a comment, a rating out of five, or both.

Neither side ever sees what was written about them. There is no notification either, because telling someone that feedback about them exists is most of the way to showing it to them. What each half is for:

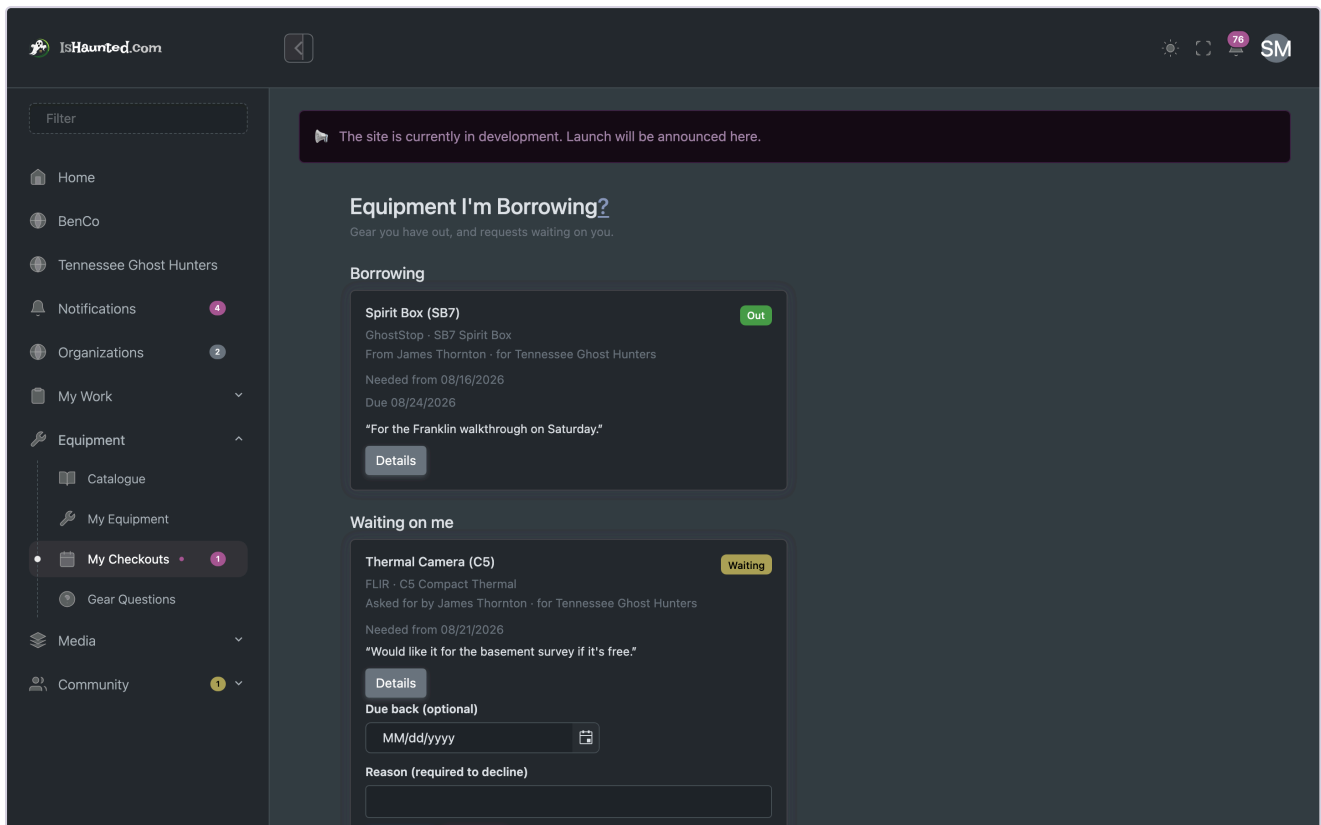
- **What a lender writes about a borrower** is shown to *future lenders* weighing that person's next request — so somebody deciding whether to hand over an expensive recorder can see that the last few lenders got it back on time and in one piece. It carries the lender's name, because an unattributed warning is hard to weigh.
- **What a borrower writes about a lender** is shown to *other borrowers* thinking of asking them, **without your name**. The protection goes where there is more to lose.

Borrowers can also review **the equipment itself**, separately. That one is public: it appears on the make and model's catalog page, still without your name, and helps somebody deciding whether the thing is worth buying or borrowing at all.

Averages are never shown from fewer than three ratings, and always appear with their count beside them — one sour rating is one voice, not a verdict.

A group's Administrators and Owner can see everything left about their group's gear and loans, and remove anything that crosses a line.

My Checkouts



Both directions in one place: what you have out, and what someone has asked you for.

My Checkouts answers three questions in one place:

- **Borrowing** — what you have out, and what you have asked for
- **Waiting on me** — requests for your gear needing a decision, and your gear currently out with somebody

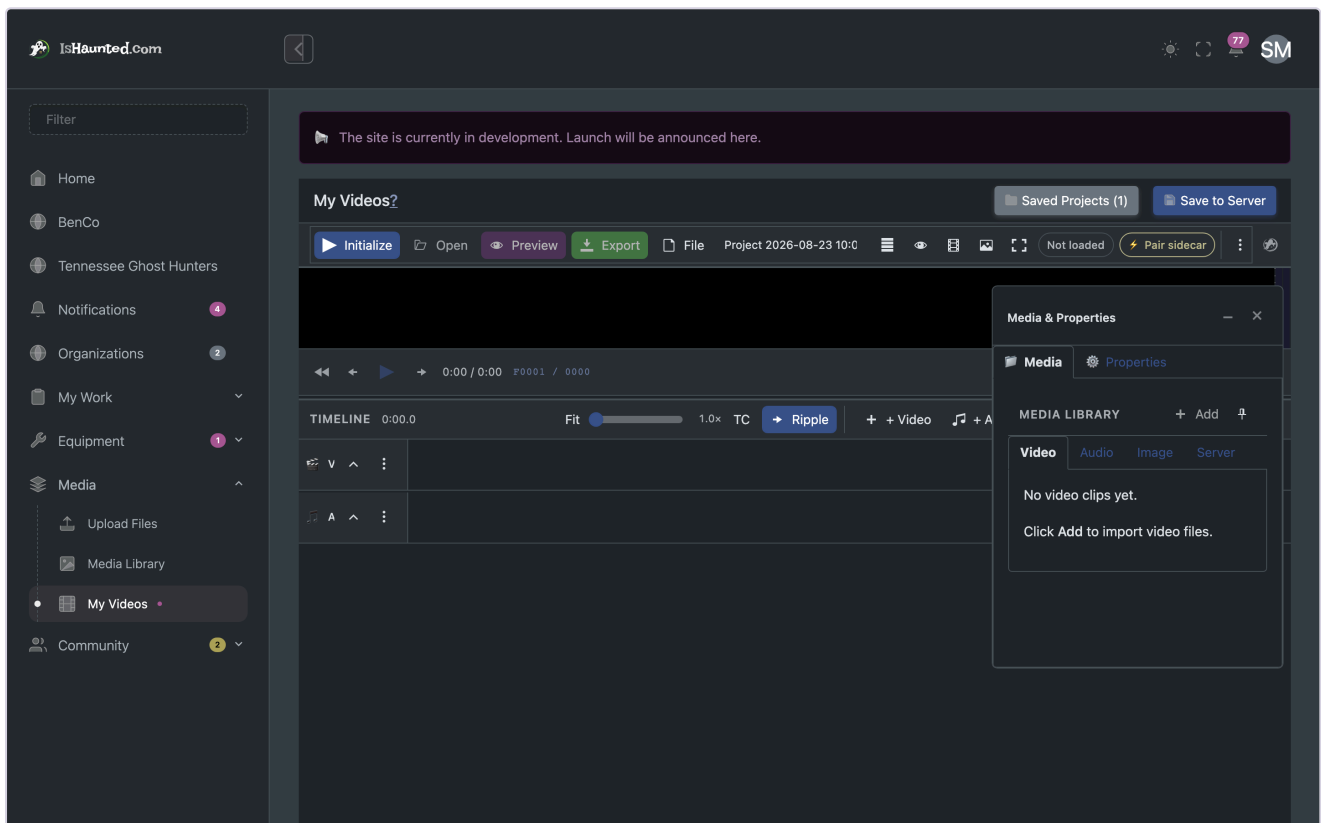
Groups with the **Equipment Checkouts** permission also get a queue of every loan of the group's gear, on the group's own Equipment tab.

Using the Video Editor

Turning raw footage into something worth watching — import, trim, title, and export.

Written for: **Signed-in users**

The video editor puts a full editing suite in your browser. Nothing is uploaded while you work: your footage is downloaded to your own machine, edited there, and rendered there. Only the finished video goes back to the server, and only if you ask it to.



The editor: preview at the top, timeline below, media and properties in the panel on the right.

Where to find it

- **My Videos** — your own workspace, for anything not tied to a case.
- **A case's Video tab** — the same editor, opened against that case, for work your group will attach to it.

There is also a standalone editor that runs on its own. It behaves identically, with one difference worth knowing: see [Working signed out](#) below.

Start the engine

The first thing to press is **Initialize**. The editor does its video work with a copy of ffmpeg that runs inside the browser, and that engine is a large download — so it is not fetched until you say so. Opening a project

to look at it costs nothing; editing needs the engine.

The chip beside the toolbar tells you where it is up to: *Not loaded*, then *Loading ffmpeg...*, then **Ready**. Import, preview and export all wait for Ready.

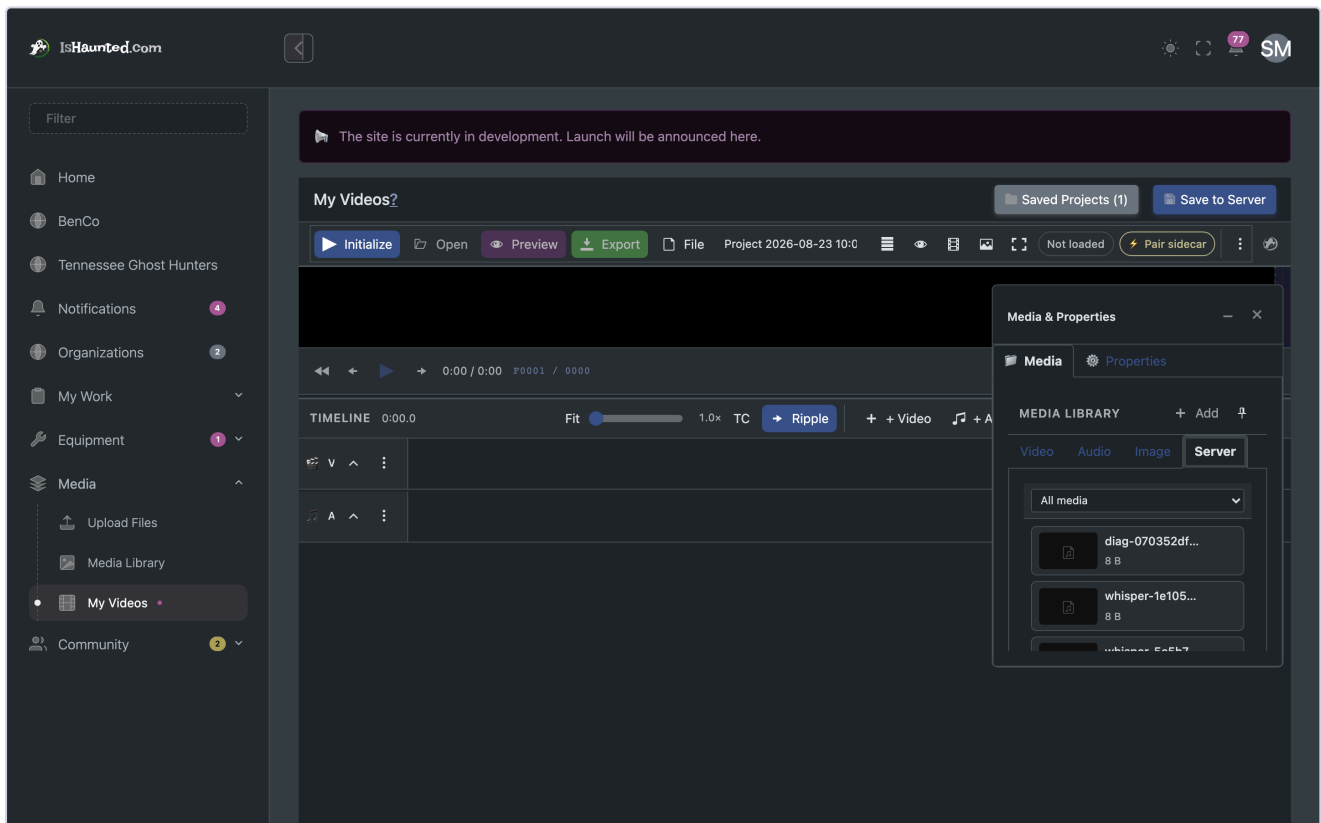
Once it says Ready the **Initialize** button goes away — it has done its one job, and the space goes to the tools you will actually use. It comes back if the engine ever fails, which is the one case where pressing it again is the right move.

Bringing in footage

There are two ways in.

From your machine — the **Open** button takes files straight off your disk. Nothing about them touches the server.

From the server — the **Server** tab lists media you already have on the site: your own uploads, and anything shared with you through a group or a case.



Everything you can reach, with its size. Clicking a file downloads it to this browser.

Finding the right file

The list above the files narrows what the tab shows:

WHAT YOU GET

All media	Everything you can reach — your uploads, and anything shared with you.
My files	Only what you uploaded yourself.
By case	One case's media. A second list appears; pick the case.

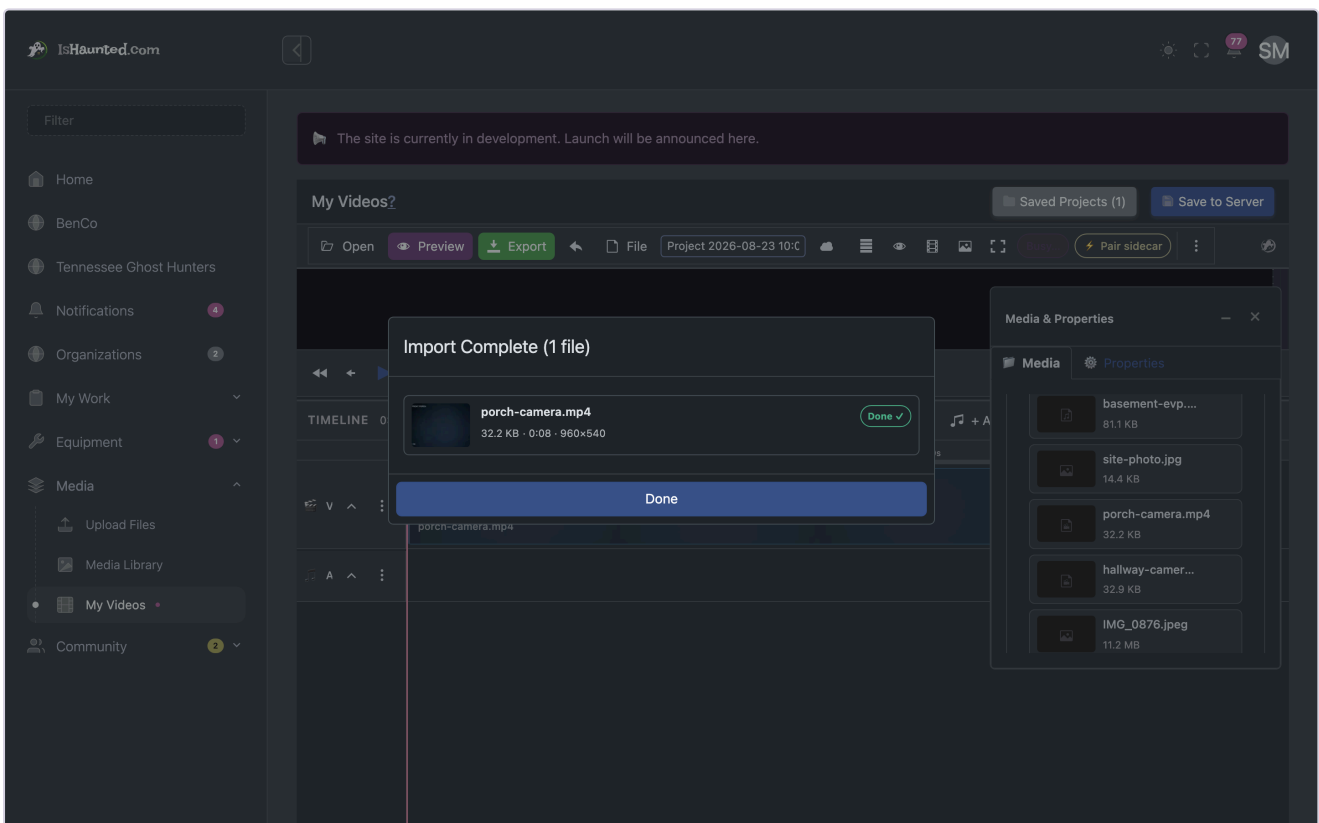
Picking a case that had more than one visit adds a third list, so you can narrow to a single night's material rather than everything the case has ever produced. Leave it on **The whole case** to see all of it.

The scope only ever narrows what you could already see. It is not a way of reaching somebody else's footage, and choosing a case you have no part in shows nothing rather than refusing.

Bringing a file over is deliberately **two clicks**:

1. **Click the file once.** It downloads to your browser and is kept there. A tick appears on the card. Nothing has been added to your video yet — this step is just fetching, and it does not need the engine.
2. **Click it again.** Now it is decoded and placed on the timeline.

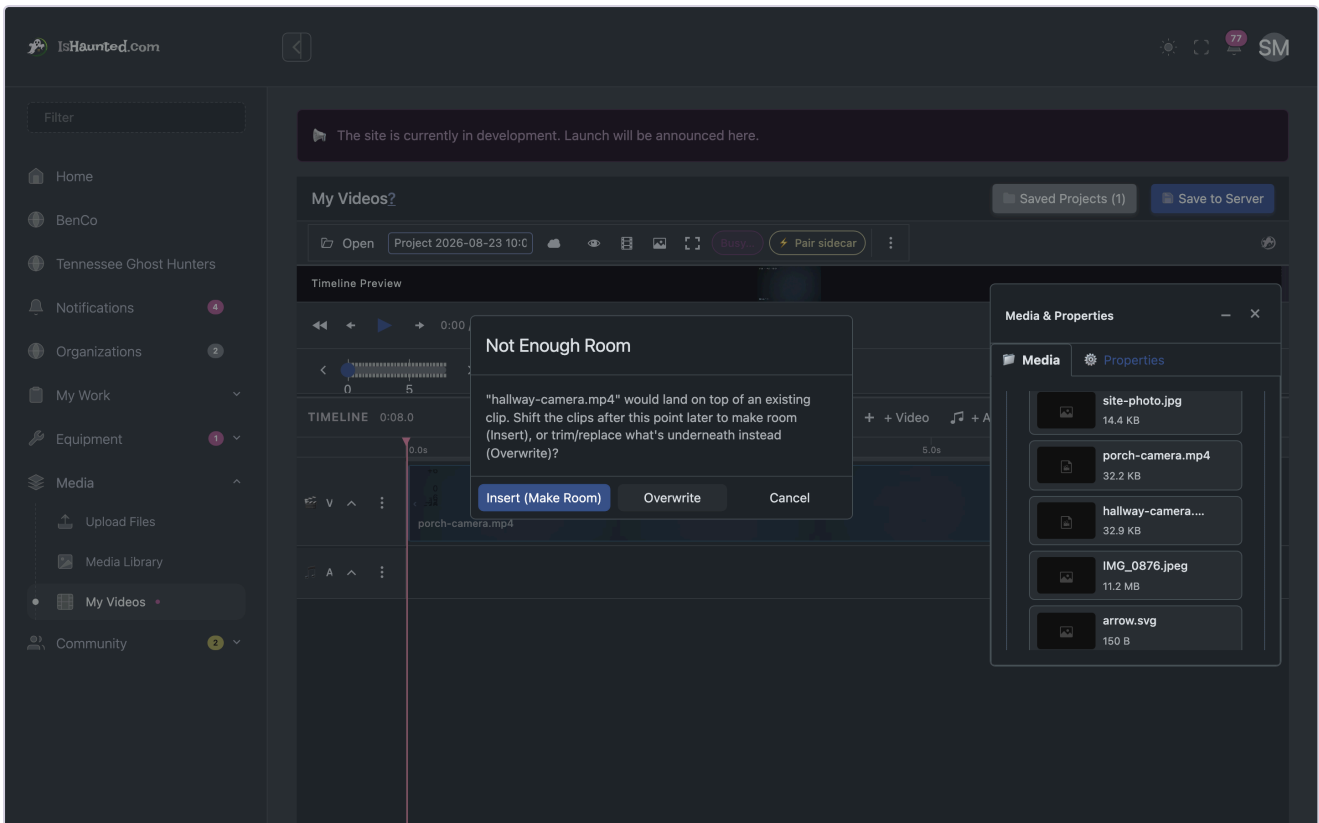
The split exists because downloading a large file and committing it to your edit are different decisions. You can pull several files down while you think, and place them later.



Each import reports what it found — length and frame size — and waits for you to dismiss it.

Landing on an occupied spot

If a clip would land where something already sits, the editor asks rather than guessing:

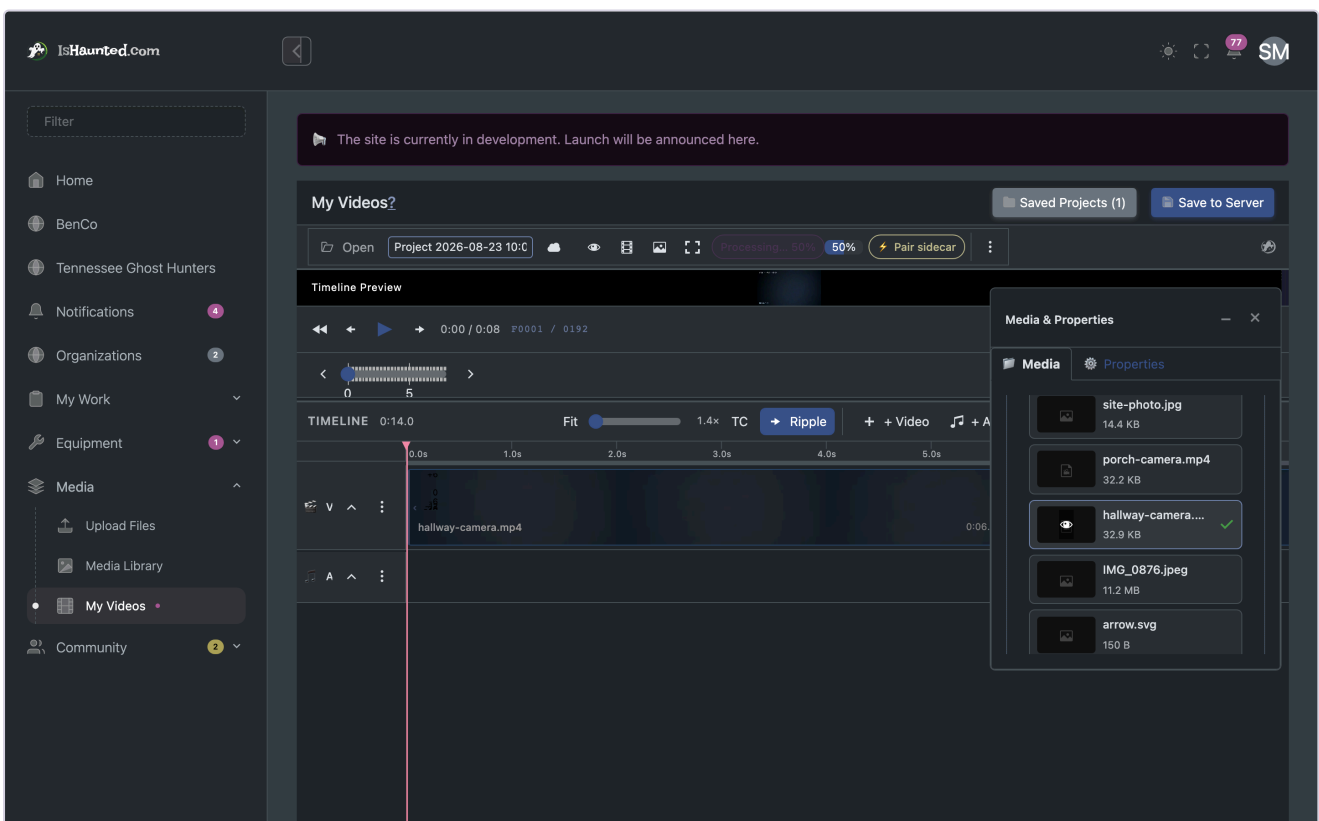


Insert pushes what is already there along. Overwrite replaces the part that overlaps.

Insert (Make Room) is the safe answer: nothing is lost, everything after the insertion point shifts later.

Overwrite is what you want when you are deliberately replacing a section.

The timeline



Two camera angles, one after the other. The pink line is the playhead.

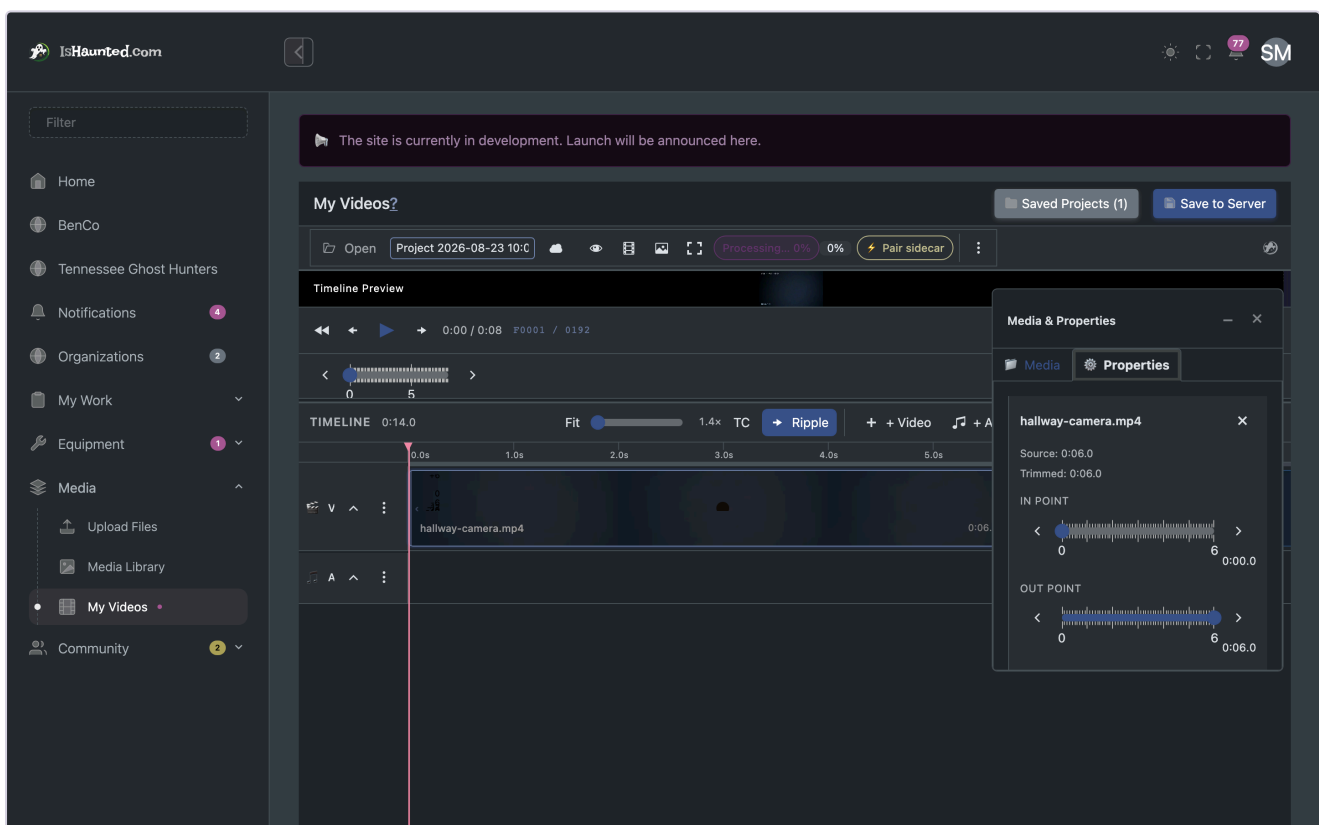
- **Tracks** stack: video on top of video, audio below. A clip on a higher track covers the one beneath it at the same moment.
- **Drag a clip** to move it. Drag its **edges** to trim — the clip's ends move, the file is untouched.
- **Fit** sizes the whole project to the width of the window; the zoom slider beside it takes you in closer for frame-accurate work.
- **TC** switches the ruler between timecode and frame numbers.
- **Ripple** decides what happens to everything downstream when you trim or delete: with it on, the gap closes and later clips move back; with it off, the gap stays.

Marking a moment

Marker drops a labelled point at the playhead. Markers are for you and anyone reviewing with you — a way to say "here" without cutting anything. They travel with the project.

Working on a clip

Select a clip and the panel's **Properties** tab describes it.



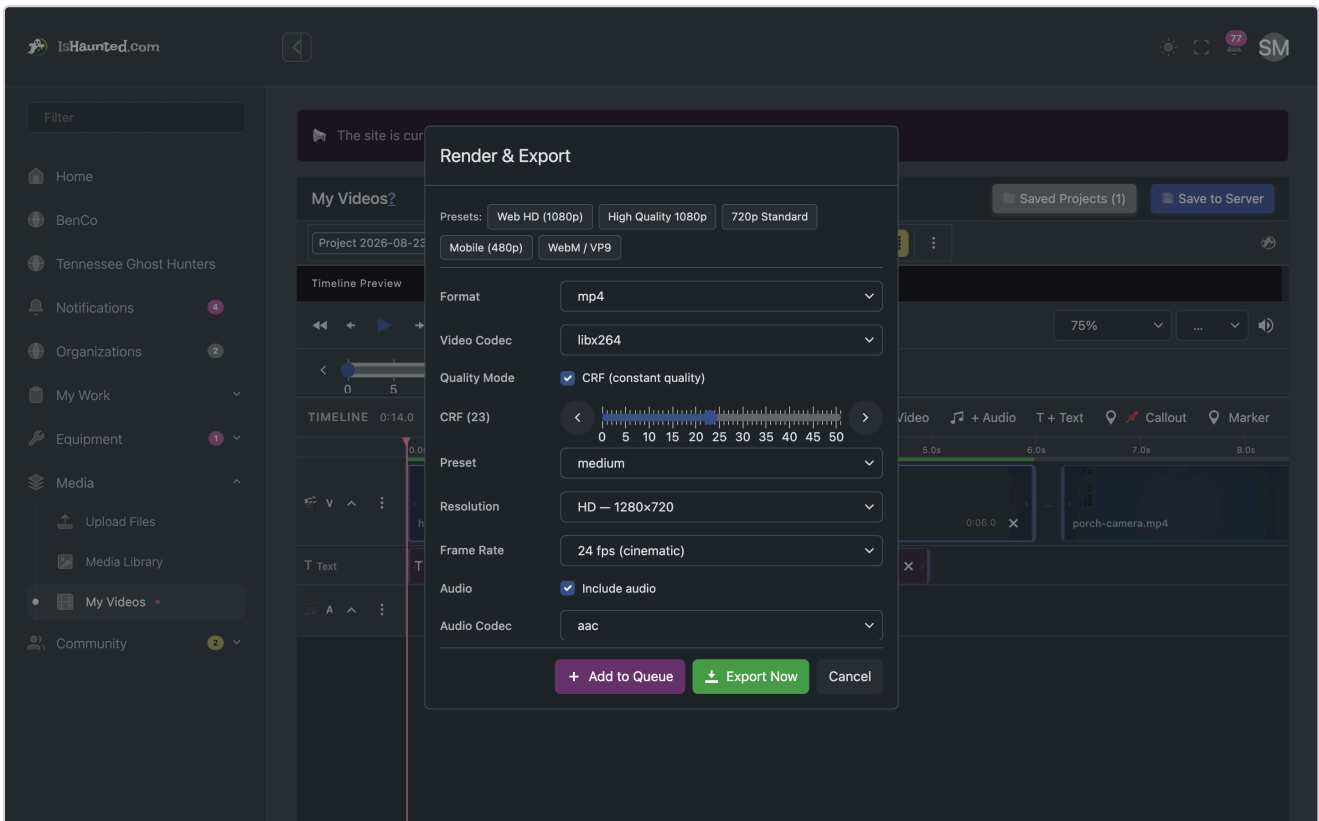
Trim, speed, volume, split and delete, all for the selected clip.

- **Apply Trim** sets exactly where the clip starts and ends, when dragging its edge is not precise enough.
- **Apply Speed** slows a moment down or runs a long stretch faster.
- **Apply Volume** sets the clip's level; audio clips also carry a draggable volume envelope on the timeline itself, for fading within a single clip.

- **Split** cuts the clip in two at the playhead.
- **Link Nearby Audio** ties a separately-recorded sound file to the picture it belongs with, so moving one moves the other.

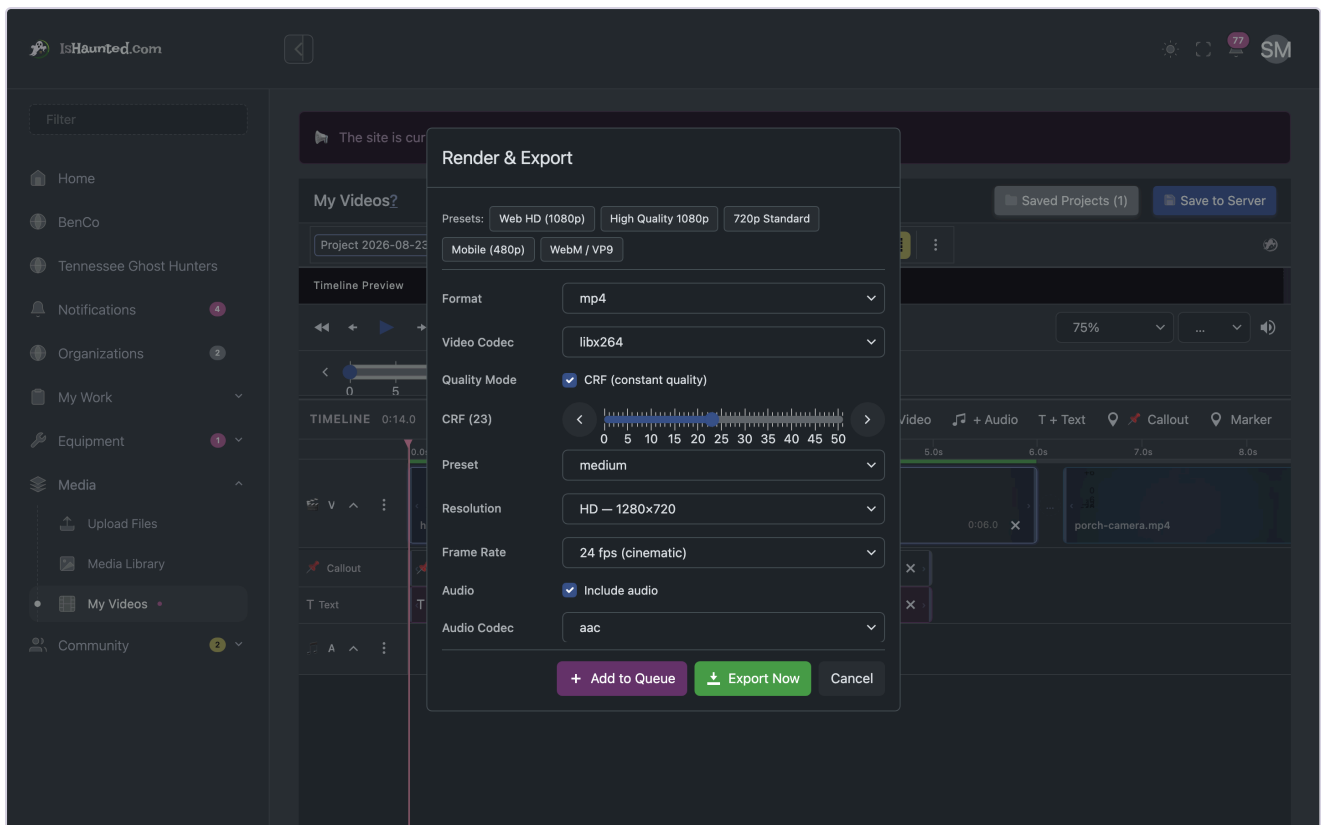
Titles and callouts

+ **Text** adds a title. It gets its own chip on the timeline, so its timing is edited exactly like a clip's — drag it to move it, drag its edges to change how long it shows.



A title is a clip like any other: it starts and ends where you put it.

Callout adds a shape — rectangle, ellipse, arrow — for pointing at something in the frame. Callouts can be moved, resized and rotated, and their movement can be animated over time.

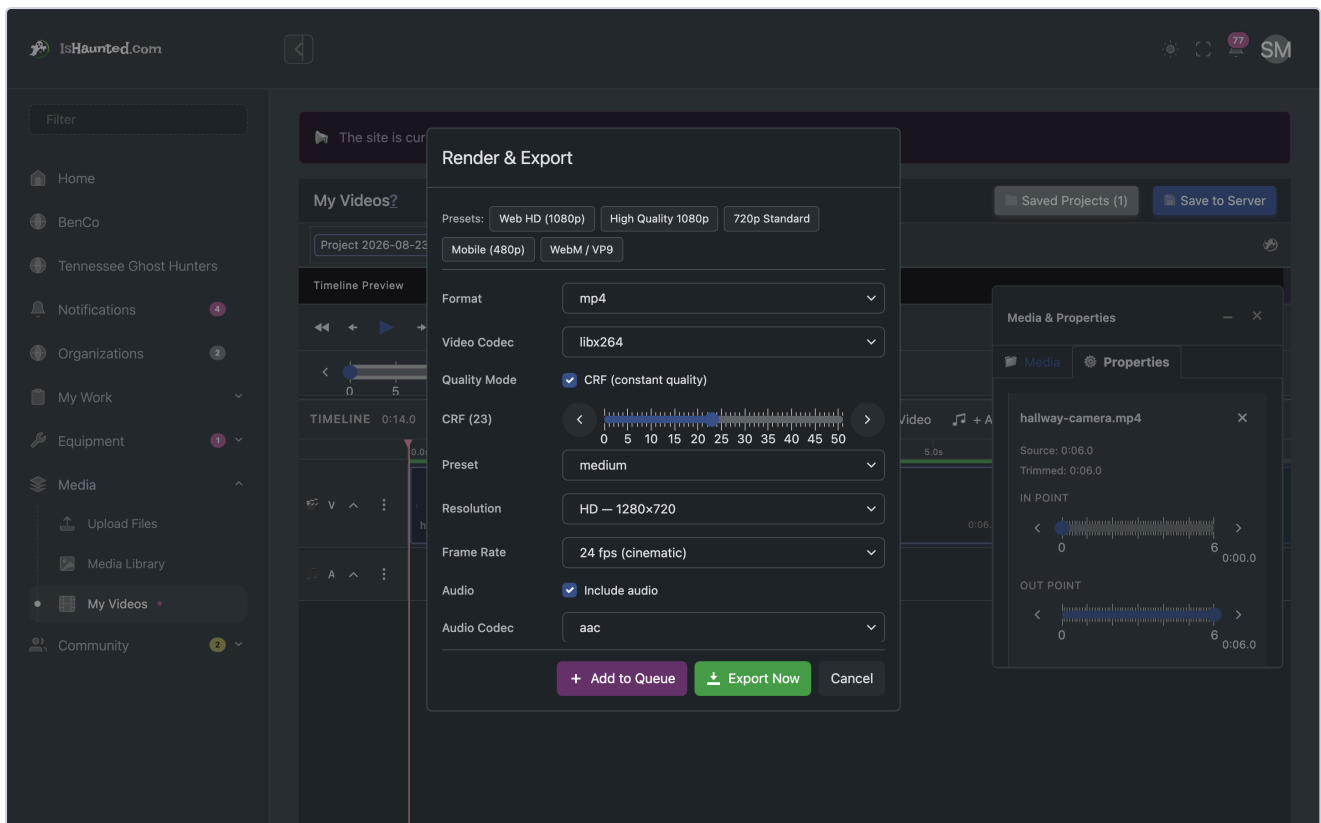


Callouts are for drawing attention to a spot in the picture.

Both take colour, font and border settings from the properties panel, and both can move across the frame while they are on screen.

Preview and export

Preview renders the real thing at full quality in a separate window, so you can check the finished result before committing to it. Meanwhile the editor keeps its own rough preview up to date in the background as you work — which is why the status chip sometimes says it is busy shortly after an edit.



Presets for the common cases, and every setting underneath them if you want it.

Export renders the final video. Start from a preset — Web HD, High Quality, 720p, Mobile or WebM — and adjust only what you care about: format, codec, quality, resolution and frame rate. **Export Now** renders immediately; **Add to Queue** lines it up so you can keep working.

You choose where the result goes:

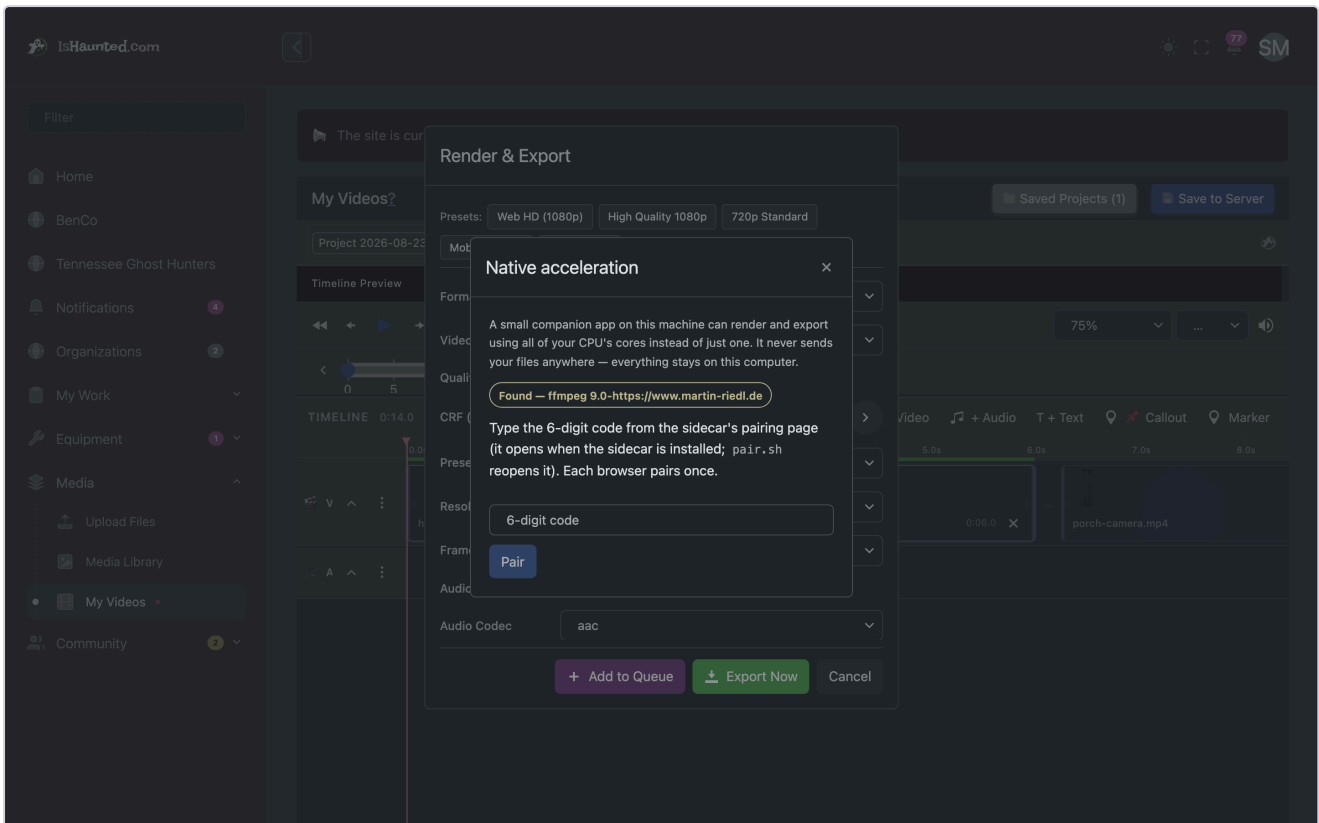
- **To your machine** — the file is saved locally and never leaves it.
- **To the server** — the finished video is uploaded and becomes an ordinary file in your media library, ready to attach to a case or publish.

Rendering is real work. A short project finishes quickly; a long one with overlays takes minutes, and both are faster with the native helper below.

The native helper (Sidecar)

Everything above runs inside the browser's sandbox, which is safe but slow: the browser will not use your machine's video hardware, and it works with one hand tied behind its back on long projects.

The **Sidecar** is a small application you install on your own computer to lift that limit. When it is running, the editor hands the heavy work — decoding, rendering, exporting — to it instead of doing it in the browser tab. The result is the same video, produced considerably faster, and long projects stop straining the browser's memory.



The panel behind the toolbar chip: whether a helper is installed, and whether this browser is paired with it.

It is entirely optional. With no Sidecar installed, everything still works — the editor uses the in-browser engine, exactly as it does now.

Installing and pairing

1. **Install it** on the computer you edit on — download it from [the sidecar downloads page](#), which carries the install steps for Windows and Mac. It runs quietly in the background and starts with your machine.
2. **Pair this browser with it.** The Sidecar shows a **six-digit code**; type that into the editor's pairing panel. That is all.

The chip on the toolbar tells you the state at a glance: *No sidecar* (none found), *Pair sidecar* (found, not yet paired) or *Native* (paired and in use).

Why a code at all. The Sidecar listens only on your own machine, and it refuses to take work from a page until that page has proved it is one you are actually using. The code is how you say so. It is single-use and expires after ten minutes, and pairing one browser does not unpair another.

Pairing is per browser and per site address. Editing from a different browser, or reaching the site by a different address, means pairing once more.

Saving your work

Save to Server stores the project — the arrangement, the trims, the titles, all of it — under your account, so you can pick it up on another machine. **Saved Projects** lists what you have.

A project is not the video. It is the recipe: which clips, in what order, cut where. The video itself only exists once you export.

Working signed out

The standalone editor can be used without signing in, and quite a lot works that way: open files from your machine, edit them, render the result and save it back to your machine. All of that is local.

Signing in is what connects it to the site. Until you do:

- the **Server** tab has nothing to list, because listing your media is a request the site must be able to attribute to you;
- **Save to Server** and publishing a finished render have nowhere to go, for the same reason.

So: edit locally as much as you like, sign in when you want your own footage or want to keep the result somewhere other than this computer.

When something looks wrong

- **The editor says "Not loaded" and nothing imports.** Press **Initialize** and wait for *Ready*.
- **Export is greyed out.** It needs both a Ready engine and at least one clip. If the chip says it is busy, a background render is running; it will free up when that finishes.
- **A file downloaded but did not appear.** Downloading and placing are two separate clicks — click the card a second time.
- **Nothing is listed on the Server tab.** In the standalone editor, sign in first. On the site, the tab lists what you own or have been given access to; a file someone else has not shared with you will not be there.

Administering a Group

Settings, members, requests, and the decisions only owners and administrators make.

Written for: Group owners & administrators

Visible to owners and administrators of a group. Managers and members work cases but do not configure the group itself.

Group settings

The group's **Edit** screen holds its public identity — name, URL, contact details — and two switches worth understanding.

Accepting membership applications controls whether people can apply to join.

Your web address

Your group lives at `/o/your-address` — the link you put on a card, in a post, or in an email to a client. It can use lowercase letters, numbers and hyphens, like `ghost-squad`. Spaces, slashes and punctuation are refused, and a handful of words the site uses itself are reserved.

No two groups can share an address, and **you can change yours whenever you like**. When you do:

- **The old address keeps working.** Every link anyone has already shared still opens your pages — visitors are simply moved along to the new address, so what they copy next is the current one.
- **The old address stays yours.** No other group can take it later, even years on. Pointing somebody's saved link at a different group would be worse than the link not working at all.

So changing your address is safe. Changing it often is still worth avoiding, because the address is what people remember.

Let clients see members' private photos is one half of a two-key rule. Turning it on shares nothing by itself; it only permits members who have *also* opted in on their own profile. This is deliberate: a group cannot volunteer its members' faces, and a member cannot overrule a group that has decided its people stay unidentified to clients.

Members and roles

The screenshot shows the IsHaunted.com interface. On the left is a sidebar with navigation links: Home, Nashville Paranormal Society, Tennessee Ghost Hunters (selected), BenCo, Administration (99+), Notifications (7), Organizations (14), My Work, Equipment, Media, and Community. The main content area is titled 'Members — Tennessee Ghost Hunters' and includes a '← Organizations' button. A banner at the top states 'The site is currently in development. Launch will be announced here.' Below this is a table of members:

Role	Member	Title	Active
Owner	AverageBen	— none —	True
Administrator	SM Sarah Mitchell	— none —	True
Administrator	RK Rachel Kim	— none —	True
Member	JT James Thornton	— none —	True
Member	MW Marcus Webb	— none —	True
Member	TB Tyler Brooks	— none —	True
Member	OC Olivia Chen	— none —	True
Member	DO David Okafor	— none —	True

Below the table is a 'Membership Applications' section with the text 'No membership applications for this organization.' The bottom of the page shows 'IsHaunted.com © 2026' and 'Help'.

Members and their roles. Roles decide what each person may do inside the group.

ROLE	TYPICALLY
Owner	Created the group. Full control.
Administrator	Configures the group and manages members.
Manager	Runs cases day to day.
Member	Works cases and attends investigations.
Viewer	Reads without changing anything.

The roles every group starts with

Every group begins with seven ready-made roles — **Case Manager Role**, **Equipment Manager Role**, **CMS Manager Role**, **Client Manager Role**, **Content Manager Role**, **Historian Role**, **Secretary Role** — each a starting point you can edit, rename, or delete like any role you build yourself. The "Role" suffix is deliberate: member *titles* (the ladder below) say how senior somebody is, roles say what they may do, and the naming keeps the two impossible to confuse.

Groups that existed before role-based case access arrived also carry an **Investigator Role** (read cases and investigations), assigned automatically — once — to everyone who was already an ordinary member, so the change took nothing from anyone. Members who join later start with no roles; hand them the Investigator Role, or any other, as they earn it.

What role grants open today

Since the enforcement flip: reading the group's cases and investigations follows role grants, not bare membership. Everyone who was already an ordinary member when the flip arrived holds the Investigator Role and noticed nothing; a member without any case-reading role no longer sees the Cases and Investigations tabs at all — the tabs and the server give the same answer. Owners and administrators always see everything.

Three of the role editor's sections started doing real work with the roles arc's Phase B: **Cases** (creating a case, and editing one you don't manage), **Client Requests** (accepting or declining what clients send in), and **Calendar** (event types, and managing other people's attendance). Each is strictly additive: owners and administrators keep everything they had, and a role grant now opens the same doors for the members who hold it. Nothing was taken from anyone — the grants only add. The remaining sections' grants become decisive as the later phases land; each section's own description says where it stands.

Banners for work that blocks other people

When a client's investigation request or a membership application is waiting on your group, a banner appears under the site-wide announcement on every page — for you and anyone else whose permissions let them open that queue, and for nobody else. Each banner names the group and the waiting count and links straight to the tab where you act. Dismissing one keeps it away for the rest of your session; a new arrival brings it back.

Custom-role permissions and your plan

Each subscription plan includes custom-role permissions for a set of areas — cases, calendar, files, and so on — and the **Pricing** page lists exactly which areas each plan includes, so what an upgrade buys is never a surprise. Most plans include everything; when yours excludes an area, the role editor says so rather than hiding it:

- Sections the plan does not include are **grayed out with their toggles disabled**, under a note naming the areas and the plan.
- **Nothing is deleted.** Grants you configured in an excluded area are kept exactly as you set them — the note counts them — and apply again the moment a plan change includes the area. A downgrade pauses; it never erases.
- The rule holds server-side too: a save can change only the sections your plan includes, and everything else is carried forward untouched.

When an administrator changes what a plan includes, groups on that plan are told: newly included areas are announced right away, and removals arrive as a notice — before the renewal that applies them for paid groups. Owners and group administrators are unaffected by area exclusions, exactly as they are unaffected by role grants: they always hold every permission.

Member titles — the ladder

Separate from roles, on purpose: a **title** says how senior somebody is in the group — a **role** says what they may do. The two never mix. Giving somebody a grander title changes nothing about what they can access, and a brand-new member with the right role can do things a ten-year veteran without it cannot.

Every group starts with the same five-rung ladder — **Probationary, Junior Investigator, Investigator, Senior Investigator, Lead Investigator** — and it is entirely yours to change: rename rungs, reorder them, add your own, or delete the ones you will never use, all under **Settings** → **Member titles**. Deleting a title simply clears it from anyone holding it; nobody loses any access, because titles never granted any.

Assign titles from the **Members** tab — each row has a title dropdown if you administer the group. A member's title shows as a badge beside their name on the roster. Someone who belongs to two groups holds a separate title in each, which is exactly how it should be: seniority is earned per group.

Investigation duties

Under **Settings** → **Investigation duties** lives the list of jobs your group hands out per visit — every group starts with Lead Investigator, Equipment, Evidence Collection, and Documentation, and the list is yours: rename, add, retire. A duty marked **one holder** (like the lead) can only be held by a single person per visit; assigning it to someone takes it from the previous holder.

A duty can ask for a **minimum title** from the member ladder — "Evidence Collection wants Investigator or above." The ask is deliberately soft: whoever manages a visit can assign past it with an explicit *Assign anyway*, and the exception is marked on the assignment. Duties never grant standing permissions; they exist so the visit's roster says who is doing what.

The Investigations tab

Every visit the group has run, mapped and listed, including ones that belong to no client case. It is visible to every member, not only administrators — knowing where the group has worked is ordinary team knowledge, not an administrative secret.

Schedule an investigation books a visit with no case behind it. What the group finds there is shared under the same rules as any other investigation.

Who can change an investigation

Being a member is enough to *read* an investigation and to answer for yourself — your own RSVP and your own arrival. Changing the record itself is narrower. Any one of these is enough:

- whoever scheduled it
- the case manager, for a visit attached to a case
- whoever is leading that particular visit
- group owners and administrators
- anyone the group has granted the **Investigation** permission under **Roles**

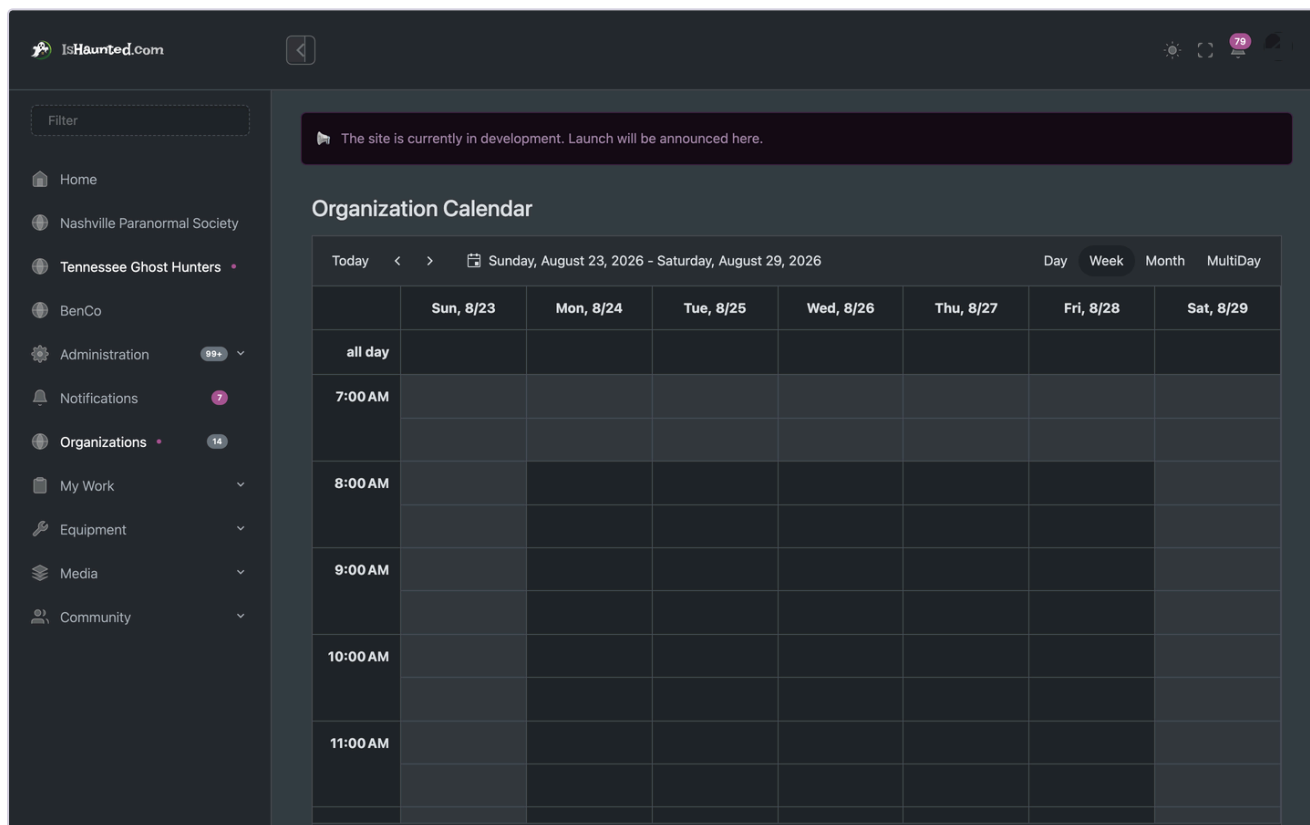
That last one is the lever you have as an administrator. Grant a role the *Update* action on **Investigation**, give somebody that role, and they can edit any of the group's investigations without being made an administrator of everything else.

Leading a visit is not a rank. It is set per investigation, in the **Lead** column of the investigation's team list, and it ends with that visit. One person leads at a time — naming a lead takes it from whoever held it — and the current lead can hand it on, which is what happens when somebody leaves halfway through the night. Somebody senior enough to lead every visit is better served by the permission above; somebody leading one Saturday is better served by the lead flag, which stops mattering on Sunday.

Incoming requests

Client requests arrive under the group's **Requests**. Mark one as under review while you decide. Declining tells the client, and lets them send it elsewhere without rewriting it.

The group calendar



The calendar carries investigations and the group's own events.

The group's **Calendar** holds meetings, training, anything with a time attached. Investigations are scheduled from the case they belong to, not here.

Where it happens. Type a free-text location, or pick one of the group's saved addresses. Prefer the saved address: it is stored as a reference rather than copied text, so correcting the address once corrects every event held there. A **meeting link** can sit alongside it — paste a Zoom, Teams or Meet join link, and a bare `zoom.us/j/123` is accepted as readily as the full URL.

Repeating events. The **Repeats** list covers the usual patterns — daily, weekly, monthly, and so on. **Custom** takes an iCal rule directly (`FREQ=WEEKLY;BYDAY=TU`) for a pattern the list does not cover.

Invites. A public event is open to the whole group by definition, so invites appear only on a non-public one. Tick members from the list, or type an email address to invite somebody outside the group. That lookup only finds addresses their owner has published *and confirmed* on their own profile — never the private address someone signs in with. If an address does not resolve, the person either has no account or has not published that address; ask them rather than guessing at another spelling.

Invites are invitations, nothing more. Assigning work belongs to investigations, where it already exists.

Calendar event types

Under **Settings**, *Calendar Event Types* is the list the calendar's **Type** dropdown offers — Investigation, Meeting, Training, whatever the group actually does. A group with no types can still create events; the events simply have no type.

Each type carries a name, an optional colour and icon, and a sort order that decides where it sits in the dropdown. Only owners and administrators can change the list.

Clear **Active** to retire a type. It disappears from the dropdown for new events but stays on the events that already use it — which is almost always what you want. Deleting one removes it from those events too, leaving their date and title untouched.

The Equipment tab

Two lists, because a group deals with two kinds of gear.

The group's gear is equipment the group itself owns. Every member can see the list — what the group has is not a secret from the people who use it — but adding, editing and deleting it needs the **Equipment** permission, and so does seeing serial numbers.

Each piece tracks who is holding it, when it was last serviced, whether it is currently faulty, and its photos. **Held by** can be set by hand: kit gets passed over in a car park without anyone opening the app, and the record should still be able to tell the truth. A holder has to be an active member.

History on a piece opens two things: the full account of everything that has happened to it — loans, requests for more time, service and faults, newest first — and the service log itself, where new entries are added.

The service log part is what you write to. Anyone can read it; adding an entry needs the Equipment permission. The entry type does real work rather than just labelling the note:

ENTRY	WHAT IT DOES TO THE ITEM
Serviced	Moves its last-serviced date
Fault reported	Marks the piece faulty, and the note becomes the reason
Fault fixed	Clears the fault

The entry and its consequence are saved together, so the log never disagrees with the piece it describes. Entries are kept — fixing a fault does not erase the report of it.

Once a piece has any loan or service history, deleting it is refused and you are asked to **retire** it instead — the button sits in the item editor. Retired gear drops out of borrowing, out of the public catalog and out of the group list, while everything that happened to it stays readable. You can put it back in service the same way. Destroying a serial-numbered asset would take the account of what happened to it along too.

Members' shared gear is the second list: equipment members own personally and have chosen to show this group. It is read-only here — it belongs to its owner — and it needs no permission to read, because the sharing itself is the owner's decision, not the group's to gate. Serial numbers stay with owners even here.

The **Borrowing** column says whether a piece can be borrowed at all, which is a separate choice from sharing it — a member can let the group know they own something without offering to lend it. Whether a particular piece is offered to the group or only lent personally is shown when you actually ask to borrow it, since that is the point at which the difference matters.

A shared piece disappears from this tab if its owner leaves the group. Their sharing choice is kept, so it comes back if they rejoin.

The two equipment permissions

Under **Roles**, equipment has two entries, and the second sits underneath the first because it is narrower:

- **Equipment** — manage what the group owns: add and edit gear, upload its photos, keep its service log, set who is holding a piece, and see serial numbers. Read access to the list needs nothing at all beyond membership.
- **Equipment Checkouts** — run the loans desk: approve and deny borrowing requests, hand gear over and receive it back. This is the "Equipment Management" job in item #55's own words.

They are separate so a group can hand someone the loans desk without also handing them the catalog. Deciding what the group buys and owns, and lending out what it already has, are different jobs and often different people. Granting **Equipment** does not grant **Equipment Checkouts**.

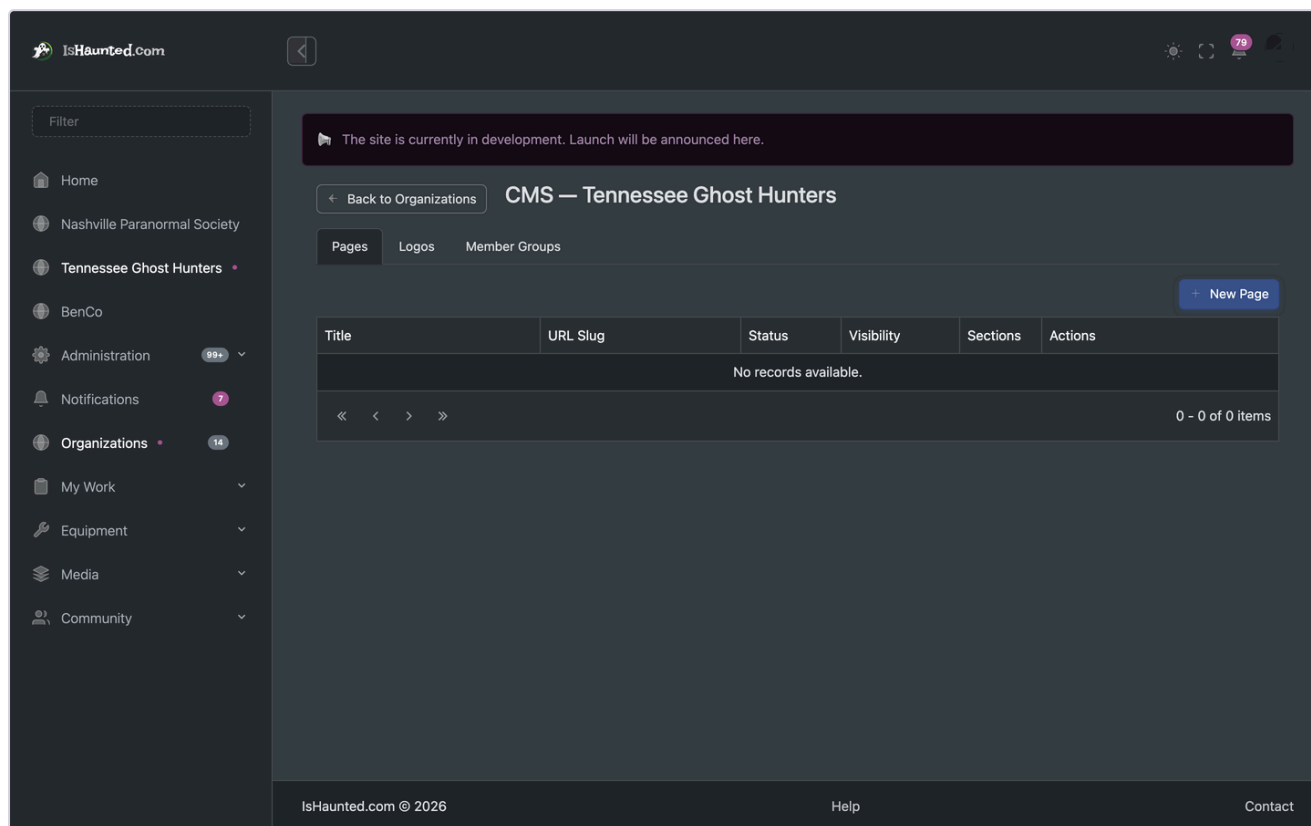
Neither permission has any say over a member's personal gear. A loan of somebody's own equipment is always approved by its owner.

The Files tab

The group's file library: upload directly, or pull in a member's own file with **Share from User**. That button opens a picker listing everything the group could take a copy of — files their owners have shared with your group first, then public files — with search, a type filter, and thumbnail or list views. Choosing one copies it into the group's library; shared files arrive **private by default**, and someone with publish permission approves them before they ever appear publicly. The original stays the owner's: only a file's owner can delete it, and a group removing its copy never touches the member's own file.

Editing your public pages

The CMS editor has a built-in walkthrough — the ? button beside New Page runs it any time, and it runs itself once for first-time editors.



Your public pages. A page is not visible to anyone until you publish it.

Pages you build under **CMS** appear on your group's public site. Two things control what visitors see, and they are different.

Published decides whether the page exists for visitors at all. **Drafts** decide whether the edits you are making right now are visible while you make them.

Drafts

Editing a page that is **not** published changes it directly. Nobody can see it, so there is nothing to protect.

Editing a page that **is** published works differently. Open it and you will be offered **Work on a draft instead**. Take it, and your changes go into a copy — the live page carries on exactly as it was until you press **Publish changes**. Until then, visitors see the old version, and you can **Discard draft** to throw the work away and leave the live page untouched.

A page has one draft at a time. If a colleague has already started one, you will see a note saying so with a link to open it, rather than being handed a second copy nobody knows about.

Publishing keeps the page's address and its permissions — the live page is updated in place, not replaced, so nothing linking to it breaks.

Page addresses

A page's address is the last part of its web address — `/o/your-group/about` . Keep it short and lowercase; it is what people paste to each other.

A few words are used by the site itself — **cases** and **events** today, plus some held back for things coming later. A page can't use one, because it could never be opened: the site would show its own page at that address instead. If you try, you'll be told which word and offered a way round it — "our-cases" rather than "cases".

If you have an older page marked **Unreachable** in the list, that is one made before this check existed. Rename it and it will start working.

Pictures on a page

An **Image or banner** section takes a picture from your group's files — **Choose an image** opens the picker with everything shared with the group; search it or filter by visibility. If the image you pick is **members only**, the editor says so on the spot: the page will render the picture for you and show visitors a broken frame, because a public page cannot hand out a file its owner kept private. Pick a public image, or make that one public on its file page first.

Seeing a page before it goes live

View as visitor on the editor opens the saved page exactly as the public renderer draws it, published or not. That is the honest check: the side-by-side panel next to the editor follows what you are typing, but it draws its own approximation in half a column, so a page can look right there and wrong in reality.

The preview also tells you if the page is not in the menu yet, which is the usual reason a freshly-published page seems to have vanished.

Reusing a page layout

Built a write-up you want to do again? On the page's editing screen, **Save as a layout** keeps its sections — their types, titles and current wording — as a named layout, for example *Investigation Results*.

Next time you add a page, pick that layout under **Start from one of our layouts** and the new page arrives with those sections ready to fill in.

Two things worth knowing:

- **The layout belongs to the group**, not to whoever saved it, so it stays when people come and go.
- **The copy is yours**. Editing the layout later does not touch pages already made from it, and editing one of those pages does not change the layout.

Sections that point at a case or an investigation keep the *shape* but you will want to re-point the pickers — a layout reused for a different night should show that night's work.

Putting your cases and investigations on a page

Two section types — **Our investigations** and **Our cases** — let you show your own work on a public page. Pick which records to show, and answer two questions about each section.

Where it happened. You can show the rough area, or nothing at all. There is no option to publish the exact address, whichever way you set it: the point shown on the map is the centre of an area several miles across and cannot be traced back to a building. That is deliberate — a case is somebody's home, and a link outlives the page it was on.

Who it was for. Cases can show the client's chosen name. Only the alias the client picked, or the one your group set for them — a real name is never published here. If neither is set, the case appears with no name.

Work that is not public yet is flagged in the picker, and adding it asks you to confirm. Until you do, those records are left off the page entirely. Publishing a private investigation makes it readable by anyone who visits, including the person it is about.

You can only show your own group's work. Everything is looked up fresh each time somebody views the page, so if a client later asks to be unnamed, they disappear from pages you published months ago — you do not have to remember which ones.

On any case page, the ? button beside Edit Case walks through exactly how a case goes public — the pseudonym, generalized addresses, and which media may appear.

Putting a case's photos on a page

Photos from a case shows pictures and files taken from one of your own cases. Choose the case, then tick the files you want.

Only some of a case's files can be published, and this is not a setting you can change here. A file appears in the picker when it is attached to a timeline entry marked **Public**, on a case that is itself public. Files on the case's **Files** tab never appear, whatever they are.

That is on purpose. There is exactly one way to publish a case file — put it on a public timeline entry — so there is one place to look when you want to know what is visible, and one place to change your mind. If a photo you want is missing from the picker, add it to a public timeline entry on the case first.

Captions are off unless you turn them on. A caption is the timeline entry's title, which is your group's own working description of what happened — useful to you, and sometimes more than you would choose to say to a visitor.

The photos stay linked to the case rather than copied onto the page. If somebody later makes that timeline entry private, or the case is unpublished, the photos come off every page that used them, by themselves. You do not have to remember which pages they were on. The same is true of the direct image links — a link copied out of the page stops working at the same moment.

Public events

An event on your calendar can be opened to anybody. Tick **Public** and it appears on your group's public site, on the site-wide **What's on** list, and anyone with an account can say they are coming.

This is the one part of the site that brings you people who have never heard of you. Somebody looking for a ghost walk near them finds your event, turns up, and meets the group — so the listing names you prominently and reads as an invitation rather than a record.

What can be made public

Events at **landmarks, businesses, and your own addresses**. Not events at a private residence, and not events attached to a case.

That is deliberate and cannot be overridden. A public listing is a date and an address advertised to strangers, and a client did not agree to have people turn up at their home. If you want to publicise work you are doing on a case, create a separate event for a venue that is yours to publish.

Hiding the address until somebody is coming

Hide exact location shows the town but not the street address. Whoever is coming sees the full address once they have said so; nobody else ever receives it, and the listing says as much up front so nobody feels tricked into signing up to find out where they are going.

If somebody cancels, the address stops being shown to them.

Places and sign-ups

- **Places** caps how many people can come. Leave it empty for no limit.
- **Sign-ups close** sets a cut-off. Leave it empty and people can sign up right up to the start.
- Somebody who cancels frees their place for somebody else.

The link you can share

A public event gets a readable web address — `/o/your-group/events/2026-08-24-ghost-walk` — made from its date and title the first time you publish it. That is the link to put on social media.

It does not change afterwards, even if you rename the event. A link somebody has already shared should keep working.

People coming who don't have an account

Somebody who finds your event and has never been here before doesn't have to sign up for anything first. They give an email address, we send them a link, and clicking it is what actually confirms they're coming.

The link matters: an address typed into a box proves nothing, and an event that hides its exact location until people are coming would be protecting nothing if anyone could type any address and be shown where you're meeting.

Confirming makes them an account with no password. They can set one later if they want to sign in properly, but they don't have to — it exists so you have somebody you can reach, and so they can see what

they've said they're going to.

You'll see them in the attendee list like anybody else.

The reminder the day before

Anyone who has said they are coming is emailed a reminder about a day beforehand, automatically. You do not send it and there is nothing to switch on.

Somebody who signed up three weeks ago has had three weeks to forget, and a stranger who does not turn up is worse for you than one who never signed up at all — so the reminder repeats the time and place, carries the link to your event page, and gives them a way to say they can no longer come while you can still offer the place to somebody else.

It goes only to people whose answer was **yes**. Somebody invited who never replied, or who said maybe, is not written to: they did not agree to come, and a reminder about a thing you never agreed to is just mail you did not ask for.

Everyone is reminded once. If the site cannot reach somebody's address, it tries again on the next run rather than giving up quietly.

Applications from would-be members

When **Accepting Membership Applications** is on (the group's Edit screen), your public page shows an apply box to signed-in visitors. Applications land on the **Members** tab, where any member with the requests permission can Accept or Deny — a denial asks for a reason, and the applicant sees your answer.

What kind of group you are

Every group is either an **investigation group** or a **ghost walking tour**, chosen when it was created and changeable in **Settings**. The choice decides what a NEW group starts with — a tour starts with a public, searchable meeting point and public events; an investigation group starts private — and after that it is a label, never a restriction. Nothing is withheld from either kind.

Alongside it sits **runs public tours**, which is a separate switch on purpose. Plenty of investigation groups run paid public tours as a sideline, and none of them should have to register a second group to be found for it. Turn it on and your group appears under **Walking tours** in the group finder while its badge still says investigation group — which is the truth about both facts at once.

Promoting your group

Settings → **Promote your group** builds a promotional card that rotates through the group finder's Featured groups, the home page, and the public feed, always marked "Promoted". In the feed, cards are fed to the people nearest your group's public address first — a group with no public address still rotates, just unranked. Once approved, the page shows two honest numbers: how many times the card was shown, and how many people clicked through. The builder walks you through it — headline (say who you help and where), a short message (what you do, what it costs, what to do next), an optional picture from your media library, and where the card leads: your public page or the group finder. Send your people to the

public page only once it's worth arriving at — a striking headline over an empty page loses the person you just won.

Every card goes through review before anyone sees it: submit, and a platform administrator approves it or declines it with a reason (you're messaged either way). Any later edit comes back through review — the approved text is the only text that ever shows. One card per group; withdraw it any time and it leaves the placements immediately.

Feed posts made from your cases

When a member (or a client) renders a video from one of your cases in the video editor and posts it to the public feed, the post is credited to *them* — **your group's name appears on nothing until you say so**.

Settings → **Feed attribution** lists that footage for your decision:

- **Claim** puts your group's name and a link to your public page on the post, plus a **Group verified** badge — you vouching that the footage is what it says. That badge also lifts the post's standing in the feed.
- **Decline** leaves the post up, credited to the person, with no link to you — ever.

Either decision can be changed later. Footage from a **private engagement** additionally required the poster's explicit, recorded confirmation before it could be posted at all — claiming or declining is only about your name, never about whether the post exists.

Location data in your photos, audio and video

Cameras and phones write the coordinates of wherever they were into the file itself. On a case at somebody's home, that file knows the address — and the site's careful, deliberately vague map pin counts for nothing if the photograph beside it carries the exact spot.

Photographs are cleaned for every group, always. The copy anyone downloads is rebuilt from the picture alone, so nothing that was not the image survives. There is no setting, because there is no reason anyone would want the alternative.

Audio and video are a setting, under Settings on your group's page. Cleaning a recording means rebuilding the file, so it is offered where a plan includes it — the switch says plainly when it is not available, and to whom to talk. Groups working only at landmarks and businesses may reasonably leave it off; a group going into people's homes should not.

Whatever is removed is still yours. Every file, of every kind, has its details recorded against its record when you upload it: where and when it was taken, the device, the technical figures. Removing that from the copy people download never removes it from your own records — you keep the facts, the public copy does not carry them. And a clip you cut from a recording keeps the recording's place, since a clip has no coordinates of its own.

Your group's plan

Plans are priced by **active members, per group** — the price list is on the **Pricing** page, visible to everyone. Yearly billing usually costs less than paying month by month; the card says how much less.

Two things worth knowing about how plans behave:

What you signed up for is a contract for the period you paid for. If the plan changes after you subscribe, improvements reach you immediately — a raised limit, a lower price, nothing to do on your side. Changes that would reduce what you have wait until your renewal, and you'll get a message about them **before** your period ends, so nothing ever changes under you mid-period. When your current terms are better than what the pricing page shows, your Pricing page says so: "you keep the terms you signed up for until" your renewal date.

Plans can include limits — on open cases, equipment, loans out at a time, open investigations, public pages. If your group reaches one, the screen where you tried says exactly which limit and what your plan includes; closed cases and retired equipment never count against you. A larger plan raises the limit.

Have a coupon code? There's a line for it at checkout — type it and the price updates before you confirm anything. Codes can be limited to first subscriptions, to renewals, to yearly billing, or to a specific account, so if a code is refused the message says why.

If your group grows past what your plan covers, your plan does not change and nothing stops anyone joining. Each person who joins beyond your member count is billed for their own seat at a per-person price, told to them when they are accepted, and shown on their own Pricing page. Your group keeps one plan and one renewal date.

Tax appears as its own line on the quote when your state taxes the service, computed from your group's address — never folded into the price. And every payment your group makes has a **receipt**: open **Billing history** on your group's card on the Pricing page to see every charge, payment and adjustment, and download any receipt by its number. Receipts are generated from the payment record itself, so the one you download in five years says exactly what it said on the day.

Publishing with Publications

Setting up a publication, writing posts, and deciding when the public sees them.

Written for: **Group owners & administrators**

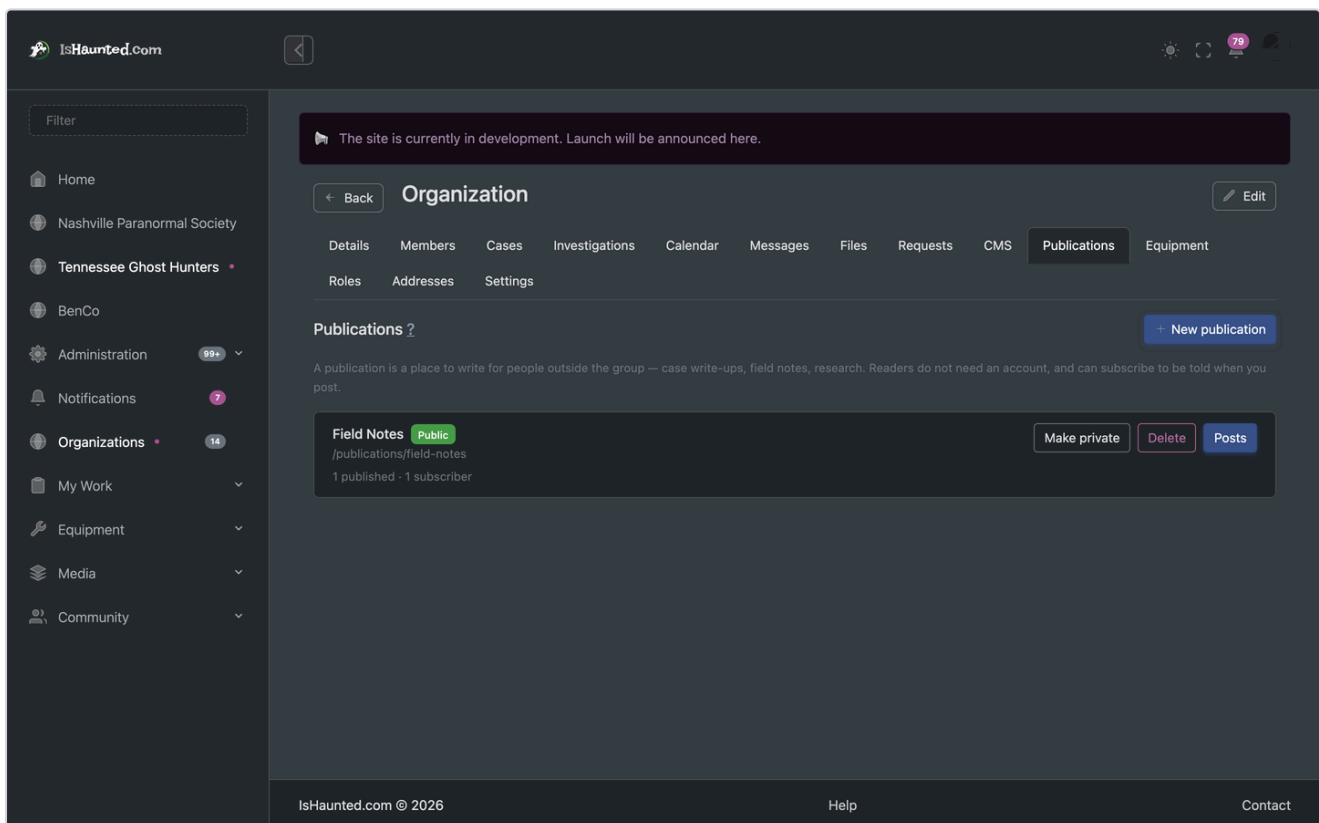
A **publication** is your group's own title — a place to write for people outside the group. Case write-ups, research, field notes, anything that deserves more room than [the Feed](#) gives it.

Readers do not need an account to read what you publish, and can subscribe to keep track of you.

Where it lives

Publications is a tab on your group's page. If you do not see it, either you do not have permission to edit the group's public material, or publications are switched off for the whole site — a site administrator controls that.

Permission is the same one that governs the group's CMS pages: whoever may speak for the group in public may write in a publication.



Each publication shows its address, how many posts are published, how many are still drafts, and how many people subscribe.

Creating one

New **publication** asks for three things.

Title — what the publication is called. *Field Notes*, *The Ridgeway Case*, *Ashcroft Research*.

Description — a line or two shown in the public directory, explaining what a reader will find.

Visible to the public — leave this **off** while you find your feet. Nothing you write is readable outside the group until *both* the publication is public *and* a post has been published. Two switches, deliberately: one lets you get a few pieces ready before anyone can see the publication exists at all.

About the address

The address — `/publications/field-notes` — is made from the title **once**, when you create the publication, and never changes afterwards.

That is on purpose. Renaming later changes the heading readers see; it does not move the link. Any link somebody shared today still works next year. If the address really matters to you, get the title right the first time.

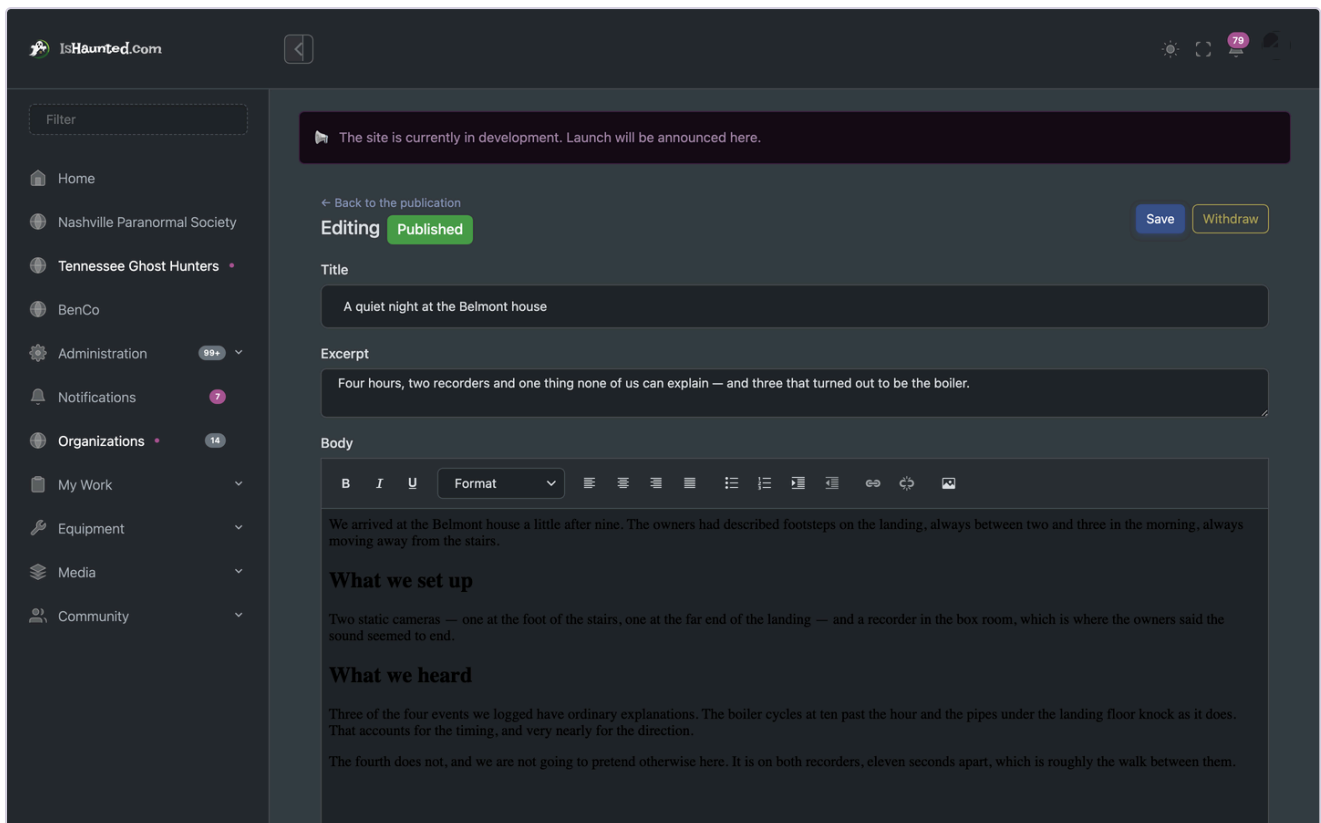
Writing a post

Posts on a publication opens everything in it, drafts included. **New post** opens the writing page, at the full width of the screen — a thousand-word piece written in a small box gets written badly.

Title — the heading, and the source of the post's own address, fixed on first save the same way the publication's is.

Excerpt — a line or two shown in listings. Worth writing rather than skipping: it is what a reader in the directory uses to decide whether to open the post.

Body — the piece itself, in the full editor.



The writing page.

Save leaves a draft a draft; Save & publish is the separate act.

Drafts and publishing

A new post is always a draft. Saving does not publish, whatever you had in mind when you hit the button. Nothing you write is in front of the public until you say so explicitly.

Save & publish saves what is on screen and then publishes it, in that order — so what readers get is what you were looking at, not the last version you happened to save.

Publish and **Withdraw** are also on the post list, if you would rather work from there.

What withdrawing does, and does not do

Withdraw stops a post being served. It does **not** un-send it: anyone who has already read it still read it, and a link they shared now leads nowhere.

It is a way to take back something published in error. It is not a way to unpublish history.

Publishing again after withdrawing gives the post a **new** date. Keeping the original would drop it back into the middle of the list, where nobody looking at the top would notice it had returned.

Subscribers

The publications list shows how many people subscribe to each one. Subscribing needs an account — reading does not — so a subscriber is somebody you can actually reach.

Nobody can subscribe to a publication that is not public, even if they know its address.

"Subscribers only" posts

You may see posts described as being for subscribers. Nothing on the site can be marked that way today: **every post you publish is free to read in full**, and there is no billing anywhere on the platform.

The groundwork is in place so that if paid publications ever arrive, they arrive without changing what you have already published.

Deleting

Delete on a post removes it outright — it asks once first. Unlike a feed post, which is hidden rather than deleted so a moderation record survives, nothing points at a publication post but its own address. The group owns what it wrote.

Deleting a whole publication

Delete on the publication itself appears only while the publication is **completely empty** — nothing written, nobody subscribed. That is the case it is for: you created one, the title came out wrong, and the address does not move when you rename it.

Once there is anything in it the button is gone, and the reason is what deleting would cost. Removing a publication people have written in and subscribed to destroys the work and breaks every link anybody shared, which is not something to do by clicking twice. Delete the posts first if you genuinely want it gone — or ask a site administrator, who can remove any publication along with everything inside it.

One thing that surprises people: **somebody who subscribed and then unsubscribed still counts**. The rule is "nothing ever happened here", and somebody having read you is something happening. If Delete is missing on a publication that looks empty, that is usually why.

Site Administration

Sitewide settings, the clipart library, and the audit log.

Written for: Platform administrators

Visible to app administrators only.

The dashboard

Administration → **Dashboard** is the overview the rest of this menu drills into: four headline numbers over a grid of charts, with a 7 / 30 / 90-day range picker.

The first three headline cards are links — **People** opens the user list, **In a group** the groups, **Cases** the case list — because the number is usually the start of a question the list answers. *Signed in this week* deliberately is not: there is no page listing recent sign-ins, and a card that sent you somewhere approximate would be worse than one that stays put.

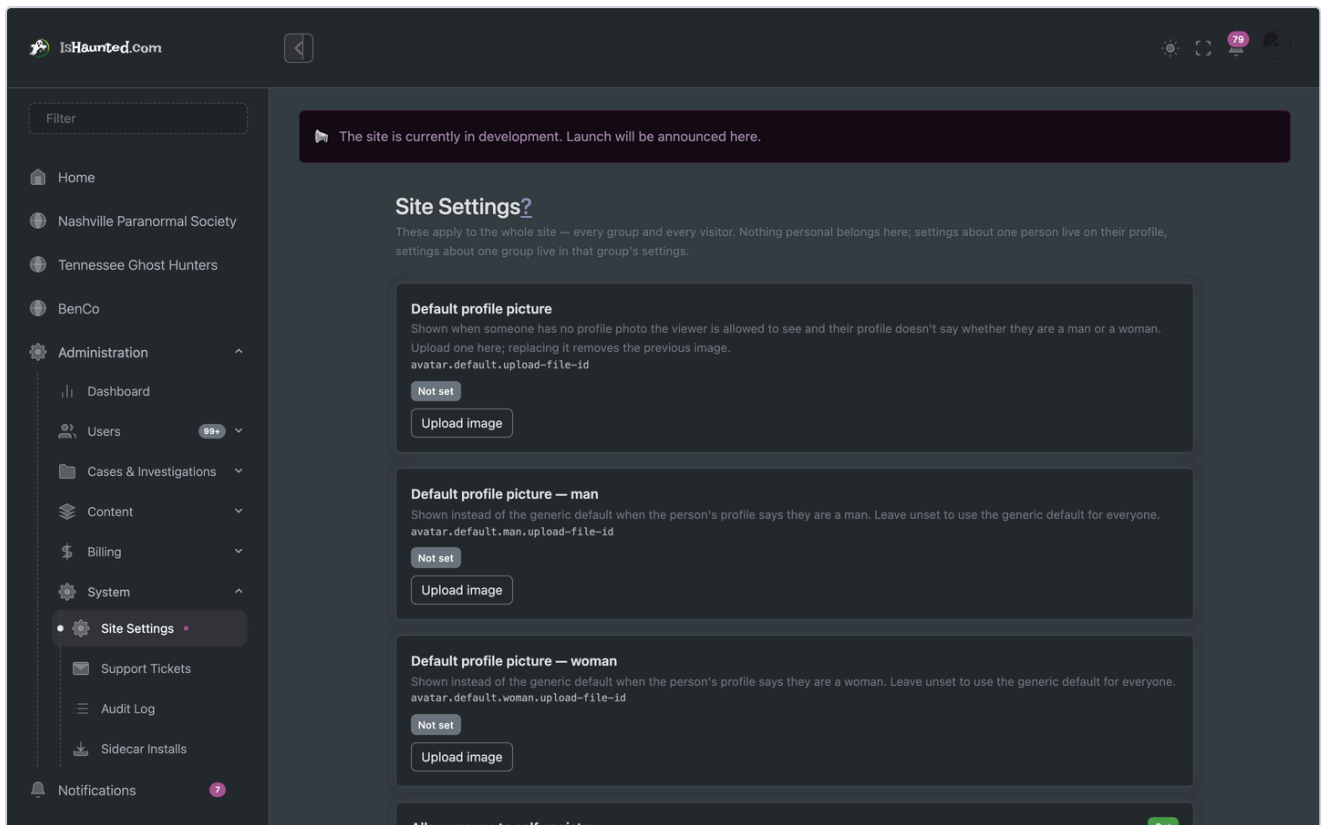
The numbers worth knowing how to read:

- **People** and **In a group** — the second is the funnel. Someone who registers and never joins a group is the person the site has not finished convincing, and the percentage under the number says how large that group is.
- **Signed in this week** counts *people*, not sign-ins; the caption below it gives the raw attempt count. Someone signing in from a laptop and a phone is one person, two sign-ins.
- **Busiest groups** counts cases and investigations started inside the chosen range, so it moves with the range picker. **Largest groups** counts active membership and does not.
- **Where this is happening** has a People / Cases / Investigations toggle, and all three come from addresses already on record: people from their profile addresses, cases from the address the case is about, investigations from the place visited. Expect People to lag the other two — it counts only those who have filled in an address, which most people have not.

What the dashboard cannot tell you

There is no count of visitors who never sign in, and no "new versus returning" split. Nothing on this platform records anonymous visitors — a page view by someone with no account leaves no trace anywhere in the database. Answering that would mean adding visitor tracking, which is a decision about privacy and data retention rather than a chart, and it has not been made. Every number on this page is about accounts and what they did.

Site settings



Site settings apply to every group and every visitor.

Administration → **Site Settings** holds values that apply to the whole site. Nothing personal belongs here — settings about one person live on their profile, settings about one group live in that group's settings.

Adding a new setting is a code change, not a database one: settings are declared in `SiteSettingKeys.Seed`, and the page renders whatever is declared.

Allowing groups to sign themselves up

Allow groups to self-register decides whether an ordinary signed-in visitor may found a group. Left on — the default, and how the site normally runs — anyone can start one from **Organizations** → **Start a Group** and becomes its owner. Switched off, that button disappears, the address behind it explains that new groups are not being accepted and points at the contact form, and the server refuses the request even if somebody has the address saved. You are exempt either way: an administrator can always create a group from this side of the site.

Reach for it when you want to pause growth — a billing change you are part-way through, or a period where each new group needs a conversation first. It has no effect on groups that already exist.

The default profile picture

There are **three default pictures**: a generic one, one for members whose profile says they are a man, and one for members whose profile says they are a woman. Each is an ordinary upload: press **Upload image**, pick a JPEG, PNG, GIF or WebP, and it takes effect immediately — the preview under the row shows what is

live. Uploading a replacement removes the previous image; there is nothing to clean up. The images are stored publicly on purpose, because they render for visitors who are not signed in.

Which one a viewer sees follows the person's own profile — the optional **Sex** field under their name (Male, Female, Unspecified; blank by default), self-declared and never guessed from a name. Blank or Unspecified gets the generic image; Male or Female gets their specific image **when you have uploaded one**, and the generic otherwise. A real photo always outranks every default.

The site-wide announcement

Site-wide announcement is for maintenance windows and known issues. While it has text, an info banner shows it at the top of every page, to everyone — signed in or not — with your line breaks preserved. Clear the box and save to take the banner down; both the posting and the removal reach visitors within about half a minute, without a restart. It is shown exactly as typed: plain text, no formatting or links.

Turning sections of the site on and off

Near the bottom of Site Settings is a row of switches labelled **Feature** — ..., one for each major section: the video editor, equipment, events and calendars, local discovery and maps, group public pages, the media library, group messaging, voting, and the two newer features below.

Where a switch is fully wired, it does exactly what it says. The links disappear from the navigation **and the addresses stop working** — someone who bookmarked the page, or who is handed a link by a colleague, gets the ordinary "page not found" screen rather than a way in. That pairing is the point: hiding a link while the page still answers is not switching a feature off.

Every switch is now fully wired. The last four were finished together: **Local discovery and maps** takes down the "what's near you" panel, the home-page maps and the nearby search; **Group public pages** takes down every /o/{group} page — including for visitors who are not signed in — along with the CMS editor and its tab; **Voting** removes the vote controls from cases, evidence and files and refuses the endpoints behind them; **Events and calendars** removes the Calendar tab, the public What's-on list, event pages, RSVPs, and the reminder emails, together — no more signing up for an event nobody will be reminded of.

What it does **not** do is delete anything. Equipment records, saved videos, messages and votes all stay exactly where they are, and turning the switch back on returns the section with its contents intact. Use it to take a section down while something is being fixed, or to run the site without a feature your groups do not want — not as a way to remove data.

Two things worth knowing:

- **A change takes up to about half a minute** to reach every page, because the site keeps the answer in memory rather than asking the database on every click. Your own browser sees it immediately after you flip the switch.
- **If the site cannot reach its API**, the switches fall back to their normal settings — the established sections on, unreleased features off. A connection problem will never make the site appear to have lost half its features.

A switch with nothing saved against it shows the setting's own default and is marked **(default)** beside On or Off — so the row always describes what the site is doing, not merely what has been typed into it. Until

recently it showed the stored value alone, which meant seven running features reported themselves as switched off simply because nobody had ever touched them.

Two switches start **off**: **Public feed** and **Publications**. Both features are built, but neither is something a site should acquire by accident — each one adds a public surface that members and visitors will start using the moment it appears, so switching it on is a decision somebody makes deliberately rather than a default they inherit.

- **Public feed** — the full arc: anyone reads without an account; members and clients post text, photos and video; posts carry experience-type categories the site learns from; groups decide which case-derived videos link back to them; promoted cards rotate through it, fed nearest-first to viewers who share their location. Turning it on means signing up to moderate it — see [Moderating the Feed](#) — and the **Feed Media** page states plainly whether screening is **automatic** (the on-server model is installed) or **manual-only** (every photo and video waits for a person). Do not launch on manual-only without meaning to. While the feed is off but has content, every SuperAdmin sees a reminder banner naming this switch — the feature cannot be forgotten in the dark by accident.
- **Publications** — long-form writing by groups, readable by visitors with no account. Turning it on adds the **Publications** entry to the menu for everyone, and a **Publications** tab to each group's page for its administrators. Nothing appears in the public directory until a group actually publishes something, so switching it on shows visitors an empty directory at worst, not an unfinished one.

Impersonating a member

Administration → **Users** → the **impersonate button** signs you in as that person, and what you see is exactly what they see: their navigation and their groups under Home, their notification counts on the bell, their pages, their refusals. Your own Administration menu disappears while you look — it is your tool, not part of their experience. A banner at the foot of the sidebar says who you are viewing as, with **Return to SuperAdmin** beside it, and both now survive a page reload — leaving impersonation always takes exactly one click, however you got there.

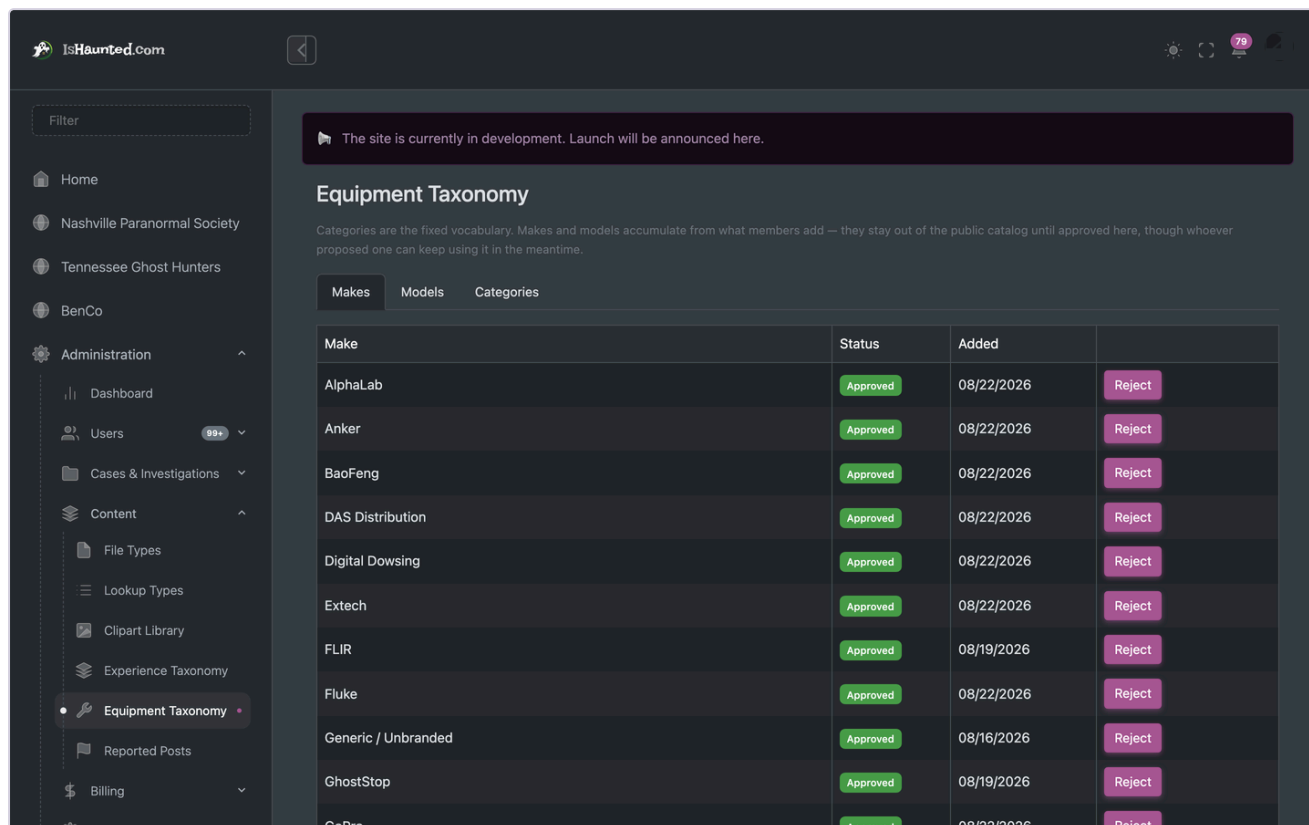
Use it to see a reported problem through the reporter's eyes before assuming the cause. Actions you take while impersonating are real actions on their account.

The clipart library

Administration → **Clipart Library** curates the shared artwork every group can use in the video editor. Upload the file first, then choose it from your media library with the picker and publish. The format is read from the file itself — SVG, PNG, WebP, AVIF, GIF or Lottie — and anything else is refused rather than published as something the editor cannot draw.

Assets are **retired**, never deleted. Projects reference artwork by id, so removing one would break renders that already use it. A retired asset leaves the catalog and stays downloadable.

Keeping the shared vocabulary tidy



Makes and models members have proposed, waiting to be approved, merged or renamed.

Two lists grow by proposal rather than by decree: the **experience taxonomy** and the **equipment catalog**. Groups add what they need on the night, and you confirm or clear up afterwards.

Confirming an entry marks it as reviewed. That matters beyond the badge: reviewed entries are the only ones offered as "did you mean" suggestions to the next person, and they stop being cleared away automatically. Confirming is how a word becomes shared vocabulary rather than one group's note.

Renaming does what it says — until the new name is already taken. Then you are shown the entry it collided with and offered a merge, because renaming onto an existing name means two things become one and somebody's records change meaning. That is too large to happen because a name was typed, so it is always a second, deliberate step.

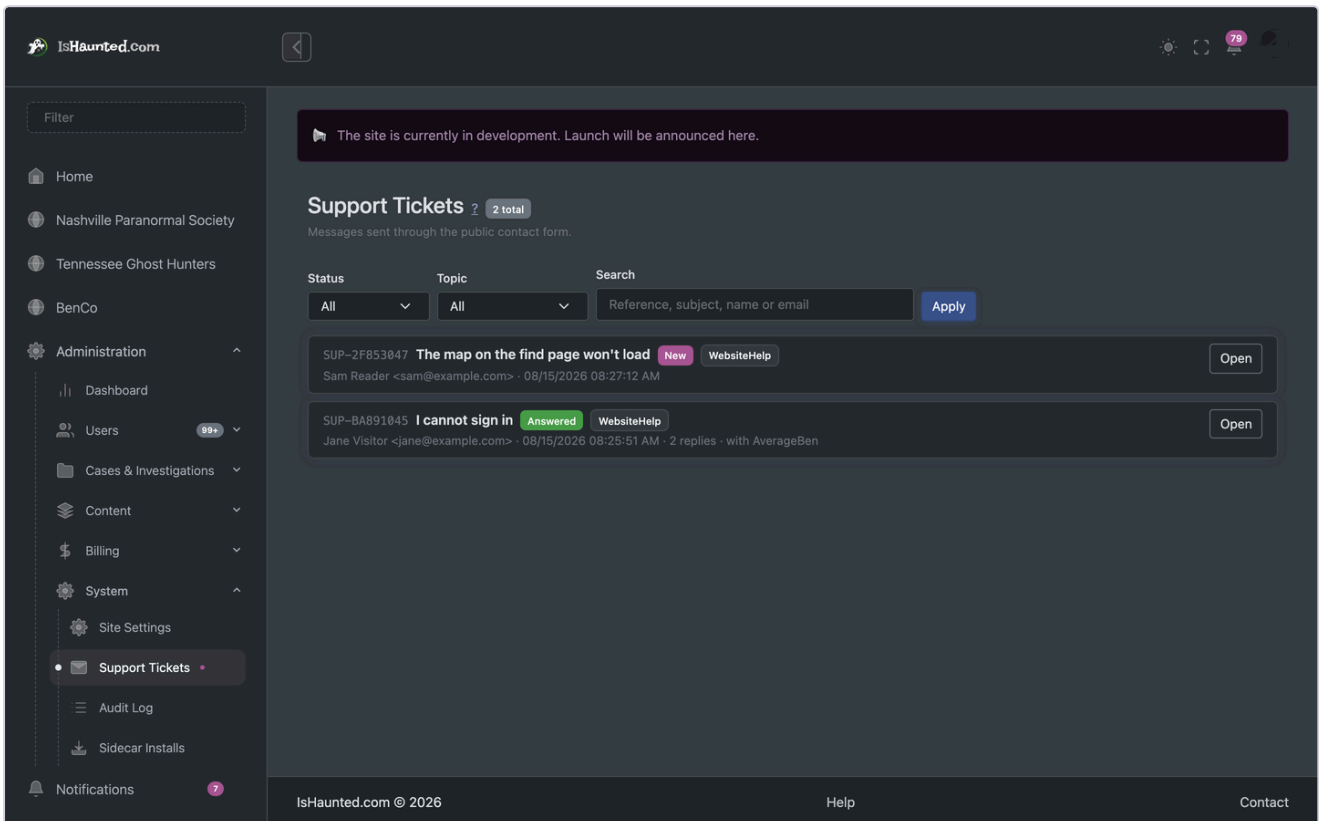
Merging moves everything across and removes the duplicate. It cannot be undone. Two guards:

- You cannot merge a **confirmed** entry into an unconfirmed one. That is almost always the direction reversed, and the result would be a list where the endorsed word vanished and the mistake survived. Merge the other way, or confirm the target first.
- You cannot merge an experience type into a **different category**. Moving a tagging from Visual to Auditory changes what somebody recorded about their own night, which is not a rename.

Deleting is only for an entry nothing uses. If it is tagged on something, you are told how many and refused — **Reject** is the action that removes a type together with its taggings, and it tells you how many it took with it.

Most tidying happens without you. An unconfirmed entry that a group proposed disappears on its own once the last thing using it is gone.

Support tickets



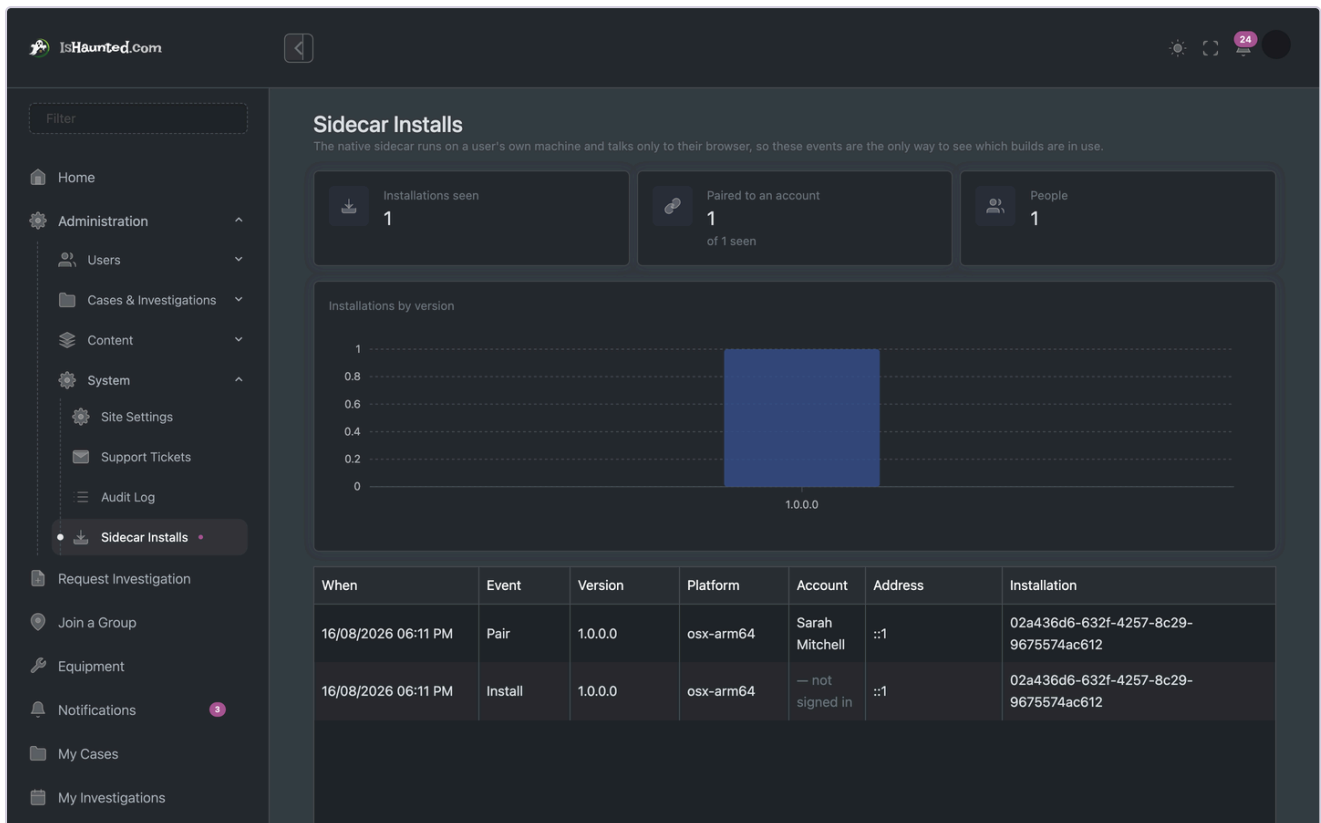
Every message sent through the contact form arrives here.

Administration → **Support Tickets** is the queue for the public contact form. A ticket arrives as **New**; replying to the sender marks it **Answered** and assigns it to you if nobody had it.

The sender reads the thread through a private tracking link, whether or not they have an account — that is how a reply reaches someone who cannot sign in. **Internal notes are never shown there.** They are for staff talking among themselves, and adding one does not mark the ticket answered.

Contact details shown beside the form — postal address, phone, email, when we reply — are site settings, so they are corrected on the Site Settings page rather than in a deploy.

Sidecar installs



Which builds of the native helper are actually in use.

Administration → **Sidecar Installs** shows the optional native helper people install to make the video editor faster. The sidecar runs on someone's own machine and talks only to their browser, so these records are the only way to see which builds are in the wild — useful before changing anything about it, and the answer to "can we stop supporting that version yet?".

Three numbers and a chart:

- **Installations seen** — distinct machines that have reported in.
- **Paired to an account** — how many of those got as far as pairing with a signed-in person. A gap between the two means people are installing it and not finishing setup.
- **People** — distinct accounts, which is lower than installs when someone uses two computers.
- **Installations by version** — the distribution. Watch this after releasing a new build; a version that never grows suggests people are not being told an update exists.

The table below lists the individual events. Nothing here identifies a machine beyond the installation id the sidecar generates for itself.

Audit log

The screenshot shows the IsHaunted.com Audit Log interface. At the top, a message states: "The site is currently in development. Launch will be announced here." Below this, the "Audit Log" section features filters for Entity Type (All types), Action (All actions), User (All users), From (07/24/2026), and To (MM/dd/yyyy). A "Search" button and a "Clear" button are also present. The table below shows 1432 total records. The table has columns for Time, Entity, Action, Entity ID, User, and Source. The table displays several "Update" actions on "SiteSetting" entities by "AverageBen" via "WebApi".

Time	Entity	Action	Entity ID	User	Source
08/23/2026 03:05:47 PM	SiteSetting	Update	b8594e43...	AverageBen	WebApi
08/23/2026 03:05:01 PM	SiteSetting	Update	b8594e43...	AverageBen	WebApi
08/23/2026 03:04:17 PM	SiteSetting	Update	34f2e0e3...	AverageBen	WebApi
08/23/2026 03:03:35 PM	SiteSetting	Update	34f2e0e3...	AverageBen	WebApi
08/23/2026 03:01:11 PM	SiteSetting	Update	a77fe1a3...	AverageBen	WebApi
08/23/2026 03:01:11 PM	SiteSetting	Update	a77fe1a3...	AverageBen	WebApi
08/23/2026 03:01:11 PM	SiteSetting	Update	a77fe1a3...	AverageBen	WebApi
08/23/2026 03:01:06 PM	SiteSetting	Update	b524d904...	AverageBen	WebApi
08/23/2026 03:01:02 PM	SiteSetting	Update	b524d904...	AverageBen	WebApi

The audit log records who changed what, and when. Filter it by entity, action, person or date.

Administration → **Audit Log** records every mutation with who made it. It is filtered and paged on the server, so date and user filters apply to the whole history rather than the page on screen.

Billing

Role areas on a price band

Each band carries a **Role areas** checklist — which parts of the site a group on that band may build custom role permissions for: Cases, Equipment, Public pages, and so on. Every band starts with everything checked, which changes nothing; unchecking an area is how bands become different products. Changes save as you click and apply to every group on the band.

The checklist is fully enforced. For a group whose band excludes an area: the role editor grays that area's section with a note naming the plan, the server refuses changes to it while carrying the stored grants forward untouched, and at runtime those grants simply stop answering — members lose the tabs the grants opened, owners and group administrators notice nothing. Nothing is ever deleted; a paused grant resumes exactly as configured the moment the area returns. The public Pricing page lists each band's included areas whenever any band excludes something.

Unchecking saves per click, so the group-facing notices are **netted**: a removal is queued (free-band groups hear after a short grace, paid groups ahead of their renewal), and re-checking the area before delivery cancels the pending notice — an accidental toggle reaches the groups as silence, not as two contradictory messages. Newly included areas are announced right away.

Capabilities on a price band

Beside the role areas sits a **Capabilities** checklist — plain may-or-may-not switches. **Case transfers**: a band without it can neither send a case to another group nor accept one transferred in, and both ends are enforced — a case can't be handed TO a group whose band lacks it either; declining never requires the capability. **Audio/video location stripping**: whether the group's media privacy setting may remove location data from audio and video files (photos are always cleaned; every file's metadata is always extracted and kept regardless). **Private-residence cases**: whether the group may take on client and residence work at all — accepting a client request, placing an investigation at a residence, receiving a private case, and publishing one are each checked; work a group already holds keeps working, and a client moving their own case is only ever limited by the destination's band. Existing cases are unaffected by unchecking; changes save per click and notify the affected groups through the same netted notices as the role areas, and the public Pricing page says plainly what a band leaves out.

Administration → **Billing** holds three screens.

Price Bands is the price list the public Pricing page renders — member ranges, a price per billing cadence, and the caps each band includes. Every save is validated as a whole list: the bands must cover every possible member count with no gaps or overlaps, and a save that would leave somebody unpriced is refused with the reason. Bands are retired, never deleted, because a band that has priced a period is part of the billing record. When an edit would affect groups already on the band, the save pauses and shows the blast radius first: improvements are announced to those groups immediately, reductions are queued and delivered up to two weeks before each group's own renewal — paid groups keep the terms they bought until then.

Coupons manages discount campaigns. A *shared* campaign is one code everybody types; a *generated* campaign is a batch of single-use codes you can print or mail, each withdrawable on its own, and addressable to a specific account. A campaign can be limited by date window, total redemptions (the budget), billing cadence, and occasion — first subscriptions only, or renewals only. A misconfigured campaign (one that takes nothing off, or whose window closes before it opens) wears a red **Broken** badge in the list rather than failing silently for whoever types it.

Every code also doubles as a **referral link** — the codes panel's *Copy link* button gives a `/pricing?code=...` URL to hand to whoever is promoting or selling access. Visitors land with the code attached and see it priced against their group before anything is confirmed; the code's redemption count is the referrer's scorecard.

Subscriptions is where every group's standing lives — including groups never set up, which is the first thing to look for. Until a payment provider is wired in, this screen *is* the payment record: when a group pays, set their band, cadence and period here. The member count and price are frozen from the moment you save, and the group keeps those terms for the whole period whatever happens to the price list. The Members column shows the current count beside the frozen one — the gap is what the group will be rebanded on at renewal.

Merging two groups

Administration → **Groups** → **Merge Groups** takes two organizations and ends with one. Choose the **base** — the group that survives, keeping its URL and settings — and the group to merge into it, then read the

preview before anything happens: it lists exactly what will move and every collision, and computing it changes nothing.

What the merge does, in one pass that either completes or leaves both groups untouched:

- **Everything the merged group owns moves to the base** — members, cases, investigations, files, equipment, pages, calendar, messages. The list in the preview is generated from the database schema itself, so it is complete by construction.
- **A person in both groups** keeps one membership, at the **higher** of their two roles.
- **Case numbers collide by design** — both groups started at #1 — so colliding merged cases are renumbered into the base's sequence; page addresses that collide get a suffix.
- **The merged group's URL becomes a permanent alias** of the base, so old links keep working and the name can never be captured by a newly created group.
- **The merged group's subscription is dropped** — the base's plan governs the combined group. If money is owed back, record it as a ledger adjustment.
- **Everyone is told:** former members get a message that their group is now part of the base, and clients with open cases are told the group handling their case has a new name.

The name after the merge is yours to choose — either group's name or a new one. Confirmation requires typing the merged group's name, because there is no undo.

The money trail

Three more screens under **Administration** → **Billing** carry the actual money.

Ledger is the record: every charge, payment, adjustment and referral payout, newest first. It is append-only on purpose — there is no edit and no delete, here or in the API underneath. A wrong entry is answered by recording an **adjustment** that names the mistake, exactly the way a paper ledger works, so "who changed this number?" always has the same answer: nobody. Recording a **charge** computes tax from the group's state and freezes both the rate and the dollars on the row; recording a **payment** assigns the next receipt number, which the group can download — and re-download, forever — from their own billing history on the Pricing page. A payment carries no tax of its own: its tax was on the charge it settles, and counting it twice would be a lie in both directions.

Tax Rates holds the current rate per state, matched against the group's address. A state with no row is taxed at **zero** — the honest default, since many states do not tax this service, and a visible zero on a bill gets questioned while a silently guessed rate does not. Editing a rate never rewrites history: every document froze the rate it used.

Overflow seats

A band covers a member count. When a group grows past it, the group's own plan does not change: each person who joins beyond the band is billed **individually**, at the per-extra-member price you set on that band's price row. The group keeps one contract at one renewal date; the extra people each hold a seat.

Set it up by putting a **per-extra-member price** on a band's price row in **Price Bands**. That also changes what the price list will accept: a top band is normally required to be unbounded, because a group must never outgrow the list — a band that prices extra members is allowed to be bounded, since growth past it is priced per seat rather than by a bigger band.

Member Seats is the worklist. A new member who takes a group past its band gets a seat marked **Awaiting payment**, and is told the price in their acceptance message. Joining is never blocked by a seat: they are a member from the moment they are accepted, and the seat is the billing record. When they pay, record the payment on the Ledger and set the seat **Active** with its period. The two are separate on purpose — the money and the entitlement can never disagree by being the same write.

Referrals and what they earn

Referrals shows every referrer's standing. A referrer is anyone a coupon campaign is attributed to — set on the campaign, by their account email — and every redemption of their codes counts as their referral, with the money frozen at redemption time. The screen shows what their codes brought in, the discount given, what they are **owed**, what has been paid, and the outstanding **balance**. Owed is a **percent of what redeemers actually paid**, set per campaign on the campaign itself — deals differ per referrer, so the percent does too. A campaign with no percent is not counted, and the owed figure wears a **partial** badge when that happens, so a low number never reads as a settled one. Recording a payout pre-fills the outstanding balance and lands on the ledger like everything else.

Moderating the Feed

The reported-posts queue, and what hiding a post does.

Written for: Platform administrators

Visible to app administrators only.

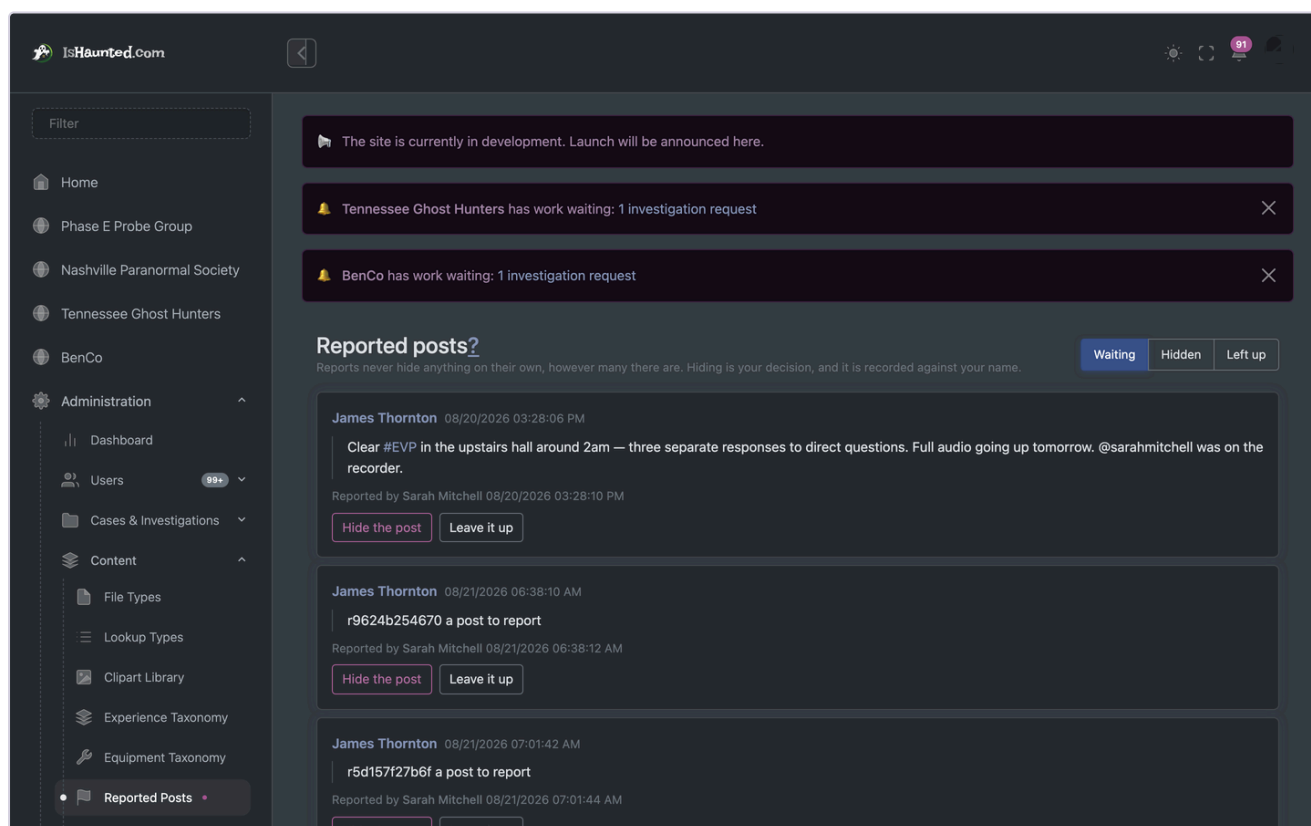
Administration → **Content** → **Reported Posts** is the queue of posts somebody has objected to.

What a report is, and is not

A report is one person saying a post should not be here. **It hides nothing.** Neither does five reports, or fifty — there is no threshold, deliberately. An automatic one would remove whatever is least popular rather than whatever breaks the rules, and the people worst served by that are the ones with unusual things to say, which is most of this site's subject matter.

Hiding is your decision, and your name is recorded against it.

Working the queue



Each row shows the post as its readers saw it, who objected, and why.

Reports are listed **oldest first**. A queue worked newest-first leaves the oldest complaint unanswered for ever, and that is the one somebody is waiting on.

Each row shows the post as its readers saw it, who reported it and why, and — where more than one person reported the same post — how many. Treat that number as context, not as a verdict.

BUTTON	WHAT HAPPENS
Hide the post	It disappears from every feed, thread, tag page and profile.
Leave it up	Nothing changes for readers. The report is marked as looked at.

Both resolve **every** waiting report against that post together. Five people reporting one post is one decision, and leaving the rest waiting would put it back in front of a colleague with no sign it had already been dealt with.

Photos and videos waiting for a look

Administration → **Content** → **Feed Media** is the other queue: photos and videos that have not been cleared for the feed. Nothing anybody uploads is shown to readers until it has been screened — automatically where the site's screening model is installed, and by a person here otherwise. The page says plainly which of those is the case.

A file the automatic screener held carries its reason ("blocked", or "borderline, needs a person") with a confidence score. **Approve** publishes it; **Hold** keeps it unpublished with your note. Neither deletes anything, and the author is only ever told their upload is being checked — never which check it tripped, because that would be a manual for dressing up the next one.

The category question

Beside the safety question sits a different one: **is this what it says it is?** A post's category label (Apparition, Voices / Whispering...) is the author's claim, shown with the site's own match score. **Is what it says** and **Category is wrong** each record your judgment — that is all they do. A wrong category never hides a post; it nudges the author to fix the label and gently lowers the post's ranking.

Those judgments are worth the click even when nothing is wrong: every one becomes a labelled example the site's classifier learns from, and the classifier is only ever as good as the record of what people who looked actually decided.

Hidden, not deleted

A hidden post is still there. Nothing is destroyed: its replies, its reports and the record of who decided what all survive, so the next person asking "what happened here" can find out. Deleting it would take all of that with it.

Put it back on a hidden post undoes the hiding. It is the same act read the other way round.

What the author is told

Nothing, at present. There is no notification, and the post simply stops appearing. If telling people is something this site should do, it is a decision to make deliberately rather than a feature to add quietly —

the wording matters more than the mechanism.

When the feed is switched off

This page still works. Switching the feed off does not un-report anything, and a site that turns it off may still have complaints nobody got to. Every other feed page disappears with the feature; this one does not, so those reports are never stranded.